

COLL 110- INTRODUCTION TO PERSONAL LEADERSHIP





COLL 110

INTRODUCTION TO PERSONAL LEADERSHIP

YOUR LEADERSHIP JOURNEY
— *Starts Here* —

JOHNSON COUNTY COMMUNITY COLLEGE

InfoPage

This text is disseminated via the Open Education Resource (OER) LibreTexts Project (<https://LibreTexts.org>) and like the thousands of other texts available within this powerful platform, it is freely available for reading, printing, and "consuming."

The LibreTexts mission is to bring together students, faculty, and scholars in a collaborative effort to provide an accessible, and comprehensive platform that empowers our community to develop, curate, adapt, and adopt openly licensed resources and technologies; through these efforts we can reduce the financial burden born from traditional educational resource costs, ensuring education is more accessible for students and communities worldwide.

Most, but not all, pages in the library have licenses that may allow individuals to make changes, save, and print this book. Carefully consult the applicable license(s) before pursuing such effects. Instructors can adopt existing LibreTexts texts or Remix them to quickly build course-specific resources to meet the needs of their students. Unlike traditional textbooks, LibreTexts' web based origins allow powerful integration of advanced features and new technologies to support learning.



LibreTexts is the adaptable, user-friendly non-profit open education resource platform that educators trust for creating, customizing, and sharing accessible, interactive textbooks, adaptive homework, and ancillary materials. We collaborate with individuals and organizations to champion open education initiatives, support institutional publishing programs, drive curriculum development projects, and more.

The LibreTexts libraries are Powered by [NICE CXone Expert](#) and was supported by the Department of Education Open Textbook Pilot Project, the California Education Learning Lab, the UC Davis Office of the Provost, the UC Davis Library, the California State University Affordable Learning Solutions Program, and Merlot. This material is based upon work supported by the National Science Foundation under Grant No. 1246120, 1525057, and 1413739.

Any opinions, findings, and conclusions or recommendations expressed in this material are those of the author(s) and do not necessarily reflect the views of the National Science Foundation nor the US Department of Education.

Have questions or comments? For information about adoptions or adaptations contact info@LibreTexts.org or visit our main website at <https://LibreTexts.org>.

The LibreTexts name, logo, and book covers are trademarked by LibreTexts, Inc. (a 501(c)(3) not-for-profit organization) and protected against unauthorized use.

This text was compiled on 08/14/2026

- [InfoPage](#) by [Delmar Larsen](#) is licensed [Public Domain](#).

TABLE OF CONTENTS

Licensing

1: Foundations of Personal Leadership for Community College Students

- 1.1: Leadership Begins with YOU
- 1.2: The Reality of Leadership
- 1.3: Goal Setting & Decision-Making
- 1.4: Relating with Others

2: How I See Myself

3: Defining My Personal Values

4. Defining My Vision, Setting Personal Goals, and Making Decisions

5: Nonverbal Communication and Active Listening in Small Groups

6: Developing Trust and Being Trustworthy

7: Perceptions are Only From My Point of View

- 7.1: Diversity and Inclusion

8: Diversity and Inclusion

9: Meeting the Challenge of Effective Groups and Teams Membership

10: Engaging with Empathy

Index

Glossary

Detailed Licensing

Licensing

A detailed breakdown of this resource's licensing can be found in [Back Matter/Detailed Licensing](#).

1: Foundations of Personal Leadership for Community College Students

Chapter 1: Foundations of Personal Leadership for Community College Students

Chapter Outline

- **1.1 Mindset and the College Landscape:** Defining personal leadership within local, academic, and professional environments.
- **2.2 Core Principles and Self-Assessment:** Mapping cultural wealth and identifying underlying values to guide decision-making.
- **3.3 Goal Setting and Structured Decisions:** Building SMART academic goals and applying concrete decision-making models.
- **4.4 Relational Agility and Resilience:** Developing emotional intelligence and growth mindsets to handle institutional challenges.

Section 1.1: Mindset and the College Landscape

Personal leadership is the foundational baseline for all broader leadership. At the community college level, leadership begins with managing competing schedules. Your unique personal experiences directly shape your personal leadership style.

Contextual Factors

- **Academic Demands:** Balancing class instruction times, homework loads, and study schedules.
- **Professional Duties:** Coordinating partial or full-time employment commitments outside school hours.
- **Civic Obligations:** Managing immediate family responsibilities and local neighborhood roles.

Section 1.2: Core Principles and Self-Assessment

To navigate external environments, you must define your internal operating values. Community college students bring immense cultural wealth to their campus environments. Identifying these values clarifies your ultimate leadership vision.

Lived Experience Matrix

Dimension	Core Curricular Definition	Community College Application	Reflection Prompt
Guiding Values	Core internal drivers shaping personal ethics	Prioritizing local economic stability and familial duty	<i>Which three values guide your decisions?</i>
Navigational Capital	Forged operational agility across complex spaces	Managing financial aid systems while commuting across town	<i>How does system navigation build grit?</i>
Aspirational Capital	Maintaining long-term vision amidst local barriers	Committing to a degree track despite career disruptions	<i>What keeps you focused on your career goals?</i>

Research Lens: Building Your HERO

What helps someone lead themselves well when life does not go exactly as planned?

Researchers in the field of positive organizational behavior have studied a group of psychological resources called **Psychological Capital**, or **PsyCap**. Rather than focusing only on what a person knows or who they know, Psychological Capital considers internal resources that can help people pursue goals, respond to challenges, and continue moving forward.

One way to remember its four components is **HERO**:

	Psychological Resource	What It Means for Personal Leadership
H	Hope	Believing that a goal is possible and being able to identify more than one pathway for reaching it.
E	Efficacy	Having confidence in your ability to take on a particular challenge and put forth the effort needed to succeed.

	Psychological Resource	What It Means for Personal Leadership
R	Resilience	Responding to setbacks, adapting, and continuing forward when circumstances change.
O	Optimism	Expecting that positive outcomes are possible while recognizing that your choices and actions matter.

Why Does HERO Matter?

One of the most useful ideas behind Psychological Capital is that these resources are **not simply fixed personality traits**. Researchers describe them as *state-like*: they can change and can be strengthened.

That distinction matters for personal leadership.

You do not have to arrive at college already feeling confident about everything. You do not need a perfect plan for every obstacle. Resilience does not mean that setbacks will not affect you, and optimism does not mean pretending that difficult circumstances do not exist.

Personal leadership involves learning how to work with the resources you have—and intentionally develop the ones you need.

Psychological Capital was originally studied in workplace and organizational settings. Research by Fred Luthans and colleagues found that hope, efficacy, resilience, and optimism could be considered together as a broader psychological resource related to performance and satisfaction. Their work provides one useful lens for thinking about how people approach goals and challenges.

Keep HERO in Mind as You Read

As you move through this chapter, notice how the four HERO resources connect to different parts of personal leadership:

- **When you examine your mindset and current circumstances:** What can you influence, and where might you need a different approach?
- **When you identify your strengths and values:** What experiences have already prepared you to handle challenges?
- **When you set goals and make decisions:** What pathways could move you toward the outcome you want?
- **When you encounter feedback, obstacles, or setbacks:** How can you adapt without losing sight of your larger purpose?

You do not need to be equally strong in all four areas. The goal is to begin noticing the psychological resources you already use and the ones you may want to strengthen.

Personal leadership question: *When things become difficult, what helps you keep moving—and what would you like to get better at?*

Research Source

Luthans, F., Avolio, B. J., Avey, J. B., & Norman, S. M. (2007). Positive psychological capital: Measurement and relationship with performance and satisfaction. *Personnel Psychology*, 60(3), 541–572. doi:10.1111/j.1744-6570.2007.00083.x

Section 2.3: Goal Setting and Structured Decisions

Vague goals dilute leadership potential. You must translate your leadership vision into measurable action steps. Furthermore, you will face hard choices that require logical framework analysis rather than raw emotional reactions.

The Strategic Action Blueprint

1. **Targeting SMART Criteria:** Write short-term and long-term academic benchmarks.
2. **Mapping Timelines:** Build out weekly milestone tracking metrics for major projects.
3. **Applying Choices:** Use analytical step models to choose classes and balance workloads.
4. **Evaluating Outcomes:** Review results periodically to adjust your operational schedules. []

Section 2.4: Relational Agility and Resilience

Leadership requires healthy human connection. You must communicate clearly across diverse academic and professional networks. Developing a strong growth mindset allows you to treat criticism as functional data for personal optimization.

THE RELATIONAL RESILIENCE LOOP		
Active Listening (Receive Feedback)	Constructive Data (Process Gaps)	Growth Action (Build Grit)

Core Interpersonal Competencies

- **Emotional Intelligence:** Managing internal stressors while recognizing the perspectives of classmates.
- **Active Listening:** Clearing mental distractions to focus completely on peer communication.
- **Resilience Frameworks:** Rebounding quickly when facing systemic institutional barriers or bad grades.

Chapter Review & Learning Portfolio Activities

- **Leadership Synthesis:** Draft a personal statement aligning your values with a target industry sector.
- **Decision Analysis:** Outline a recent complex decision using a structured choice model.
- **Mindset Assessment:** Identify one personal blind spot where you historically reject negative feedback.

This page titled [1: Foundations of Personal Leadership for Community College Students](#) is shared under a [CC BY](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by .

1.1: Leadership Begins with YOU

Leadership Begins with You

When you hear the word *leader*, what comes to mind? You might picture a CEO leading a company, a coach motivating a team, or an elected official making important decisions. While these are all examples of leadership, they overlook an important truth: **every great leader first learns to lead themselves.**

Personal leadership is the ability to intentionally guide your own thoughts, behaviors, decisions, and actions toward meaningful goals. It is the foundation upon which all other leadership is built. Before you can successfully lead a team, manage a project, or influence an organization, you must first develop the habits and discipline to lead yourself.

Leadership scholar Charles C. Manz, widely recognized as the founder of self-leadership theory, explains:

"Self-leadership is a comprehensive self-influence perspective that concerns leading oneself toward the performance of naturally motivating tasks as well as managing oneself to do work that must be done but is not naturally motivating."
— Charles C. Manz

This definition reminds us that personal leadership involves much more than simply staying motivated. It means making intentional choices every day—even when those choices are difficult. Sometimes personal leadership means studying for tomorrow's exam instead of scrolling through social media. Other times it means showing up for work on time after a late night, asking for help when you're struggling, or following through on a commitment when no one is checking on you.

Unlike traditional leadership, which focuses on influencing others, **personal leadership begins with influencing yourself.** It is demonstrated through everyday actions such as managing your time, regulating your emotions, keeping commitments, making ethical decisions, and remaining focused on long-term goals despite short-term distractions.

For community college students, personal leadership is especially important because success rarely depends on just one responsibility. Many students are balancing coursework with jobs, family obligations, financial responsibilities, and involvement in their communities. Each day requires dozens of decisions about how to use limited time and energy. These daily choices are acts of leadership.

The encouraging news is that personal leadership is not a personality trait that some people are born with and others lack. Like any other skill, it can be learned, practiced, and strengthened over time. Every assignment completed, every challenge overcome, and every thoughtful decision contributes to your development as a leader.

As you progress through this course, you will discover that leadership does not begin when you receive a title or position. **It begins the moment you take responsibility for your own growth, choices, and actions.**

Leadership Insight

Leadership begins with leading yourself. Every decision you make today shapes the leader you will become tomorrow.

Why This Matters

Research consistently shows that students who develop strong self-leadership skills are more likely to persist through challenges, manage competing responsibilities effectively, and achieve both academic and career success. In the chapters ahead, you'll explore practical tools for strengthening your self-awareness, clarifying your values, setting meaningful goals, and developing the habits that prepare you to lead both yourself and others.

This page titled [1.1: Leadership Begins with YOU](#) is shared under a [CC BY](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by .

1.2: The Reality of Leadership

The Reality of Community College Leadership

Every leader operates within a unique set of circumstances. These circumstances, known as **contextual factors**, influence the decisions we make, the challenges we face, and the leadership skills we develop.

For community college students, leadership often begins not in a boardroom or student government meeting, but in the everyday challenge of balancing multiple responsibilities. Unlike the traditional image of a full-time college student whose primary job is attending class, many community college students are simultaneously employees, parents, caregivers, military members, volunteers, or active participants in their communities. Each role competes for the same limited resource: time.

Researchers who study student success describe community college students as **place-bound**, meaning they are deeply connected to their families, workplaces, and local communities while pursuing higher education. These responsibilities create unique opportunities to develop leadership skills long before students hold formal leadership positions.

Rather than viewing these competing responsibilities as obstacles, consider them your first leadership laboratory. Every day you make decisions about where to invest your attention, how to prioritize competing demands, and how to remain committed to long-term goals despite immediate pressures. These are the same decision-making skills effective leaders use throughout their careers.

Academic Demands

College requires far more than attending class. Success depends on planning ahead, meeting deadlines, preparing for exams, collaborating with classmates, and asking for help when needed. Unlike high school, instructors often expect students to manage their own learning with much greater independence.

Educational research consistently finds that **time management, self-regulation, and academic planning are among the strongest predictors of student success**—often more influential than prior academic achievement. Students who intentionally schedule study time, monitor their progress, and adjust their learning strategies are more likely to persist and graduate.

Every decision to prepare for class, complete an assignment early, or seek tutoring demonstrates personal leadership.

Leadership Skills Developed

- Planning and organization
 - Self-discipline
 - Accountability
 - Persistence
 - Problem solving
-

Professional Responsibilities

Nearly two-thirds of community college students work while enrolled in college, and many work twenty or more hours each week. Balancing employment with academic responsibilities requires careful planning, flexibility, and resilience.

Work experiences also provide valuable opportunities to practice leadership. Showing up on time, communicating professionally, solving customer problems, collaborating with coworkers, and accepting constructive feedback are all behaviors associated with effective leadership.

Students often underestimate how much their workplace prepares them for future leadership roles. Whether you supervise others or not, your daily work experiences strengthen skills that employers consistently identify as essential, including reliability, communication, adaptability, and teamwork.

Leadership Skills Developed

- Responsibility
 - Professional communication
 - Teamwork
 - Adaptability
 - Reliability
-

Family and Community Responsibilities

Many community college students carry significant responsibilities beyond school and work. Some care for children or aging parents. Others support siblings, volunteer in their communities, participate in faith organizations, coach youth sports, or serve in civic organizations.

These responsibilities require leadership that is often unseen but deeply meaningful.

Supporting family members teaches empathy and patience. Volunteering develops service and collaboration. Caring for others strengthens organization, emotional intelligence, and resilience. These experiences shape the kind of leader you become because they influence how you solve problems, communicate with others, and respond to challenges.

Leadership is not limited to formal positions or titles. It is demonstrated whenever you positively influence the people around you through responsibility, integrity, and service.

Leadership Skills Developed

- Empathy
 - Emotional intelligence
 - Service
 - Collaboration
 - Resilience
-

Every Day Is Leadership Practice

Managing multiple responsibilities can feel overwhelming, but it also provides daily opportunities to strengthen your personal leadership.

Leadership is not about finding more hours in the day—it is about making intentional choices with the hours you already have.

Every decision to attend class instead of sleeping in, prepare for an exam after work, help a family member while staying committed to your goals, or ask for support when needed reflects your ability to lead yourself.

The habits you build while balancing school, work, and life today are the same habits that will prepare you to lead teams, organizations, and communities tomorrow.

Research Spotlight

Studies by the **Community College Research Center (CCRC)** at Columbia University and the **Center for Community College Student Engagement (CCCSE)** consistently show that community college students are more likely than students at four-year residential institutions to balance multiple roles, including employment and family caregiving. These competing responsibilities increase the importance of effective time management, self-regulation, and help-seeking behaviors for academic persistence and completion. Likewise, educational psychologist **Barry Zimmerman's** research on self-regulated learning demonstrates that successful students actively plan, monitor, and evaluate their learning rather than relying solely on ability or motivation. Together, these findings reinforce a central theme of this course: **personal leadership is expressed through the everyday choices students make to manage competing priorities and remain committed to their goals.**

This page titled [1.2: The Reality of Leadership](#) is shared under a [CC BY](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by .

1.3: Goal Setting & Decision-Making

Goal Setting and Structured Decision-Making

Imagine setting out on a road trip without a destination or a map. You might stay busy driving, but you're unlikely to arrive where you want to be. Personal leadership works much the same way. Without clear goals and thoughtful decision-making, it is easy to become overwhelmed by daily responsibilities and lose sight of what matters most.

Effective leaders do more than dream about success—they create a plan to achieve it. They establish meaningful goals, break large tasks into manageable steps, monitor their progress, and adjust when circumstances change. These habits transform good intentions into measurable results.

Leadership also requires making decisions. Every semester, you'll make choices that affect your academic success and personal well-being. Which classes should you take? How many credit hours can you realistically manage? Should you accept additional work hours, or devote more time to studying? These decisions are rarely simple, and they often involve competing priorities.

Research in cognitive psychology suggests that while emotions provide valuable information, effective decisions are strongest when they combine thoughtful analysis with personal values. Rather than reacting impulsively, successful leaders pause, gather information, consider alternatives, and evaluate the likely consequences of each option before making a decision.

Fortunately, goal setting and decision-making are skills that improve with practice. By following a structured process, you can make choices with greater confidence while remaining flexible enough to adapt when life changes.

The Strategic Action Blueprint

1. Set SMART Goals

Effective goals provide direction and motivation. Instead of saying, *"I want to do better in school,"* create goals that are:

- **Specific** – Clearly define what you want to accomplish.
- **Measurable** – Identify how you will measure success.
- **Achievable** – Set goals that challenge you while remaining realistic.
- **Relevant** – Connect your goals to your personal values and long-term aspirations.
- **Time-Bound** – Establish a deadline for completion.

Example

✗ *I want better grades.*

✓ *I will earn at least a B in College Algebra by studying four evenings each week and attending tutoring before every exam.*

2. Map Your Timeline

Large goals become manageable when they are divided into smaller milestones.

Instead of focusing only on the final deadline, identify the checkpoints that will keep you moving forward.

For example, if you have a research paper due in six weeks, your timeline might include:

- Week 1: Choose a topic.
- Week 2: Locate and evaluate sources.
- Week 3: Create an outline.
- Week 4: Write the first draft.
- Week 5: Revise and edit.
- Week 6: Submit the final paper.

Breaking large projects into smaller tasks reduces procrastination and helps you maintain steady progress.

3. Make Decisions Using a Structured Process

Strong leaders avoid making important decisions based solely on emotion or convenience. Instead, they use a systematic approach.

A simple four-step model can help:

1. Define the decision.
2. Identify possible options.
3. Consider the benefits and consequences of each option.
4. Choose the option that best supports your goals and values.

This process can be used for academic, career, financial, and personal decisions throughout college.

4. Reflect and Adjust

Leadership is an ongoing process of learning and improvement.

After completing a project or reaching a milestone, ask yourself:

- What worked well?
- What challenges did I encounter?
- What would I do differently next time?
- What adjustments should I make moving forward?

Reflection allows you to learn from experience rather than simply repeating the same habits.

Leadership in Action

A goal without a plan is only a wish. Effective leaders transform goals into daily actions by creating clear plans, making thoughtful decisions, and adjusting as they learn.

Research Spotlight

Research consistently supports the value of structured goal setting and self-monitoring. In a landmark study, psychologists **Edwin Locke** and **Gary Latham** found that people who set **specific, challenging goals** consistently outperform those with vague intentions such as "do your best." Clear goals improve motivation, focus attention on priorities, and increase persistence when obstacles arise.

Educational research reaches similar conclusions. Psychologist **Barry Zimmerman**, a leading scholar on self-regulated learning, found that successful college students actively **plan, monitor, and evaluate** their progress. Rather than relying on motivation alone, they break large tasks into manageable steps, track their performance, and adjust their strategies when needed.

These findings highlight an important principle of personal leadership: **success is rarely the result of willpower alone. It is built through intentional planning, informed decision-making, and consistent reflection on your progress.**

This page titled [1.3: Goal Setting & Decision-Making](#) is shared under a [CC BY](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by .

1.4: Relating with Others

Relational Agility and Resilience

Personal leadership is not a solitary journey. Even the most independent students rely on instructors, classmates, advisors, supervisors, family members, and mentors throughout their college experience. Leadership grows through relationships, and those relationships depend on effective communication, empathy, and the ability to learn from feedback.

Successful leaders understand that every interaction is an opportunity to build trust. They communicate clearly, listen with curiosity, and seek to understand perspectives that differ from their own. In today's classrooms and workplaces, people collaborate across cultures, generations, experiences, and viewpoints. The ability to work effectively with diverse individuals is one of the most valuable leadership skills you can develop.

Equally important is resilience—the ability to recover from setbacks, adapt to challenges, and continue moving forward. Every student experiences disappointment at some point. Perhaps you earn a lower grade than expected, struggle with a difficult course, receive constructive criticism from an instructor, or find that balancing school, work, and family is more demanding than anticipated.

Personal leaders do not view these moments as evidence that they cannot succeed. Instead, they treat challenges as opportunities to learn, adjust, and grow.

Psychologist Carol Dweck describes this perspective as a **growth mindset**—the belief that abilities can be developed through effort, effective strategies, and learning from experience. Students with a growth mindset are more likely to persist through challenges because they see setbacks as temporary rather than permanent.

Resilience is not about avoiding failure. It is about responding to failure in ways that make you stronger, wiser, and better prepared for future success.

The Relational Resilience Loop

Effective leaders strengthen relationships and resilience through a continuous cycle of learning.

Step	Leadership Practice	Purpose
Active Listening	Listen carefully before responding. Ask questions to understand rather than simply preparing your reply.	Build trust and strengthen relationships.
Constructive Feedback	View feedback as information that identifies opportunities for growth rather than as personal criticism.	Increase self-awareness and improve performance.
Growth Action	Apply what you have learned by adjusting your habits, communication, or study strategies.	Develop resilience and continuous improvement.

Each time you complete this cycle, you strengthen both your relationships and your ability to overcome future challenges.

Core Interpersonal Competencies

Emotional Intelligence

Emotional intelligence is the ability to recognize, understand, and manage your own emotions while recognizing the emotions and perspectives of others.

Students with strong emotional intelligence are better equipped to:

- Remain calm during stressful situations.
- Resolve disagreements respectfully.
- Work effectively on group projects.

- Demonstrate empathy toward classmates and instructors.
- Build positive academic and professional relationships.

Leadership begins not with controlling others, but with managing your own emotional responses.

Active Listening

Listening is more than hearing words—it is giving someone your full attention.

Effective listeners:

- Eliminate distractions.
- Maintain eye contact when appropriate.
- Ask thoughtful follow-up questions.
- Avoid interrupting.
- Seek understanding before offering advice.

Active listening strengthens collaboration, reduces misunderstandings, and builds mutual respect.

Building Resilience

Every college student encounters obstacles. A difficult semester, an unexpected family responsibility, financial stress, or a disappointing exam grade can challenge even the most motivated learner.

Resilient students respond by asking:

- What can I learn from this experience?
- What resources can help me improve?
- What strategy should I try next?
- What is still within my control?

Rather than giving up after setbacks, resilient leaders adjust their approach and continue moving toward their goals.

Leadership in Action

Strong leaders are not those who never struggle—they are those who continue learning, adapting, and growing through every challenge.

Research Spotlight

Research consistently demonstrates that interpersonal skills and resilience are critical components of effective leadership. Psychologist **Daniel Goleman** found that **emotional intelligence—including self-awareness, self-regulation, empathy, and relationship management—is a strong predictor of leadership effectiveness**, often distinguishing high-performing leaders from equally talented peers. Similarly, **Carol Dweck's** research on **growth mindset** shows that individuals who believe their abilities can be developed are more likely to embrace challenges, persist after setbacks, and learn from constructive feedback rather than avoiding it.

Studies of college student success reinforce these findings. Students who build supportive relationships with instructors, advisors, and peers are more likely to remain engaged, persist through challenges, and achieve their educational goals. Likewise, students who view setbacks as opportunities for learning rather than signs of failure demonstrate greater resilience and academic persistence.

Together, this research highlights a simple but powerful truth: **leadership is strengthened through relationships, and resilience grows through reflection, feedback, and continuous improvement.**

This page titled [1.4: Relating with Others](#) is shared under a [CC BY](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by .

2: How I See Myself

Self-Awareness

Lindsay Hastings

INTRODUCTION

The way we see ourselves is critical to our development as leaders. The more we know about ourselves, the more strategic we can pursue leadership roles that fit our talents and values. The more we understand ourselves, the more easily we can understand others. The more mindful we can be of our feelings and state of mind, the more intentionally positive our actions can be. In short, our self-awareness as leaders is foundational and serves as an essential starting block for leadership development.

CHAPTER SPOTLIGHT

How we see ourselves is influenced by the messages we receive from others. Consider an example – Let us imagine two students, Lila and Jonah. Lila is in a home where she is appreciated and accepted. Every time she gets an ‘A’ on a test, she posts it on the refrigerator. Cherished adults in her life come to activities like soccer games and point out what she did well. Her teachers compliment her intellect and tell her she should go to college someday. What kind of picture does Lila have of herself? Would we imagine that picture to be positive or negative? Do we think Lila will work hard and do well in school? Why or why not? Do we think Lila might attend college? Why or why not?

Let us imagine Jonah is in a home where he is unappreciated and, frankly, ignored. No one asks how he is doing in school. No one cares if he gets an ‘A’ on a test. Important adults in his life rarely come to activities like soccer games and, if they do, only point out his mistakes. His teachers barely know his name, and no one has suggested attending college. What kind of picture does Jonah have of himself? Would we imagine that picture to be positive or negative? Do we think Jonah will work hard and do well in school? Why or why not? Do we think Jonah will attend college? Why or why not?

What if Lila and Jonah have roughly the same intellectual and athletic abilities? What would be the difference between them? The way others saw them. Again, how we see ourselves can be influenced by the messages we receive from others. Some messages from others are important to hear and retain. For example, we should cherish the messages we receive from our difference makers when they point out our talents and strengths. There may be other hurtful messages from our past that we need to reject or that we need to learn from and move forward. Each of us has the potential to be a great leader, and there is no such thing as a perfect leader. There has yet to be a standard set of personality characteristics in the research on leadership traits that are always associated with effective leadership. What does this mean for us? Each of us has the power to leverage what we uniquely do well to be an effective leader. Each of us has the power of positive influence. However, it is incumbent upon us to study ourselves, be students of our unique attributes, learn constructively from past experiences, and consider how to make a positive difference.

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

By the end of this chapter, we will be able to...

- Describe and distinguish between self-awareness, self-concept, and self-esteem
- Explain the importance of self-awareness to developing our leadership identity
- Identify turning points that have shaped our leadership identity
- Recognize the value in our unique leadership identity
- Articulate the utility of becoming self-aware

KEYWORDS: Self-awareness, self-concept, self-esteem, leadership identity

We may not realize it, but we have been painting the picture of ourselves since birth. The messages we have received from others influence the picture of ourselves. Charles Horton Cooley, a sociologist from the University of Michigan, created a “looking glass self” principle in 1902. A “looking glass” is the same as a mirror, and the “looking glass self” principle suggests that we have an imaginary mirror from the top of our heads to the tip of our toes. Others reflect how we behave towards them, arguing that *it takes two people to see one person*. The way we view ourselves and the messages we receive from others form our picture of ourselves.

Self-Concept is the collection of ideas we hold about ourselves and how we interpret those ideas through our *self-image* or how we see ourselves. While self-concept is related to the ideas and interpretations we have of ourselves, **self-esteem** refers to how much *value* we place on ourselves (Rogers, 1959). In other words, self-esteem is determined by how much worth we attribute to those

ideas we hold about ourselves. Positively seeing ourselves requires a commitment to self-awareness. **Self-awareness** is the ability to recognize our internal thoughts, feelings, and reactions, as well as our external behaviors (Fenigstein et al., 1975). Table 1 highlights the relationship between self-concept, self-esteem, and self-awareness.

Table 2.1: Self-Concept, Self-Esteem, and Self-Awareness

Self-Concept	Collection of ideas held about oneself and the interpretation of these ideas
Self-Esteem	Amount of value attributed to the ideas held about oneself
Self-Awareness	Ability to acknowledge internal thoughts, feelings, and reactions, as well as external behaviors

Self-concept, self-esteem, and self-awareness all originate from psychology. However, the positive psychology movement has drawn attention to self-concept, self-esteem, and self-awareness, acknowledging that self-images impact our quality of life (Seligman & Csikszentmihalyi, 2000). Thus, remembering that the picture we have of ourselves is often influenced by the messages we receive from others, a consistent commitment to self-awareness affords us the opportunity to (a) see ourselves more positively when positive attributes are recognized, (b) reflect and grow in response to constructive criticism, and (c) reject destructive messages. In the Social Change Model (SCM), self-awareness is discussed explicitly through the value, Consciousness of Self.

Consciousness of Self is one of the individual values in the Social Change Model (SCM). It means “to know oneself, or simply to be self-aware” (HERI, 1996, p. 31). There are two aspects to Consciousness of Self: (a) personality (i.e., relatively stable aspects of ourselves like talents and values) and (b) mindfulness (i.e., ability to observe our behaviors, feelings, and state of mind). Consciousness of Self is critical to the SCM because other values like *Collaboration* and *Controversy with Civility* hinge on the development of self-awareness. For example, suppose we are self-aware of our talent for listening. We might use that talent to make sure all team members’ voices are heard during a team meeting. For example, self-awareness might also help us recognize aggravated feelings and create mental space to consider words and behaviors that maintain civility despite such feelings.

Consciousness of Self can benefit the self, groups, and communities. Groups form shared values and purposes when each group member has a strong awareness of their personal beliefs and values. Consciousness of Self is the key to unlocking the consciousness of others. The more we understand ourselves, the more we understand others.

Why does self-awareness matter to leadership?

Self-awareness matters to leadership because it helps formulate our identity as a leader. We might decide to pursue specific leadership roles on campus or in the community because we see a strong fit between our leadership talents and the demands of the leadership roles. Understanding our identity as leaders might help us determine where we can contribute best on a group project. Identity is central to our development as leaders because it helps us identify where and how to have the most positive influence.

Several respected leadership scholars have researched to document the relationship between identity and leadership for both adults (Day & Harrison, 2007; Day et al., 2008; Ibarra et al., 2014; Lord & Hall, 2005; Miscenko et al., 2017; Shaughnessy & Coats, 2019) as well as youth and college students (Day & Sin, 2011; Komives et al., 2005, 2006; Lord et al., 2011; Murphy, 2019; Murphy & Johnson, 2011). Specifically, leadership identity has been related to leadership effectiveness (Avolio & Hannah, 2008; Day & Sin, 2011). In other words, your self-awareness is linked to your effectiveness as a leader.

We might be asking, “So how do I develop my identity as a leader exactly?” The development of our identity as leaders will constantly be evolving. It may sometimes feel repetitive because we often will have to unpack previous experiences to help illuminate elements of our identity as leaders. Significant people, experiences, and our ability to reflect on those people and experiences will all influence our identity as leaders and our implicit views of leadership.

A group of scholars in the early 2000s conducted a foundational study to understand the development of leadership identity. Led by Dr. Susan Komives, this team of scholars conducted in-depth interviews with college students and formulated a six-stage process of leadership identity development (See Figure 1; Komives et al., 2005, 2006).

Figure 1 | *Leadership Identity Development Model* (Komives et al., 2006)

Figure 2.1: Leadership Identity Development Model (Komives et al., 2006)

The first stage is *Awareness*, where we might recognize that leaders exist; however, we may not personally identify as a leader. The second stage is *Exploration/Engagement*, where we might intentionally get involved in groups and organizations and assume responsibility within those groups. Stage 3 is *Leader Identified*, where we start to see both leaders and followers in groups and identify leaders as those who hold a leadership position. We will know we are in Stage 4 (*Leadership Differentiated*) when we recognize that anyone in the group can do leadership. We start to see leadership as a process that requires lots of interdependence among the group members. The fifth stage (*Generativity*) will emerge when we take on a personal passion for our activities and actively commit to developing the leadership capacity of younger members. Finally, we will recognize that we have reached Stage 6 (*Integration/Synthesis*) when the word “leader” becomes integrated into our self-identity. We see leadership as not something we do but part of who we are. Leadership becomes part of our daily process. We apply our leadership in various situations (e.g., school, campus involvements, off-campus workplaces). We have a general sense of confidence in working effectively with people. The results from Komives et al.’s (2005, 2006) study demonstrated that the development of leadership identities constantly evolves and is influenced by adults, peers, meaningful involvement, and reflective learning (Priest et al., 2018).

While the Leadership Identity Development (LID) model helps us understand how our views of leadership might change and grow throughout our collegiate experience, our self-concept, self-esteem, and self-awareness contribute to formulating our unique leader identity. The activities at the end of this chapter help us (a) articulate our unique identity as a leader, (b) reflect on past experiences that have influenced our self-concept and self-esteem, (c) generate our definition of leadership, and (d) recognize our implicit views of leadership. Among the myriad definitions of leadership, the common denominator is the notion of *influence*. Each of us holds the power to leverage what we do uniquely well to influence our world positively.

QUESTIONS FOR JOURNALING OR DISCUSSION

1. In what ways, if at all, do your self-concept and self-esteem support your development as a leader?
2. How do your self-concept and self-esteem influence your behavior as a leader?
3. In your opinion, how might low self-esteem due to a negative self-concept influence a leader’s effectiveness?
4. What are ways to create regular opportunities to engage in self-awareness?
5. How can a positive self-concept be maintained when experiencing negative messages from others?

ACTIVITY

Implicit Leadership

Identity Statements

Directions: Below is an incomplete sentence (I am...) intended to guide your thinking about your identity as a **leader**. For this activity, you are asked to write this prompt (incomplete sentence) ten times and fill in the blanks for each of the ten prompts. While it may be tempting to write things like, “I am __good at basketball__” or “I am __artistic__,” **think about how you would describe yourself as a leader**. What are your strengths as a leader? Where do you add value to a team? How are you, or how would you like to be a positive difference-maker?

Our life experiences shape how we see ourselves as leaders. Below each identity statement, reflect upon the significant moment(s) that shaped the identity statement and indicate why.

I am..._____

- What significant moment has shaped this identity statement and why?

Reflection Prompts

Directions: Use these prompts to journal or reflect on your experiences related to self-esteem.

- What have been 3 – 5 “turning points” that have positively impacted your self-esteem?
- What have been 3 – 5 “turning points” that have negatively impacted your self-esteem?
- What have been the redemptive moments that have allowed you to overcome turning points that negatively impacted your self-esteem?

Definition of Leadership

Directions: Write your definition of leadership below. Use the prompts below to guide your thinking prior to writing your definition.

- Best leaders you have known
 - Qualities that are associated with effective leadership:
- Worst leaders you have known
 - Qualities that are associated with ineffective leadership
- Your definition of leadership
 - Often, our current environment influences our definition of leadership. How has your current context influenced your definition?

Illustrations of Leadership

Directions: Pick an object from the pictures below and consider how that object illustrates your definition of leadership. With a partner, share your definition of leadership and indicate how your selected object illustrates your definition of leadership. Discuss the following questions together:

- What were the similarities in our leadership definitions?
- What were the differences in our leadership definitions?
- Why were there differences in our leadership definitions? How have our life experiences shaped our unique definitions of leadership?

 This image displays several objects for you to choose between for the activity described above. The objects are a flashlight, tennis ball, trumpet, banana, army tank, rubber ducky, black pug dog, an apple, a blow dryer, a brown teddy bear, a rainbow container holder containing various paintbrushes, a wrist watch, orange spike high heel shoes, a front loader, and a yellow coffee mug.

Figure 2.2: Implicit Leadership Activity; L. McElravy, personal communication, August, 30, 2021

REFERENCES

- Avolio, B. J., & Hannah, S. T. (2008). Developmental readiness: Accelerating leader development. *Consulting Psychology Journal*, 60, 331–347.
- Cooley, C. H. (1902). Human Nature and the Social Order (New York: Scribner's, 1902). *Social Organization*.
- Day, D. V., & Harrison, M. M. (2007). A multilevel, identity-based approach to leadership development. *Human Resource Management Review*, 17(4), 360-373.

- Day, D. V., Harrison, M. M., & Halpin, S. M. (2008). *An integrative approach to leader development: Connecting adult development, identity, and expertise* New York, NY: Taylor & Francis, LLC.
- Day, D. V., & Sin, H. P. (2011). Longitudinal tests of an integrative model of leader development: Charting and understanding developmental trajectories. *The Leadership Quarterly*, 22(3), 545-560.
- Fenigstein, A., Scheier, M. F., & Buss, A. H. (1975). Public and private self-consciousness: Assessment and theory. *Journal of Consulting and Clinical Psychology*, 43(4), 522.
- Higher Education Research Institute (HERI). (1996). *A social change model of leadership development guidebook: Version III*. Los Angeles, CA: Author.
- Ibarra, H., Wittman, S., Petriglieri, G., & Day, D. V. (2014). Leadership and identity: An examination of three theories and new research directions. In D. V. Day (Ed.), *The Oxford handbook of leadership and organizations* (pp. 285 – 301). New York, NY: Oxford University Press.
- Komives, S. R., Longerbeam, S. D., Owen, J. E., Mainella, F. C., & Osteen, L. (2006). A leadership identity model: Applications from a grounded theory. *Journal of College Student Development*, 47(4), 401 – 418.
- Komives, S. R., Owen, J. E., Longerbeam, S. D., Mainella, F. C., & Osteen, L. (2005). Developing a leadership identity: A grounded theory. *Journal of College Student Development*, 46(6), 593 – 611.
- Lord, R. G., & Hall, R. J. (2005). Identity, deep structure and the development of leadership skills. *The Leadership Quarterly*, 16(4), 591-615.
- Lord, R. G., Hall, R. J., & Halpin, S. M. (2011). Leadership skill development and divergence: A model for the early effects of gender and race on leadership development. In S. E. Murphy & R. J. Reichard (Eds.), *Early development and leadership* (pp. 229-252). New York, NY: Routledge.
- Miscenko, D., Guenter, H., & Day, D. V. (2017). Am I a leader? Examining leader identity development over time. *The Leadership Quarterly*, 28(5), 605–620. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.leaqua.2017.01.004>
- Murphy, S. E. (2019). Leadership development starts earlier than you think. In R. E. Riggio (Ed.), *What's wrong with leadership? Improving leadership research and practice* (pp. 209 – 225). New York, NY: Routledge.
- Murphy, S. E., & Johnson, S. K. (2011). The benefits of a long-lens approach to leader development: Understanding the seeds of leadership. *Leadership Quarterly*, 22, 459- 470.
- Priest, K. L., Kliewer, B. W., Hornung, M., & Youngblood, R. (2018). The role of mentoring, coaching, and advising in developing leadership identity. In L. J. Hastings & C. Kane (Eds.), *New Directions for Student Leadership: No. 158. Role of mentoring, coaching, and advising in developing leadership* (pp. 9 – 22).
- Rogers, C. R. (1959). A theory of therapy, personality, and interpersonal relationships, as developed in the client-centered framework. In S. Koch (Ed.), *Psychology: A study of a science: Vol. 3* (pp. 184-256). New York, NY: McGraw-Hill.
- Seligman, M. E., & Csikszentmihalyi, M. (2000). Positive psychology: An introduction. *American Psychologist*, 55(1), 5 – 14.
- Shaughnessy, S. P., & Coats, M. R. (2019). Leaders are complex: Expanding our understanding of leader identity. In R. E. Riggio (Eds.), *What's wrong with leadership? Improving leadership research and practice* (pp. 173 – 188). New York, NY: Routledge.

This page titled [2: How I See Myself](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by .

3: Defining My Personal Values

Donnette Noble & Jeni McRay

INTRODUCTION

What beliefs are important to you? What are the values that help to define who you are and impact what you think, how you act, and how you feel? These are questions that may seem simple to answer, but further study reveals that our values are driving factors in how we choose to live, learn, and lead. This chapter will examine what values are, how they develop, how they are used in decision-making, and how they impact our relationships, vocation, and other parts of our life.

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

By the end of this chapter, you will be able to...

- define what values are and how they are formed.
- identify your current personal values.
- distinguish some of the cultural and/or social considerations that impact your values.
- understand how to leverage your values to drive positive change.

KEYWORDS: Beliefs, ideals, ethics, morals, alignment, values

Our values guide, motivate, and influence our attitudes and behaviors (Boer & Fischer, 2013). Values encompass our beliefs and ideals, and those are based on the things we learn from others – parents, peers, schools, faith-based communities, government, media, etc. (Fritz et al., 2005). **Beliefs** (Merriam-Webster, n.d.) are a state of mind or habits wherein trust or confidence is placed in a person or a thing; they are things that are accepted and considered to be true. **Ideals** (Merriam-Webster, n.d.) are standards or expectations of goals to achieve or models to emulate. Just like values, beliefs, and ideals will differ among people. See Figure (\PageIndex{1}) for examples of values.

 Values Word Cloud displayed. Figure 3.1: Values Word Cloud

Quite simply, values are individually internalized attitudes about what is right, wrong, ethical, unethical, moral, and immoral. Values can influence our perceptions of problems, our preferences, and the choices we make related to our behavior. Examples of values include fairness, justice, honesty, freedom, equality, altruism, loyalty, and civility (Yukl, 2013). Values exist at the individual level, societal or communal level, national level, and within all types of organizations.

Values are not necessarily static, however, and can fluctuate over time when new information is made available, a new experience unfolds, or some new understanding reveals itself. Value systems will also vary, sometimes quite dramatically, from culture to culture and even among the various subcultures within a given country or region.

Our values frame how we view the world around us. This chapter addresses the individual beliefs that serve to motivate people to think and behave in certain ways. It also examines what influences people, shapes their values, and considers the conundrum of competing values as well as how and why values might shift over time. Furthermore, this chapter will present a clear distinction between ethics (studying the societal standards of right and wrong, a legal and codified set of agreed-upon behaviors) and morals (individual principles related to right and wrong). There should be congruence among our values, decision-making, approaches to leadership, and intentions. This chapter also shines a “spotlight” on a convicted felon who thought he held strong and ethical values, yet he participated in one of the biggest corporate fraud cases in United States (U.S.) history.

CHAPTER SPOTLIGHT

In 2000, Andrew Fastow, the former Chief Financial Officer (CFO) for Enron, was named CFO of the Year by *CFO Magazine*, but “This is my actual trophy,” he later told the Association of Certified Fraud Examiners (ACFE) as he held up his prison ID card (Coonan, 2016). “Every inmate in the federal system is supposed to carry this at all times,” explained Fastow (Coonan, 2016, para. 4). Here’s the interesting thing—he received both the award and the prison card in the same year. How do you become *CFO of the Year* at the same time that you are committing one of the biggest frauds in the history of corporate America?

In 1985, after the Federal Government deregulated natural gas pipelines, two companies (Houston Natural Gas and InterNorth) merged to form Enron. During the merger process, Enron incurred massive debt, but because of the deregulation of the industry, the company did not have exclusive rights to pipelines. This caused some problems for the company. For Enron to survive, it had to come up with a new and innovative strategy to generate profits and ensure a steady cash flow (Thomas, 2002). The Chief Executive

Officer (CEO) hired a global management firm to develop a new strategy. The firm assigned Jeffrey Skilling, an experienced consultant, to take the lead in designing a revolutionary solution. Skilling quickly rose through Enron's corporate ranks, and ultimately tapped Fastow to be a part of the team.

It was Fastow who was the real “mastermind behind a supremely complex network of off-balance-sheet special purpose entities and shell companies [that were] used to conceal years of massive losses [that were] leveraged on Enron stock” (Coonan, 2016, para. 6). Fastow was a genius in finding business management workarounds and tax loopholes, and all of the maneuvering he choreographed “was approved by the accountants at Enron, the outside auditors, the internal attorneys, the outside attorneys and the board of directors” (Coonan, 2016, para. 8).

Throughout the spring and summer of 2001, the risky deals Enron had made in terms of its underperforming investments began to unravel and caused the company to suffer a huge cash shortfall (Thomas, 2002) that ultimately led to its spectacular collapse when \$1 billion in employee retirement funds and 5,000 jobs were wiped out overnight (Flanagan, 2020).

Prior to the collapse, Fastow considered himself to be a hero of sorts (Flanagan, 2020), but, in the end, he served six years in prison for his part in the fraud (a reduced sentence for providing evidence against his colleagues). Skilling (the CEO) served 12 years, and the Chairman of the Board (Ken Lay) died while awaiting his sentencing. Fastow, with the tacit approval of others, followed the rules but compromised values and hurt a lot of people in the process.

“For many organizations, values are a social glue” (Manning & Curtis, 2009, p. 105). Values are used to create a sense of corporate identity, and they can foster greater cohesion. They can also be relied upon to increase effective decision-making: “To be meaningful, values must enter into the daily practice of the organization [and] reflect enduring commitments, not vague and empty platitudes” (p. 105). When it came to Enron, the company's core values of communication, respect, integrity, and excellence (Enron, 2000) were shrouded in hypocrisy.

As you reflect on this case study, can you think of other situations where people “followed the rules but compromised values”? Can you think of a situation where you have “followed the rules” but still compromised your own values?

History

“For millennia, philosophers, sociologists, psychologists, and others have tried to figure out just exactly what values are” (Sharma, 2015, p. 42). The word, *values*, comes from the Latin “valeo” which means to be strong (Sharma, 2015). According to Halstead and Taylor (2000), values can be broadly defined as the principles or fundamental convictions which serve as general guides to human behavior and the related actions are then judged as good or desirable (or not). They can also be considered “abstract ideals” as they relate to people's behavior (Hanel et al., 2018, p. 1).

In the 1930s, a psychologist, Gordon Allport (1937), created a list of values, or what he thought were easily recognized consistencies, that tend to define and support a person's unique path in life (Sharma, 2015). The first of Allport's values or consistencies is *theoretical* and encompasses the pursuit of truth and objectivity (something we've heard a lot about in the last couple of years but more about that later in the chapter). The second one, *economic*, is all about usefulness and practicality. The third is *aesthetic*, which focuses on harmony and beauty. The next is *social*, which is centered on love and compassion for people. Then there is *political* value which hinges on power, and finally, *religious* value which is defined by unity or moral excellence (Tsirogianni & Gaskell, 2011).

Each person is in possession of any number of values, and those values are tied to varying degrees of importance (Schwartz, 2012). For example, a value that may be critically important to one person may not be at all important to someone else. Relying on the works of many theorists over the years (Allport, 1961; Feather, 1995; Kluckhohn, 1951; Morris, 1956; & Rokeach, 1973), Schwartz (2012) contends there are six main features to values (pp. 3-4); (see Table 3.1).

Table 3.1: What are values?

Values are...	beliefs that are linked to affect and when activated, become infused with feeling (emotions).
	connected to desirable goals that motivate people's actions.
	ordered by a system of priorities that characterize each person's individuality.

transferable, (i.e., they may be relevant at home, the workplace, or school and in business or politics or with friends as well as strangers).

the standards which guide the selection or evaluation of actions, policies, people, or events.

the determiners of the gravitas or implication of actions.

Defining Values

Social values are the standards that influence the judgments we have about ourselves and others, and they impress upon us what is important as we pursue our individual purpose in life; thus, they are also closely tied to our self-conception. As we endeavor to make value-enhancing choices across the different domains of our lives, we find that our values contribute to our sense of self-worth and efficacy (Tsirogianni & Gaskell, 2011). Values are used to characterize cultural groups, societies, and individuals. Additionally, they are used to trace personal changes over time and can explain the motivational bases of attitudes and behaviors (Schwartz, 2012).

The early years of a child's life are often completely dependent on their parents: "Parents are a child's first and most significant shapers of character" (MacElroy, 2003, para. 3). As we grow older, we develop our morals and values, not only based on parental influence but also on the influence from peers. As young people leave home and transition to college, more people come into their lives who play a part in shaping their sense of self (MacElroy, 2003). These new relationships, increased freedom, and more latitude in decision-making can result in shifts or challenges to previously held values.

Values have contextual relevance, and some may cross into different domains while others may not. Personal values related to self may include education, academic accomplishments, physical fitness, self-respect and esteem, responsibility, creativity, wealth, social status, or humor. Relationship values are comprised of concepts such as family, friends, love, loyalty, camaraderie, harmony, and diversity of perspectives. Justice, recognition, opportunities, expertise, and goal achievement are considered vocational values. Spiritual values may address forgiveness, reflection, integrity, wisdom, inner peace, and optimism.

One mechanism to help students assess their own values is adapted from the [BCJ Institute for Learning and Development](#) (See Figure 3.2).

 This image depicts a wheel divided into three sections which represent professional, personal, and community. **Figure 3.2: Values Wheel**

When people take time to examine their values and think about what is important to them and why, they are more prepared to meet life's challenges. Having a strong sense of values helps to create a road map that helps them to figure out things such as (BCJ, nd):

1. What are their goals and how will they get there?
2. What should be prioritized in life?
3. How do they want to behave in certain situations?
4. What is the best course of action when making decisions?
5. What would they like their legacy to be?

There are, however, situations when people find themselves not living in accordance with their values, and this misalignment can create stress, anger, or anxiety and conjure up other negative emotions. Additionally, a lack of alignment can lead to poor or even unethical decision-making. This is why consistency among our values, thoughts, and actions is so critically important. Additionally, when we are living in alignment with our values, we are more resilient and better equipped to address difficulties that will inevitably arise over time.

ACTIVITIES

Values Assessment

Begin this activity by dividing a piece of paper into three columns and label the columns, Personal, Professional, and Community. Under each of the three headings, make a list of values that are important to you personally, professionally, and in terms of community. For example, when it comes to personal values, love and kindness may be important to you. Professionally you might value transparency or integrity. When it comes to community you may value justice or safety. If you need help getting started, [click this link for a list of 305 values](#).

Once you have developed a meaningful list of values, go back through the list and place a star by the *five most important values* in each of the three categories. For the purpose of this exercise, we will refer to these as your *core values*.

Next, prioritize each of your five core values from each section and plot them by drawing the diagram from Figure 2 on a sheet of paper and placing the values in the appropriate category. The most important of the five core values from each list will be closest to the center of the diagram, whereas the values with lesser priority will be toward the periphery of the diagram in each section. Now you have the start of a personalized road map that will aid in helping you maintain consistency in your values, thoughts, and actions in three distinct spaces of your life – personal, professional, and community.

Be ready to discuss your values in each category with the class.

As you think about the motivational bases of attitudes and behaviors, consider what has happened since January 2020. The world has collectively lived with the COVID-19 pandemic, an experience that forced people to reevaluate what is important to them. People have had to reassess what they value and how those values affect their decisions in terms of living through unprecedented circumstances. The U.S. comprises less than 5% of the global population

(Whelan, 2020), yet leads the world in the total number of reported COVID cases (77,956,627) as well as reported deaths (923,110) as of February 15, 2022 ([John Hopkins, 2021](#)). These figures have required that people reflect on the role of science in their lives, in addition to considering how mask mandates, social restrictions, and the availability of COVID vaccines impact their values, if at all. This raises one conundrum after another for thoughtful individuals who are trying to sift through the noise to find answers. For instance, do personal liberty and freedom (individual values) take precedence over the greater good of public health concerns (collective values)? The answers lie within the beliefs, ideals, and values each person holds.

Leadership, Values, and Change

There are many facets to power, and it can be exerted for good or ill. A leader's personal values and internal code of ethics may be among the most important determinants in terms of how a leader will exercise power (Hughes et al., 2015). Leaders will undoubtedly be faced with challenges time and again, and those challenges often lack simplistic answers. The key is doing what is right and not just what is expedient. This is where authentic leadership comes into play: "authentic leaders exhibit consistency among their values, their beliefs, and their actions" (p. 166), and "honesty, altruism, kindness, fairness, accountability, and optimism" have been identified as core values of authentic leaders (Yukl, 2013, p. 351). The tenets of altruism, fairness, and accountability can be significant drivers of social change.

The basic values we hold dear are those that help us set our course for action as responsible individuals and community members who are concerned with protecting our democratic society. Indeed, the Social Change Model (HERI, 1996) hinges entirely on values with an expectation that leadership will be inclusive. Leadership is a process and not a position, and it explicitly promotes additional values of equity, social justice, self-knowledge, personal empowerment, collaboration, citizenship, and service (Noble & Kniffin, 2021).

The year 2020 was rife with racial and social tensions in the United States. The calls for social justice were amplified after George Floyd was killed by a police officer in Minneapolis:

Floyd's death sent a nation of people in quarantine out into the streets in mass protests. Major corporations issued statements in support of Black Lives Matter. Politicians promised a new direction. Years later, some activists argue there is still more work to be done to reach equity and social justice for Black and brown people (Gunderson, 2021, para. 2 – 3).

The Black Lives Matter movement is demonstrative of how racial and social tensions have the power to divide a society based on differing values systems. There is a delicate balancing act that must take place between individual values and those that are important to others. To bridge the gap that these differences create, we must use empathy to better understand the values behind differing opinions. By taking time to understand the values of others, we can identify ways to better engage with others.

Value Systems, Alignment, and Change

One of the national values of the U.S. is explicitly stated in what was considered its defacto motto until 1956, *E Pluribus Unum*, meaning "from the many, one" (B., 2011). It is a testament to the fact that, from its beginning, the U.S. has been a pluralistic society where different races, ethnicities, religions, traditions, and languages have converged to co-create and share a common national experience; however, the persistence of deep differences among the people residing in the United States raises the corollary challenge of how to maintain at least a basic level of social cohesion and solidarity when in fact, those "deep differences" (Hoover, 2016, p. 26) very often result in competing value systems. While some differences are accommodated, "Peaceful, constructive pluralism doesn't "just happen." It requires leadership, both from the top-down (government) and the bottom-up (civil

society). Social flourishing becomes sustainable, even under conditions of deepening diversity, when all stakeholders develop reserves of commitment..." (Hoover, 2016, p. 27) to supporting one another and honoring the differences among us – including the ebb and flow of our fluctuating values.

Adding layers to the complexity of competing values are disparate views of both morals and ethics. While the terms are often interchanged, they are not necessarily the same thing. Both words refer to some form of proper conduct (Rosenstand, 1997). Morals address customs or habits, whereas ethics (or moral philosophy) is the study of moral judgments about what is virtuous (or not), just or unjust, right or wrong, good or bad or evil (Moore & Bruder, 2008).

While personality traits are relatively stable throughout one's life, values are characteristic adaptations and motivational goals that can change as a function of developmental priorities at different ages and stages of one's life (Gouveia et al., 2015). Schwartz (2012) proffers that there are three systematic sources of age-related differences that can result in shifts in values. These shifts can occur in response to a person's changing roles associated with their stage in life (this is the first of the systematic sources of changing values). Some of the values of a young, relatively unencumbered, traditional-aged college student likely differ rather significantly when compared to those of a mid-career professional with a partner or spouse and children to raise. The second systematic source of shifts in values is the result of physiological or biological changes – changes in maturity and/or abilities which could include declines in energy and sharpness of the senses. Finally, changes in values can result from societal changes, including democratization and political and economic stability (Gouveia et al., 2015).

Summary

Broadly speaking, Brown (2012) suggests there are two buckets that people will put their values into – the practiced values bucket (*what we are actually doing, thinking, and feeling*) and the aspirational values bucket (*what we want to do, think, and feel*). The difference between what is practiced and what is aspirational results in a values gap. Brown (2012) contends that disengagement is inevitable when practiced values conflict with aspirational values and expectations within a culture. Disengagement (detaching, releasing, disconnecting, or withdrawing from someone or something) is the issue underlying the majority of problems that exist in families, schools, communities, and organizations. We must, therefore, *mind the gap* and stay focused to ensure that our values are aligned and match our actions (Brown, 2012).

Values are messy and complex: "Thinking about [them] is not a luxury; you live them every day of your life. Your values show in the way you treat your friends, enemies, [and others], and they determine your politics, ethics, emotions, daydreams, life, and leisure" (Halberstam, 1993, p.

186). The way we engage our values and how they drive our lives is a lifelong process. What kind of a leader you are will be reflected in how you handle the challenges surrounding your beliefs, ideals, and values – particularly when they collide.

QUESTIONS FOR JOURNALING OR DISCUSSION

- If you are involved in or have completed a service-learning project this semester, identify some of the organizational values you observed. If you haven't participated in a service-learning project before, identify some of the values you've observed in an organization that you have been a client or customer of (either non-profit or for-profit).
- Think about some of the groups you interact with (at home, at school, at work, etc.) and identify some of the values you observed.
 - How do the values you observed in the situations described above align with your own values (if they do)?
 - If the values you observed are different from your own, what things do you think contributed to those differences?
- When you think of social change, what issues are important to you and which of your values are congruent with those issues?
- Think about a time when you had to work through a difficult situation where two or more of your values were in conflict. How did that make you feel and how did you resolve the situation?

Cave Rescue

Read the following Scenario about a caving accident. After reading the scenario, carefully complete the steps that follow in order. Please do not skip any steps in this process.

Scenario

Your group is asked to take the role of a research management committee that is funding projects into human behavior in confined spaces. You have been called to an emergency meeting as one of the experiments has run into an emergency situation.

Six volunteers have been taken into a cave system in a remote part of the country connected only by a radio link to the research hut by the cave entrance. It was intended that the volunteers would spend four days underground, but they have been trapped by falling rocks and rising water.

The only rescue team available tells you that rescue will be extremely difficult, and only one person can be brought out each hour with the equipment at their disposal. It is likely that the rapidly rising water will drown some of the volunteers before rescue can be completed.

The volunteers are aware of the dangers of their plight. They have contacted the research hut using the radio link and said that they are unwilling to make a decision regarding the order in which they will be rescued. By the terms of the research project, the responsibility for making this decision now rests with your committee.

Life-saving equipment will arrive in 50 minutes at the cave entrance, and you will need to advise the team of the order for rescue by completing the ranking sheet provided below. The only information you have available is drawn from the project files and is reproduced on the volunteer personal details sheet that can be found below. You may use any criteria you think fit to help you make a decision.

Cave Rescue: Volunteer Personal Details Sheet

Volunteer 1 Helen	Helen is a 34-year-old married and a homemaker. Her husband is a member of the City Council. She had been a promising psychology student before leaving the university to be married. Helen has four children (ages 7 months to 8 years) and lives in a suburban community near the university. Helen became introduced to the experiment through Owen, with whom she has become romantically involved.
Volunteer 2 Tozo	Tozo is 19 years old. She is single and a pre-med student at Provincial University. Her parents live in Tokyo where her father is a prominent businessman and her mother is chairperson of the Cancer Research Foundation. She has achieved top honors in her classes for the last three years and has been awarded two scholarships for academic achievements. Tozo was voted by her classmates as most likely to succeed and intends to return to Japan and set up a free clinic for the poor.
Volunteer 3: John	John is 41 years old. He is married and is the campus coordinator for Catholic Social Services at Provincial University. He has five children (ages 6 to 19 years). John worked full-time while attending university where he earned a master's degree in social work. He has become very involved in an anti-racist group, which holds frequent protests.
Volunteer 4 Owen	Owen is an unmarried man of 27 years. As a short-commission officer he spent part of his service in Northern Ireland where, as an undercover agent, he broke up an IRA cell and received a special commendation. Since returning to civilian life, he has been unsettled and drinking has become a persistent problem. At present, he is a Youth Adventure Leader, devoting much energy to helping young people and leading caving groups. His recreation is preparing and driving stock cars. He lives in Brecon, South Wales.

Volunteer 5 Suni	Suni is a 47-year-old medical research scientist at the University Hospital. He is recognized as a world authority on viruses, such as Zika, SARS, and COVID-19. He feels he is getting closer to a breakthrough that would not just prevent but cure viruses such as these, but much of the research data is still in working (handwritten) notebooks. He recently suffered a nervous breakdown from overwork and volunteered for this project because he felt a break might clear his head so he could move forward with his research.
Volunteer 6 Edward	Edward is a man of 59 years who has lived and worked in the United States for most of his life. He is the general manager of a factory producing rubber belts for machines. The factory employs 71 people. He is prominent in local society and is a Freemason and a conservative councilor. He is married with two children who have their own families and have moved abroad. Edward has recently returned from Poland where he was personally responsible for promoting a contract to supply large numbers of industrial belts over a five-year period. This contract, if signed, would mean work for another 250 people. Edward's hobbies include gun collecting and online sports gambling.

Now that you have reviewed the *Volunteer Personal Details Sheet*, complete the following steps in order. Please do not skip any steps:

1. Individually, use a ranking sheet (see sample below) to indicate the order the volunteers should be extracted from the cave. Write your answers in the left-hand column. You have 10 minutes to do this.
2. Working in your groups, discuss the order in which each of you believes each of the volunteers should be removed from the cave. Work to arrive at a group decision by sharing your reasons or criteria and working to develop criteria the group can agree to. Use the right-hand column to record the group consensus.
3. Collectively, use a group ranking sheet (see example below) to present the order of extraction from the cave. Share with the class the order of extraction your group arrived at and the issues and values that were discussed in arriving at your decisions.

Cave Rescue Ranking Sheet

Your Individual - Order of Rescue:	Group - Order of Rescue:
NAME	NAME
	1.
2.	2.
3.	3.
4.	4.
5.	5.
6.	6.
Notes:	Notes:

Questions for Consideration:

- Did your group establish a decision-making criterion? If so, what was it?
- Was consensus reached? If not, what criteria did you use to make your decisions?
- Did everyone feel their point of view was heard and considered by all other team members? Why or why not?

- Was anyone unhappy with the outcome? Why?
- What could other team members have done to listen and support each other?
- What emotions or feelings did you have that affected your ability to make decisions in this activity? What would you have recommended to the research team if this were a real activity?

REFERENCES

Allport, G. W. (1937). *Personality: A psychological interpretation*. Holt, Rinehart & Winston.

Allport, G. W. (1961). *Pattern and growth in personality*. Holt, Reinhart & Winston.

Berkeley Well-Being Institute. *Printable List of Values*. <https://www.berkeleywellbeing.com/uploads/1/9/4/8/19481349/printable-list-of-values.pdf>

B. J. (2011). Change the motto of the United States of America to “E Pluribus Unum.” *We the People*. <https://petitions.obamawhitehouse.archives.gov/petition/change-motto-united-states-america-e-pluribus-unum/>

BJC Institute for Learning and Development (n.d.). *Clarifying your values*. <https://www.bjclearn.org/resiliency/PDFs/001103.pdf>

Boer, D., & Fischer, R. (2013). How and when do personal value guide our attitudes and sociality? Explaining cross-cultural variability in attitude-value linkages. *Psychological Bulletin*, 139(5), 1113–1147. <https://doi.org/10.1037/a0031347>

Brown, B. (2012). *Daring greatly: How the courage to be vulnerable transforms the way we live, love, parent, and lead*. Avery.

Coonan, C. (2016, January 6). Former Enron CFO Andrew Fastow: You can follow all the rules and still commit fraud. *The Irish Times*. <https://www.irishtimes.com/business/companies/former-enron-cfo-andrew-fastow-you-can-follow-all-the-rules-and-still-commit-fraud-1.2485821>

Enron. (2000). Enron annual report. <https://picker.uchicago.edu/Enron/EnronAnnualReport2000.pdf>

Feather, N. T. (1995). Values, valences, and choice: The influences of values on the perceived attractiveness and choice of alternatives. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 68(6), 1135–1151. <https://doi-org.libproxy.unl.edu/10.1037/0022-3514.68.6.1135>

Flanagan, P. (2020, January 9). Enron’s former CFO Andrew Fastow once saw himself as ‘a hero.’ *Chron*. <https://www.chron.com/business/energy/article/Andrew-Fastow-Who-Helped-Bring-Down-Enron-Saw-14962065.php>

Fritz, S., Brown, W. F., Povlacs Lunde, J., & Banset, E. A. (2005). *Interpersonal skills for leadership* (2nd ed.). Pearson.

Gouveia, V. V., Vione, K., Milfont, T. L., & Fischer, R. (2015). Patterns of value change during the life span: Some evidence from a functional approach to values. *Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin*. 4(9), 1276–1290. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0146167215594189>

Gunderson, E. (2021). *Social Justice Organizations Reflect on 2020 as Floyd Anniversary Nears*. WTTW News. Retrieved January 15, 2023, from <https://news.wttw.com/2021/05/23/soc...iversary-nears>

Halberstam, J. (1993). *Everyday ethics: Inspired solutions to real-life dilemmas*. Viking/Penguin Books.

Halstead, J. M., & Taylor, M. J. (2000). Learning and teaching about values: A review of recent research. *Cambridge Journal of Education*, 30(2), 169–202. <https://doi.org/10.1080/713657146>

Hanel, P.H.P., Litzellachner, L .F., & Maio, G. R. (2018). An empirical comparison of human value models. *Frontiers in Psychology*, 9, 1643. <https://doi.org/10.3389/fpsyg.2018.01643>

Higher Education Research Institute. (1996). *A Social Change Model of Leadership Development* (Version III). UCLA. <https://www.heri.ucla.edu/PDFs/pubs/ASocialChangeModelofLeadershipDevelopment.pdf>

Hoover, D. R. (2016). Pluralist responses to pluralist realities in the United States. *Society*, 53(1), 20–27. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s12115-015-9967-2>

Hughes, R. L., Ginnett, R. C., & Curphy, G. J., (2015). *Leadership: Enhancing the lessons of experience* (8th ed.). McGraw Hill.

John Hopkins Coronavirus Resource Center. (2022). COVID-19 dashboard. <https://coronavirus.jhu.edu/map.html>

Kluckhohn, C. (1951). Values and value-orientations in the theory of action: An exploration in definition and classification. In G. W. Allport, C. Kluckhohn, H. A. Murray, R. R. Sears, R. C. Sheldon, S. A. Stouffer, & E. C. Tolman (Eds.), *Toward a General*

- Theory of Action* (pp. 388–433). Harvard University Press. <https://doi.org/10.4159/harvard.9780674863507.c8>
- MacElroy, M. (2003). Educating for character: Teaching values in the college environment. *The Vermont Connection*, 24(1). <https://scholarworks.uvm.edu/tvc/vol24/iss1/3>
- Manning, G., & Curtis, K. (2009). *The art of leadership* (3rd ed.). McGraw Hill.
- Merriam-Webster. (n.d.). Belief. In Merriam-Webster.com dictionary. Retrieved June 20, 2023, from <https://www.merriam-webster.com/dictionary/belief>
- Merriam-Webster. (n.d.). Ideal. In Merriam-Webster.com dictionary. Retrieved June 20, 2023, from <https://www.merriam-webster.com/dictionary/ideal>
- Moore, B. N., & Bruder, K. (2008). *Philosophy: The power of ideas* (7th ed.). McGraw Hill.
- Morris, C. (1956). *Varieties of human value*. University of Chicago Press.
- Noble, D., & Kniffin, L. E. (2021). Building sustainable civic learning and democratic engagement goals for the future. *New Directions for Higher Education*, 2021(195–196), 171–179. <https://doi.org/10.1002/he.20421>
- Rokeach, M. (1973). *The nature of human values*. Free Press.
- Rosenstand, N. (1997). *The moral of the story: An introduction to ethics* (2nd ed.). Mayfield Publishing.
- Schwartz, S.H. (2012) An overview of the Schwartz theory of basic values. *Online Readings in Psychology and Culture*, 2(1). <https://doi.org/10.9707/2307-0919.1116>
- Sharma, K. (2015). A comparative study of aesthetic, economic, and political values of undergraduate students. *The International Journal of Indian Psychology*, 2(2), 42–55. <https://doi.org/10.25215/0202.008>
- Thomas, C. W. (2002). The rise and fall of Enron: When a company looks too good to be true, it usually is. *Journal of Accountancy*. <https://www.journalofaccountancy.com/issues/2002/apr/theriseandfallofenron.html>
- Tsirogianni, S., & Gaskell, G. (2011). The role of plurality and context in social values. *Journal for the Theory of Social Behavior*. 41(4), 441–465. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1468-5914.2011.00470.x>
- Whelan, N. (2020). Countries by percentage of world population. *World atlas*. <https://www.worldatlas.com/articles/countries-by-percentage-of-world-population.html>
- Yukl, G. (2013). *Leadership in organizations* (8th ed.). Pearson.

3: Defining My Personal Values is shared under a [CC BY-NC](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by LibreTexts.

4. Defining My Vision, Setting Personal Goals, and Making Decisions

Personal Leadership Philosophy - Part 1

L.J. McElravy

***Note:** The author would like to thank and acknowledge Blaise Lanoha for his contributions in planning and developing the outline of this chapter.*

The Visioning Process

Often, when we think about great leaders, we think about the change they strived to achieve. For example, Abraham Lincoln's Emancipation Proclamation declared "that all persons held as slaves ... are, and henceforward shall be free" (National Archives, 2022). Although the proclamation was limited to ending slavery in the rebellious states and left the inhumane practice of slavery untouched for other parts of the United States, President Lincoln communicated his vision, an expansion of freedom to many more people within the United States. Like optical vision using glasses, a vision is a tool for creating focus and clarifying what you would like to see. A vision helps focus attention on what we believe the desired future should be (Den Hartog & Verburg, 1997).

 This is a decorative image of glasses. The bottom of the image says "A vision brings focus to a desired future." Figure 1: Photo by David Travis on Unsplash

INTRODUCTION

Visioning happens at many different levels. For example, organizations and teams may have a vision. In these cases, groups of people may come together to determine their collective or shared vision, articulating who and what they want to be as a group. For the purpose of this chapter, we focus specifically on visioning as an individual, or the vision people may have for themselves and for their own leadership.

Creating a vision requires us to be rooted in our past, think about the desired future, and consider how what is going on in our life today has merit and meaning (Friedman, 2008). Friedman (2008) discusses how visioning represents who you are and what you stand for and can pave the path for future success in our career and personal lives. Visioning is a process of taking thoughts and ideas and making them tangible through writing. Though a vision is future-oriented, it is based in understanding past experiences, and an important element of making sense of the past is to intentionally reflect on those experiences. In other words, to know where we want to go, we have to know where we have been and who we are.

In this chapter, you will create a vision for your leadership, referred to as a Personal Leadership Philosophy (PLP). A PLP is an individual's vision for the kind of leader that they want to be. By elucidating your leadership vision, you are creating a beacon to serve as your guide for effective leadership. Like any visioning process, we start with self-reflection. Self-reflection, intentionally thinking about past experiences, allows us to make sense of the past in order to plan for the future. In this chapter, you will be encouraged to reflect on your leadership assumptions, beliefs, and values to help clarify a vision for your own leadership.

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

By the end of this chapter, you will be able to...

- describe the relationship between leadership assumptions, beliefs, values, vision, personal leadership philosophy, goals, and behaviors.
- identify personal leadership assumptions, beliefs, and values through reflection.
- create a draft personal leadership philosophy.
- describe approach and mastery goals.
- define hope as it relates to goal setting.
- apply SMART goal format to create goals supporting personal leadership and interpersonal skill development.

KEYWORDS: Vision, personal leadership philosophy, goal setting

Visioning: Your Personal Leadership Philosophy

As a vision for your own leadership, a Personal Leadership Philosophy (PLP), can provide direction and motivation. In other words, a PLP can guide actions, behaviors, and thoughts to help you become the leader you want to be. We will provide a process to help you create a PLP, and this process will involve reflecting on your experiences to articulate your leadership values, beliefs, and assumptions.

To begin the PLP writing process, we start with a short activity. In this activity, you are given two story prompts. For each prompt, please take four to five minutes to create a story about someone described in the prompt. There are no right or wrong stories. Please make sure the story is clear in your mind (it may be helpful to write it down). You should highlight specific notes, draw a picture, or do anything that can help you create a clear picture in your mind. Within the story, please make sure you are thinking about how your character interacts with other people in the story. What are the people in the story doing, saying, thinking, and feeling? Each box below contains a specific prompt and a space for you to make notes about your story. After each prompt, there is a series of questions about the character in the story. Please refrain from looking at the questions until after the story about the character is clear in your mind. Please take about five to 10 minutes to respond to the questions.

Story #1: Someone is elected president of a student organization, and they are giving a speech to the organization after learning they won. *(Please take four to five minutes to create a story about the president using the prompt above. There are no right or wrong stories. Please make sure you are thinking about how your character interacts with other people in the story. What are the people in the story doing, saying, thinking, and feeling? Please make sure the story is clear in your mind, and feel free to use the space below to take notes, draw, doodle, or whatever helps clarify the story in your mind).*

Question #1: What did the president say?

Question #2: How were people reacting to what the president was saying?

Question #3: What did the president do to get elected? This may have been something said directly or something implied.

Question #4: What were the president's priorities? This may have been something said directly or something implied.

Story #2: There is a conflict within a team working on a project. One of the members is working to manage the conflict. *(Please take four to five minutes to create a story about the team member working to manage the conflict using the prompt above. There are no right or wrong stories. Please make sure you are thinking about how your character interacts with other people in the story.. What are the people in the story doing, saying, thinking, and feeling Please make sure the story is clear in your mind, and feel free to use the space below to take notes, draw, doodle, or whatever helps clarify the story in your mind).*

Question #1: What did the team member say to manage the conflict?

Question #2: How did the team respond to the team member trying to manage the conflict?

Question #3: What were the priorities of the team member trying to manage the conflict? This may have been something said directly or something implied.

Now that you have finished with the stories and the questions, let's discuss why this kind of reflection is important for a PLP.

Leadership Assumptions

Leadership assumptions are the ideas we have about what leadership "is" or "should be" that are not often part of our conscious thinking. For example, if you are appointed the president of a student organization, what would you start doing automatically? Perhaps you would want to make sure you meet everyone else in the organization. Perhaps you would read the bylaws of the organization to make sure you understand all the policies. Our assumptions are automatic thoughts about leadership. The stories provided you an opportunity to think about your automatic ideas about what leaders do, either in a specific role as president or in an informal role as a team member. To help you reflect and explore your leadership assumptions, take up to 10 minutes to brainstorm up to 25 characteristics that you think were displayed by the leaders in your stories.

Think of this process in relation to a map. The stories allowed your brain to wander; you did not know where you were going; you just kept the story moving along in any direction. Identifying the leadership characteristics is like seeing where you wandered on a map. Mapping the characteristics connects the actions of the characters to tangible waypoints, something specific you can describe.

Please review the stories and the answers to the questions to help you identify these leadership characteristics. These characteristics should represent what the leaders did, whether their leadership was effective or not. For example, if in your story, the team member was not able to manage the conflict, you should still list the characteristics of that team member. The characteristics may be the same for leaders in both stories, but you should also list any characteristics that were displayed by only one of the leaders in your stories. List these on a separate sheet using the following example below as a template.

1.	6.	11.	16.	21.
2.	7.	12.	17.	22.

3.	8.	13.	18.	23.
4.	9.	14.	19.	24.
5.	10.	15.	20.	25.

These characteristics provide insight into your leadership assumptions – your automatic thoughts about leaders. Next, we will discuss leadership beliefs.

Leadership Beliefs

Leadership beliefs are the conscious ideas you have about what leadership “is” or “should be.” While assumptions are the automatic ideas you have, beliefs are the ideas you have when you get a chance to think and reflect. These are the ideas about leadership you intentionally choose to have. To help you identify your leadership beliefs, review the list of characteristics you identified and circle five to seven characteristics you think are most important. Please take a few minutes to identify these characteristics and list the characteristics using the example that follows.

1.	
2.	
3.	
4.	
5.	
6.	
7.	

These characteristics make up part of your leadership beliefs, what you believe leadership “is” or “should be.”

Now that you have identified some of your leadership assumptions and beliefs, we want to help you identify your leadership values. As you may remember from a previous chapter, values are ideas about appropriate beliefs, outcomes, and behaviors that are applied generally to numerous contexts (Lord & Brown, 2001). In other words, values are what we use to evaluate what we do, and what we see others do, to determine if those actions are appropriate or not.

Our values are often held across various situations. For example, if I value environmental sustainability, I likely hold this value in my home, at work, and in my social life. At home, I might be willing to make sure that I separate my recycling from my trash and take trips to a recycling center. I may choose to work for a company that focuses on promoting environmental sustainability. Within my social life, I might only want to eat at restaurants that serve locally sourced foods. This is one example of how individual values might hold across multiple contexts. To help you identify your own leadership values, take a few minutes to respond to the following questions:

- Who should lead and who should follow?
- How are followers engaged in leadership?
- What is the purpose of leadership?
- Can leadership be good and bad?
- Is leadership different from being a leader?
- What role does the situation or context play in leadership?

As you review your responses to the questions above, can you identify any values that may emerge from your responses? Again, values can be thought of as general “truths” about what leadership should be across different situations. You might also want to review the previous chapter where you identified your values to see if any of those also fit as leadership values. Below is a list of values related to leadership. This list is not comprehensive, and it is provided to give you an idea of some different leadership values.

Autonomy	Egalitarianism	Humility	Materialism

Autonomy	Egalitarianism	Humility	Materialism
Caring	Empathy	Inclusiveness	Novelty
Collectivism	Equity	Independence	Personal development
Connection	Faith	Individualism	Power
Conservatism	Family	Innovation	Rationality
Courage	Generativity	Integrity	Respect
Creativity	Harmony	Justice	Selflessness
Democracy	Hierarchy	Learning	Service
Duty	High performance	Liberalism	Tradition
Efficiency	Honor	Loyalty	Well-being

Using your responses and any other general ideas about leadership, identify three to six values that you believe are important for your own leadership identity. You can choose from the list above, or you can list values you generate on your own. In either case, please provide your own personal definition for each of your values.

Values	Definition
1.	
2.	
3.	
4.	
5.	
6.	

Using the reflective activities above, you have been able to identify your leadership assumptions, beliefs, and values. The next step is to put all of this together to create a personal leadership philosophy (PLP). We encourage you to take a few minutes to review your response above. We would then encourage you to take 15-30 minutes to write out a draft of your PLP. It may be helpful to give yourself time to write without any editing. Instead of deleting or editing what you have written, simply write the statement again in another way. Setting a time goal (for example, I will write for 30 minutes without stopping or editing) can be helpful as you try to get ideas out of your head and onto paper or a computer screen. After writing, take some time to edit and refine what you have written. Not everything you write needs to be in your final PLP, and you may also realize important ideas need to be added. Separating writing from editing allows you to make progress without getting stuck writing and re-writing the same sentence.

Below is an example of a Personal Leadership Philosophy. Please treat it as an example; your PLP should reflect your own vision for leadership and should be written in a way consistent with who you are and who you want to become as a leader.

Personal Leadership Philosophy Example 1

- Leadership is a process, not a position
- I strive to use my strengths within my leadership: honesty, creativity, love of learning, and teamwork
- I will ensure people are treated equitably
- I will not be a bystander, and I will speak out to make sure my voice and the voice of those with less power are heard
- I will devote time and energy to become the leader I want to be
- Relationships are the foundation of influence
- I will lead ethically and with moral courage

Personal Leadership Philosophy Example 2

- Leadership is a dynamic social influence process driving progress.
- I am committed to my core values. Core values are the driving force behind my actions and are the foundation of who I am and who I want to become. My core values include integrity, respect, creativity, action, and justice.
 - Integrity: my words and actions are aligned. I am committed to transparency in my decisions and actions.
 - Respect: I care for the well-being of others and myself. Respect includes treating people with compassion and dignity.
 - Creativity: I encourage innovation, creativity, and resourcefulness in others and in myself.
 - Action: Progress is achieved through active commitment and hard work.
 - Justice: I make decisions with thought and consideration. Because justice is not absolute, I strive to do what is right by accepting people as whole beings, with individualized experiences and beliefs.
- I search for clarity by challenging my values, while also recognizing my values are not universal.
- My influence permeates all my communication, and I take ownership of what and how I communicate.
- My leadership involves continuously developing myself and others.

Write your own draft Personal Leadership Philosophy

The Basics of Goal Setting

A vision for your leadership helps motivate your behaviors and actions, but it may also be too abstract to give you a clear path to living up to your vision. Like glasses, a vision provides clarity for everything within view. Within the field of vision, goals can be thought of as the specific object upon which we choose to focus. Goals concentrate and refine what we see so we can focus on certain elements out of the broader picture. Goals can be helpful because they can provide you with specific steps to take to achieve your leadership vision. If your PLP is a beacon representing where you want to be, your goals can be the map to help you get there.

Hope is an important component of goal achievement. Although hope may seem to be an abstract idea, within the field of positive psychology, hope has a very specific meaning, and hope consists of both the willpower and waypower to accomplish goals (Ciarrochi et al., 2015; Snyder et al., 1991). Willpower is the determination to achieve goals, and waypower is the ability to generate different pathways to achieve goals. In other words, someone who has high hope will be motivated to achieve their goals, and they can find many different ways to achieve their goals. One of the best ways to develop hope is to write out goals using the “SMART” (Doran, 1981) format (see Figure 2).

 This image describes the five components of the SMART Goals model. Specific: Identify a tangible outcome that is focused on what you want to achieve. Measurable: define the parameters by which you will evaluate your progress towards the achievement of your goal. Attainable: Draft an outline of the steps you will take to achieve your goal. Your goal should be reasonable to accomplish but challenging enough to ensure development and personal growth - including any potential barriers that may inhibit your success. Relevant: Determine the significance of this objective and identify how it aligns with your personal values to ensure it is appropriate for accomplishing your intended outcome. Time-bound: Establish a time frame for completing this goal to help regulate your motivation towards achievement.

Figure 2: SMART Goals

The SMART goal format helps ensure that goals contain major components that are associated with higher goal success rates. For example, when people set specific goals vs. goals “to do my best,” people with specific goals are more likely to achieve them (Latham & Seijts, 2016). Measurable goals ensure that you can see progress and achievement. Setting specific action steps helps accomplish goals that are challenging but also attainable. Motivation is a key component of accomplishing goals, and identifying why goals are relevant helps you align motivation with goal achievement. Finally, a timeline provides urgency to a goal, supporting the need to continue working to meet the goal before the deadline.

Another factor in the success of goals is having an approach and mastery focus (Van Yperen et al., 2014). *Approach-focused* refers to goals where you are trying to achieve something. This is in contrast to goals where you’re trying to avoid doing something. Consider the following two goals: 1) I will spend 30 minutes editing my paper after I write it, and 2) I will avoid making mistakes in my paper. Goal one is an approach goal, and goal two is an avoidance goal. Approach goals tend to be more motivating because it is clear what defines success.

Mastery-focused refers to goals meeting a specific standard or previous performance. In contrast, a performance goal is focused on performing better than others or peers. Again, let us consider two examples: 1) I will increase my grade from a “B+” to an “A” in my course by the end of the semester, and 2) I will have the best paper in the class. Example one is focused on a specific standard, a grade, and is based on a previous performance standard of “B+,” whereas example two is using peers as the standard. Although both types of goals can lead to positive results, generally, mastery-focused goals are considered better because they promote more prosocial behavior (e.g., sharing resources with others and tolerance for opposing views) compared to performance-focused goals, which can promote more negative feelings (e.g., worry and anxiety) and unethical behaviors (e.g., cheating).

Goal Setting: Developing Leadership & Interpersonal Skills

The next step in the process of becoming the leader you envision in your PLP is to identify specific goals. That said, setting goals for your own leadership and interpersonal skill development may be different from other goals you may have set in the past. For example, setting a goal to achieve a certain grade in a class or to run a marathon have very clear, tangible outcomes. Setting goals for leadership and interpersonal skill development, such as setting goals to develop empathy or better cultural awareness, are more abstract and may require more creativity.

Where to start? This book is filled with specific skills necessary for leadership. For example, communicating with others, developing trust, and conflict resolution are some specific skills that are critical for leadership. While reviewing your PLP, take a few moments to review the skills covered in this textbook, and identify 3-5 skills you would like to focus on developing. It's important to remember that the purpose of goal setting is to provide intentional focus, so even though all the skills in this textbook are important for leadership and are likely elements of your PLP, it's important to prioritize a few as a starting place for your own development.

Leadership & Interpersonal Skills
1.
2.
3.
4.
5.

Now that you have identified the skills you would like to develop, the next step is to identify how. A course project, for example, a service-learning project or group project, are great settings to work on developing your skills. To help illustrate the goal-setting process, we are going to outline interpersonal skill development within a service-learning project, where students spend 20 hours during the semester volunteering at an after-school program, where youths aged 6-12 years old attend for care between the end of the school day and when they go home (usually between 3:30 PM and 5:30 PM).

For this example, the development of active listening as a specific skill is outlined and provided in Figure 3.

 This image provides an example of Active Listening in the SMART Goal Model. Each "SMART" component is contextualized to a goal of improving active listening. Figure 3: Active Listening SMART Goal Setting Example.

Goal Setting: Planning for Obstacles

Hope is an important component of goal success and consists of both willpower and waypower. In this section, we want to discuss waypower or visualizing multiple pathways for goal achievement. People who can visualize many ways to accomplish a goal will be able to overcome obstacles. Let's say, for example, you want to get an "A" on your next written paper, and you intended to spend 60 minutes editing your paper. Unfortunately, you ended up with the flu, preventing you from spending the time you intended to edit your paper. Waypower is about finding many ways to achieve your goal. In this specific example, can you generate other pathways? You might be able to ask your roommate, friend, or parent to edit your paper. Additionally, you could try to rearrange your schedule so that you could free up time before your paper is due. However, we don't have to wait for an obstacle to occur before generating different success pathways.

A *premortem* (Klein, 2007) is an activity that can be applied to any type of project. In short, a premortem asks people to begin by assuming their project has failed and has them generate all the reasons why the project failed. This activity encourages thinking about potential obstacles that could prevent the project from success before it begins. By identifying obstacles, you can start proactively identifying pathways and resources to overcome those obstacles. A premortem activity is a way that you can build resilience, which is known as a way to bounce back to normal or even beyond normality when faced with challenges and adversity (McElravy et al., 2018). As you set your goals for your own leadership development, it can be helpful to identify the obstacles you might face and then plan for how you might overcome those obstacles.

Chapter Summary

To provide an overview of this chapter, Figure 3 illustrates how the PLP and goals fit together on a scale of abstract and intangible to concrete and tangible. The reality is that our assumptions, beliefs, and values may not always be clear to us or something we can

immediately identify; nonetheless, they are foundational to our leadership actions. Taking these abstract ideas and creating a personal leadership philosophy provides an opportunity for more intentionality, where we can actively choose to be a certain type of leader. As we think about how to become the leader we envision, goals provide specificity on prioritizing skill development. We can't develop all skills at once, and goals help clarify priority and progress. Finally, the specific behaviors we display are the most tangible elements of leadership others will experience. This process of bringing the abstract to the concrete creates clarity to our own leadership development.

Figure 3 |

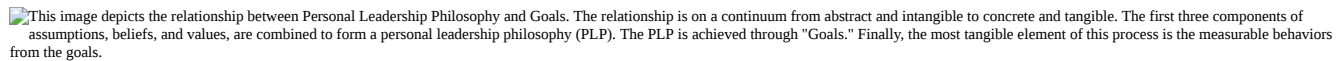
 This image depicts the relationship between Personal Leadership Philosophy and Goals. The relationship is on a continuum from abstract and intangible to concrete and tangible. The first three components of assumptions, beliefs, and values, are combined to form a personal leadership philosophy (PLP). The PLP is achieved through "Goals." Finally, the most tangible element of this process is the measurable behaviors from the goals.

Figure 1: Personal Leadership Philosophy and Goals

ACTIVITY

Exercises

Goal Setting for Your Service-Learning Project

 This image describes the five components of the SMART Goals model. Figure 1: Goal Setting for Your Service-Learning Project

Now that you understand the fundamentals of goal setting, use the following diagram to outline three to five S.M.A.R.T. goals that help you live out your PLP, and use your service-learning project as the context or lab to develop this skill set. Be sure to include all elements of the model in your goals.

Goals	(S)pecific	(M)easurable	(A)ttainable	(R)elevant	(T)ime-Bound
Goal 1					
Goal 2					
Goal 3					
Goal 4					
Goal 5					

REFERENCES

- Den Hartog, D. N., & Verburg, R. M. (1997). Charisma and rhetoric: Communicative techniques of international business leaders. *The Leadership Quarterly*, 8, 355–391. [https://doi.org/10.1016/S1048-9843\(97\)90020-5](https://doi.org/10.1016/S1048-9843(97)90020-5)
- Ciarrochi, J., Parker, P., Kashdan, T. B., Heaven, P. C. L., & Barkus, E. (2015). Hope and emotional well-being: A six-year study to distinguish antecedents, correlates, and consequences. *The Journal of Positive Psychology*, 10(6), 520–532. <https://doi.org/10.1080/17439760.2015.1015154>
- Doran, G. T. (1981). There's a S.M.A.R.T. way to write management's goals and objectives. *Management Review*, 70(11), 35–36. <https://community.mis.temple.edu/mis0855002fall2015/files/2015/10/S.M.A.R.T-Way-Management-Review.pdf>
- Friedman, S. (2008). Define your personal leadership vision. *Harvard Business Review*. <https://hbr.org/2008/08/title>
- Klein, G. (2007). Performing a project premortem. *Harvard Business Review*, 85(9), 18–19. <https://hbr.org/2007/09/performing-a-project-premortem>
- Latham, G. P., & Seijts, G. H. (2016). Distinguished scholar invited essay: Similarities and differences among performance, behavioral, and learning goals. *Journal of Leadership & Organizational Studies*, 23(3), 225–233. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1548051816641874>
- Lord, R. G., & Brown, D. J. (2001). Leadership, values, and subordinate self-concepts. *The Leadership Quarterly*, 12(2), 133–152. [https://doi-org.libproxy.unl.edu/10.1016/S1048-9843\(01\)00072-8](https://doi-org.libproxy.unl.edu/10.1016/S1048-9843(01)00072-8)
- McElravy, L., Matkin, G., & Hastings, L. (2017). How can service-learning prepare students for the workforce? Exploring the potential of positive psychological capital. *Journal of Leadership Education*, 16(3), 97–117. <https://doi.org/10.12806/V16/I3/T1>
- National Archives. (2022, January 28). *The Emancipation Proclamation*. Online Exhibits. <https://www.archives.gov/exhibits/featured-documents/emancipation-proclamation>

Snyder, C. R., Harris, C., Anderson, J. R., Holleran, S. A., Irving, L. M., Sigmon, S. T., Yoshinobu, L., Gibb, J., Langelle, C., & Harney, P. (1991). The will and the ways: Development and validation of an individual-differences measure of hope. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, 60(4), 570–585. <https://doi.org/10.1037/0022-3514.60.4.570>

1 comment on PubPeer (by: Statcheck)

Van Yperen, N. W., Blaga, M., & Postmes, T. (2014). A meta-analysis of self-reported achievement goals and nonself-report performance across three achievement domains (work, sports, and education). *PLoS ONE*, 9, e93594. <https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pone.0093594>

4. Defining My Vision, Setting Personal Goals, and Making Decisions is shared under a CC BY-NC license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by LibreTexts.

5: Nonverbal Communication and Active Listening in Small Groups

Kate D. McCain & Jaclyn S. Marsh

“Nonverbal communication comprises a core element of the interactions between leader and follower...the role of communication for leadership in organizations is indisputable, supporting everyday interaction between supervisors and subordinates” (Gkorezis et al., 2015).

INTRODUCTION

Nonverbal communication and active listening play a vital role in leadership skill development, influencing how we engage in small groups. Organizations can benefit from leaders who utilize effective communication skills—both verbal and, more importantly, nonverbal—to represent their ideas. This chapter will investigate the following questions: How do we communicate with others nonverbally? What are some characteristics of nonverbal communication? How can we listen more effectively? How are our small groups affected by our nonverbal communication and listening? We will define nonverbal communication and understand how to interpret it in our everyday interactions. We will then discuss the ten channels of nonverbal communication. Next, we will describe the six stages of effective listening as they apply to interpersonal relationships and small group situations by understanding the HURIER Model (Brownell, 2012). Lastly, we will focus on connecting nonverbal communication and active listening within the Social Change Model of Leadership.

CHAPTER SPOTLIGHT – By Kate McCain: The Story of Two Friends in Healthcare

Two of my best friends work in healthcare. One is a physical therapist at a rural hospital. The other is a pharmacist at a large metropolitan women’s hospital. I was having dinner with my two friends and listening to them talk about their jobs. They both described two types of experiences in their roles: (a) serving patients and administrative/managerial duties such as organizing schedules and ordering supplies and (b) dealing with issues among co-workers.

As they shared more about their roles, I started asking them questions about leadership. Everything they were discussing connected to working in small groups and leadership skills. The physical therapist discussed working with patients whose first languages are not English and relying heavily on nonverbal communication to understand the patients’ issues and concerns. She also shared how she listens attentively to others to find the best means for treatment outcomes.

The pharmacist, who is in a *service leader* role, discussed how she oversees a group of people and must navigate the complexities of staffing when multiple people ask for time off. She also shared the challenges of listening to all employees on managing staffing for overnight shifts (no one likes to work nights) to ensure the rotations among co-workers are fair. As illustrated by their experiences, nonverbal communication, active listening, and navigating small group challenges are essential leadership skills for many careers.

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

By the end of this chapter, you will be able to...

- define nonverbal communication and identify the ten channels of nonverbal communication.
- interpret nonverbal messages as they pertain to everyday conversation (and in leadership situations).
- identify the six stages of effective listening.
- understand the role of nonverbal communication and active listening as critical interpersonal skills for leadership.

KEYWORDS: Nonverbal communication, active listening, interpersonal leadership skills

Defining Nonverbal Communication

Nonverbal communication is everything we do while communicating that is *not* verbal, including our gestures, facial expressions, and eye movements (Greene et al., 1994; Jandt, 2001). Floyd (2017) defines nonverbal communication as the meaning we convey through our actions without using words and describes five characteristics of nonverbal communication (see Table 5.1).

Table 5.1 | Characteristics of Nonverbal Communication

Characteristic	Description

Characteristic	Description
Nonverbal communication is present in all conversations.	Focusing on what people are saying and how they are saying the words.
Nonverbal communication usually delivers more information than just our verbal word choices.	Researchers have found that we gather 65-70% of our meaning in conversations of our nonverbal clues (Burgoon, et al., 2011).
Nonverbal communication is more believable than verbal communication.	We tend to believe a person's nonverbal cues over what they are saying when there are conflicting messages (Burgoon, et al., 2010).
Nonverbal communication is the primary way we show our emotions.	We can talk about our feelings, but our emotions (e.g., sad, happy, or upset) are visible on our faces (Matsumoto & Hwang, 2013).
Nonverbal communication tells people when and if we are ready to communicate.	When we do not like a conversation, it is evident through our nonverbals that we are unhappy at that moment.

Note: Information presented in this table is adopted from Floyd (2017).

These characteristics represent the role of nonverbal communication in our relationships. We can utilize Floyd's (2017) theory on the characteristics of nonverbal communication to ensure that *what* we are saying and *how* we are saying it is communicating the same message. Overall, it is necessary to remember that nonverbal cues are believed more than our words, and nonverbal communication impacts how we convey meaning in our conversations.

Ten Channels of Nonverbal Communication

Now that we have defined nonverbal communication, let's look at the ten most common ways we use our nonverbals. Table 5.2 outlines how we communicate nonverbally. These ten channels represent how nonverbal communication can strengthen or hinder the interpretations of our verbal messages. By understanding *how* our nonverbals affect our communication, we can be more aware of our communication patterns.

Table 5.2 | Channels of Nonverbal Communication

Method of Communication	Explanation
Facial expressions	- Facial expressions are among the universal forms of nonverbal body language - Universal facial expressions include anger, contempt, disgust, fear, joy, sadness, and surprise
Eye contact	- Eyes play an important role; staring, blinking, and pupil dilation can tell a lot about a person and how someone is feeling - Eye gaze can determine if someone is being honest or deceptive
Body language/ kinesics	- Kinesics is the study of movement used to explain our thoughts or ideas - Hand gestures and body posture all hold nonverbal meanings
Touch/ haptics	- Haptics is the study of touch, which conveys meaning through physical contact - Touch is used to share feelings and relational meanings with others
Vocal behaviors/ paralinguistics	- Paralinguistics is the study of vocal signals beyond the basic verbal message or speech - Vocal pitch, pronunciation, and inflection all influence our interactions with others
Sense of smell	- Smell triggers memories and emotions and can affect how we communicate or receive communication

Method of Communication	Explanation
Use of space/ proxemics	- Proxemics is the study of space; indicating where we choose to stand often represents how we feel about a person - In Western cultures, we use four different spatial zones: intimate, personal, social, and public zones
Physical appearance	- Clothing, hairstyles, tattoos, and other factors affecting appearance are a means of nonverbal communication - Appearance can alter physiological reactions, judgments, and interpretations of others
Time/ chronemics	- Chronemics is the study of the use of time, and it influences perceptions of punctuality, willingness to wait, and interactions - Time can affect lifestyles, daily agendas, speed of speech, and movement
Color	- Research on color psychology has demonstrated that different colors can evoke different moods - The use of color can nonverbally communicate personalities

Note: Information presented in this table is adopted from Floyd (2017).

Nonverbal Communication & Interacting with Others

Think back to the most recent experience you had working in a group or team. Chances are you are working in groups right now in your classes, jobs, or even your service-learning experience. When we interact and communicate with others, we engage in small group situations. The complexity of working with group members or a team is best illustrated by thinking of a group as a system, a set of interconnected parts working together in a changing environment (Littlejohn & Foss, 2008). As group size increases, the complexity of the interaction system increases as well. Consider the following calculations: two group members = two possible interactions; three group members = nine possible interactions; four group members = 28 possible interactions; five group members = 75 possible interactions, and so on (*Business Communication for Success*, 2012). No wonder it can be challenging to schedule meetings and make decisions when working in small groups.

The behavior of one member affects the entire group due to the interconnectedness of system parts, especially if the behavior is disruptive. How do you interpret the nonverbal behavior of a group member who appears distracted on their cell phone during a team meeting? How do you feel when that group member looks up from their phone and asks what is going on in the conversation? As you can see, our nonverbal communication and listening skills play essential roles within our interpersonal and small group interactions. Your ability to communicate effectively or ineffectively can mean success or failure for a group.

Riggio et al. (2003) explain that leaders skilled at communication (including nonverbal skills) are the most effective. For example, when you show genuine interest (both verbally and nonverbally) and actively listen to others' opinions in the group, you exercise supportive communication patterns. The more followers "feel respected by their leaders, the more they will 'return the favor' by being open to their leader's influence" (van Quaquebeke & Eckloff, 2010, p. 352).

As you consider your next steps after college, think about how nonverbal communication will impact your success in future professional positions. For a closer look at how your nonverbals influence your career, you might be interested in reading this article:

Darics, E. (2020). E-leadership or "How to be boss in instant messaging?" The role of nonverbal communication. *International Journal of Business Communication*, 57(1), 3-29. <https://doi.org/10.1177/2329488416685068>

HURIER Model of Active or Effective Listening

This image depicts the stages of active listening. Stages are positioned in a circle with the last stage having an arrow indicated that active listening is a cycle.

An important aspect of nonverbal communication is showing we are effectively listening to others. In 2012, a professor of organizational communication, Judi Brownell, created the HURIER Model of Effective Listening to describe the various stages of listening. Figure 1 illustrates the six stages of engaging in active listening.

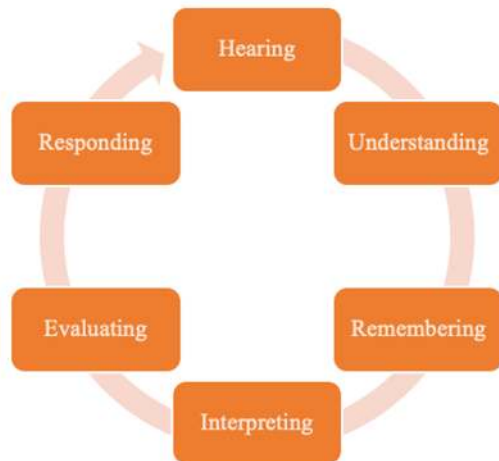


Figure 5.1: Stages of Active Listening

1. **Hearing.** The physical act of perceiving sound. We can hear someone talking, but that does not mean we *listen* to them. First, we physically hear the words but do not necessarily process or understand the words.
2. **Understanding.** We then begin to hear what people are saying and can understand it. Understanding means that we comprehend the meaning of what someone is telling us (Macrae & Bodenhausen, 2001).
3. **Remembering.** We use our memory to help us store information we can retrieve later (Janusik, 2007).
4. **Interpreting.** We move beyond understanding and remembering to interpret the information; this involves interpreting nonverbal cues alongside verbal communication.
5. **Evaluating.** We evaluate the message for credibility and truth behind the communication to decide opinions versus facts. We are also thinking about the context of the communication to evaluate its authenticity.
6. **Responding.** Finally, we respond. Notice that responding is the sixth step and not one of the first steps. We give *feedback* during this stage, both verbally and nonverbally. There are multiple ways of responding depending on the situation and the context.

Active Listening & Interacting with Others

Active listening skills are important when we interact with others. Especially in our digital age, with the increase in technology and global interactions, listening in online contexts actively is a vital skill for building relationships and developing as a leader. Kane (2018) explains that leaders with strong digital communication skills are in high demand. A recent article identified five critical competencies for digital listening by leaders: (1) frequently sharing information, (2) allowing employees to ask questions, (3) asking for input about leaders' ideas, (4) following up on employee suggestions, and (5) demonstrating awareness and appreciation for employee efforts (Cardon et al., 2019). Think about how current events have moved so much of our interactions and communication online. Are you aware of how others are perceiving your nonverbals online? Do you take time to engage in active listening when working with others online? Whether the environment is face-to-face or digital, active listening is an essential interpersonal skill that takes practice.

Connection to the Social Change Model of Leadership

Values of the Social Change Model (SCM) are connected to the concepts of nonverbal communication and active listening in interpersonal relationships and groups. Individual values (*e.g.*, *Consciousness of Self*) refer to people's awareness of their traits, values, and strengths, as well as self-awareness (Fincher, 2009). An individual's awareness of their own communication in terms of nonverbal behaviors and active listening is essential in leadership skill development.

Cilente (2009) explains, "Leadership for social change occurs at the group level" (p. 57). When considering group complexities, group values from the SCM (*i.e.*, *Collaboration, Common Purpose, and Controversy with Civility*) require active listening from all group members and understanding of nonverbal communication. With nonverbal communication channels and active listening strategies in mind, how might you better engage in social change within your relationships and groups?

Summary

As you can see, nonverbal communication and active listening are important interpersonal skills for leadership. These skills are essential for successful communication in interpersonal and small-group settings. Day in and day out, we engage with others. Thus, you must practice your nonverbal behaviors and active listening skills to ensure you are an effective leader while working with others, whether on a small scale in classroom groups or a large scale for social change. What you say and how you say it matters.

QUESTIONS FOR JOURNALING OR DISCUSSION

- Reflect on your service-learning experiences and how they have shaped your understanding of nonverbal communication and active listening. Can you describe a situation where you noticed someone's nonverbal communication during a conversation that influenced your perception? How did their nonverbals impact the conversation?
- Why is it beneficial to use nonverbal communication and active listening in small group situations? What might be the negative consequences for leaders who do not practice these skills? Identify and describe a situation where a leader did/or did not effectively communicate.
- We use turn-requesting gestures to indicate that we wish to speak and turn-denying gestures to indicate that we do not wish to speak. For example, turn-requesting would be probing “what do you think” with an open hand gesture. In contrast, turn-denying would be putting up a hand (i.e., stop) to indicate you are not willing to communicate. How do you find your nonverbals to help (or hinder) your ability to communicate within an interpersonal or small group leadership setting?

ACTIVITIES

Exercises

Video Activity (30 minutes)

TED Talk: Amy Cuddy on Nonverbal Communication (20-minute video). Cuddy's research on body language reveals that we can change other people's perceptions and even our body chemistry by changing the position of our bodies.

https://www.ted.com/talks/amy_cuddy_your_body_language_may_shape_who_you_are



Instructions:

STEP 1: Observe how students sit when they come into the room.

STEP 2: Ask students to record how they are sitting.

STEP 3: Ask students to reflect on three questions; jot them down in notebooks

- Can you ‘fake it til you make it?’
- Do our nonverbals impact how we think/feel about ourselves?
- Can our bodies (posture) change our minds?

STEP 4: Watch the video and openly discuss students' reactions

Practice/Application Activity (Full class period or homework activity)

Observations & Data Gathering. This activity aims to have you observe daily nonverbal communication behaviors (a mini-ethnography), which can be done during class or as an out-of-class homework activity.

Instructions:

STEP 1: Location—Choose a location to sit where you are out of the way, but you can observe interpersonal interactions and nonverbal communication of others. Some locations you may choose are libraries, restaurants, shopping malls, the student center, athletic events, etc.

STEP 2: Observation Notes—Once you have chosen your location, observe the nonverbal communication between observed individuals. Can you identify the type of relationship they may have with one another? Please make detailed observation notes. Your notes may include the setting or environment, location surroundings, noise level, nonverbal communication channels, etc. Your notes should be on a separate sheet of paper and approximately one page.

Observation prompts:

1. Describe the setting chosen for the observation.
2. Describe the interpersonal interaction(s) and nonverbal communication observed. Describe what you saw happening. Some examples could be a couple in an argument, classmates in confusion, a couple in love, etc. What are your conclusions from these observations? What helped you to draw these conclusions?
3. Spend a few moments analyzing and evaluating your observations, then describe your interpretations and reactions.
4. Share any other insights or comments about the observation.

STEP 3: Review the ten nonverbal communication channels (Floyd, 2017) and make notes of where you observed these in action.

STEP 4: Have students discuss their findings in class. What were their observations? How much can we learn from understanding nonverbal communication?

Active Listening Activity

Students will learn how to engage in active listening by practicing their listening skills with a partner. You will hand out a sheet of paper, and one of the students will be the clue giver, and the other will be the clue receiver. The clue giver will be allowed to speak, and the clue receiver will have to follow the instructions to draw the picture that the clue giver tells them to draw from their handout. There are a total of three rounds.

Instructions

STEP 1: With your partner, decide who will be the clue giver and who will be the clue receiver. The clue-giver will be provided a picture. Only the clue-giver can look at the picture. The receiver should not look at the picture.

STEP 2: Using the provided picture, the clue-giver will tell the receiver about the picture, and the clue giver should keep the picture face down until told to look at it.

STEP 3: Only the clue giver can look at the picture and is the ONLY person allowed to speak this first round.

- The clue receiver is not allowed to speak or ask questions.
- After about 5 mins or so, stop and discuss with your partner.

STEP 4: Now switch places as to who is the clue giver and receiver.

- Using a new provided picture, the clue giver will describe it to the receiver.
- For this round, the receiver is allowed to ask clarifying questions—not engage in any dialogue but ask clarifying questions.
- Only the clue giver is allowed to see the picture still.
- After about 5 minutes or so, stop and discuss with your partner.

STEP 5: Have the students select which one will receive and which one will give the clues based on their last two attempts.

- For this last round, you may have a back-and-forth dialogue with your partner.
- Each person can talk openly now, though only the giver is allowed to see the picture still.
- After about 5 mins, stop and prepare to share your thoughts in a large group discussion.

STEP 6: Debrief by discussing which round was “easier, clearer, or best” and why.

- Discuss the importance of active listening; which round represented active listening and why?

REFERENCES

Brownell, J. (2012) *Listening attitudes, principles, and skills* (5th ed.). Pearson.

Burgoon, J. K., Guerrero, L. K., & Manusov, V. (2011). Nonverbal signals. In M. L. Knapp & J. Daly (Eds.), *The Sage handbook of interpersonal communication* (4th ed., pp. 238–282). Sage.

Burgoon, J. K., Guerrero, L. K., & Floyd, K. (2010). *Nonverbal communication*. Routledge.

Business communication for success, v. 1.0. (2012). Saylor Academy. https://saylordotorg.github.io/text_...ess/index.html

Cardon, P. W., Huang, Y., & Power, G. (2019). Leadership communication on internal digital platforms, emotional capital, and corporate performance: The case for leader-centric listening. *International Journal of Business Communication*, 1–27. <https://doi.org/10.1177/2329488419828808>

Cilente, K. (2009.) An overview of the Social Change Model of Leadership Development. In S. R. Komives, W. Wagner, & Associates (Eds.), *Leadership for a better world: Understanding the Social Change Model of Leadership Development*. Jossey-Bass.

Darics, E. (2020). E-leadership or “how to be boss in instant messaging?” The role of nonverbal communication. *International Journal of Business Communication*, 57(1), 3–29. <https://doi.org/10.1177/2329488416685068>

Floyd, K. (2017). *Interpersonal communication* (3rd ed.). McGraw-Hill.

Fincher, J. (2009). Consciousness of self. In S. R. Komives, W. Wagner, & Associates (Eds.), *Leadership for a better world: Understanding the Social Change Model of Leadership Development*. Jossey-Bass.

Gkorezis, P., Bellou, V., & Skemperis, N. (2015). Nonverbal communication and relational identification with the supervisor. *Management Decision*, 53(5), 1005–1022. <https://doi.org/10.1108/md-11-2014-0630>

Greene, M. G., Adelman, R.D., Friedmann, E. & Charon, R. (1994). Older patient satisfaction with communication during an initial medical encounter. *Social Science & Medicine*, 38(9), 1279–1288. [https://doi.org/10.1016/0277-9536\(94\)90191-0](https://doi.org/10.1016/0277-9536(94)90191-0)

Jandt, F. E. (2001). *Intercultural communication: An introduction* (3rd ed.). Sage.

Janusik, L. A. (2007). Building listening theory: The validation of the conversational listening span. *Communication Studies*, 58(2), 139–156. <https://doi.org/10.1080/10510970701341089>

Kane, G. C. (2018, July 9). Common traits of the best digital leaders. *MIT Sloan Management Review blog*. <https://sloanreview.mit.edu/article/...gital-leaders/>

Littlejohn, S. W., & Foss, K. A. (2008). *Theories of human communication*. Waveland Press, Inc.

Macrae, C. N., & Bodenhausen, G. V. (2001). Social cognition: Categorical person perception. *British Journal of Psychology*, 92, 239–255. <https://doi.org/10.1348/000712601162059>

Matsumoto, D., & Hwang, H. S. (2013). Facial expressions. In D. Matsumoto, M. G. Frank, & H. S. Hwang (Eds), *Nonverbal communication: Science and applications* (pp. 15–52). Sage. <https://doi.org/10.4135/9781452244037.n2>

Riggio, R. E., Riggio, H. R., Salinas, C., & Cole, E. J. (2003). The role of social and emotional communication skills in leader emergence and effectiveness. *Group dynamics: Theory, research, and practice*, 7, 83–103. <https://doi.org/10.1037/1089-2699.7.2.83>

van Quaquebeke, N., & Eckloff, T. (2010). Defining respectful leadership: What it is, how it can be measured, and another glimpse at what it is related to. *Journal of Business Ethics*, 91, 343–358. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10551-009-0087-z>

5: Nonverbal Communication and Active Listening in Small Groups is shared under a CC BY-NC license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by LibreTexts.

6: Developing Trust and Being Trustworthy

Hannah M. Sunderman

“Trust is the glue of life. It’s the most essential ingredient in effective communication. It’s the foundational principle that holds all relationships.”

—Stephen Covey

INTRODUCTION

While trust is widely regarded as a critical component of healthy interpersonal relationships, the concept of “trust” can be difficult to define and describe. Some have described trust as launching yourself into the air and knowing someone will catch you, while others view trust as a tree that, once it is cut down, takes much time to regenerate. Although the analogies for trust are boundless, they emphasize one common theme: trust is necessary for relationships. In this chapter, we’ll explore the following questions: What is trust? How is it built? How is it maintained? How is it broken? And, finally, how does trust relate to our well-being and other areas of our life?

CHAPTER SPOTLIGHT

As told by Tori Pedersen, NHRI (formerly known as the Nebraska Human Resources Institute) Mentor

As a freshman in college and a new mentor in NHRI Leadership Mentoring, I was eager to jump into sharing my knowledge and experiences with my mentee. I wanted to hear all about her life as a middle schooler—her challenges and successes. Throughout my first year of mentoring Natalie, I quickly learned that strong relationships are not built overnight. Getting to know someone on a deeper level takes time, and most importantly, it takes trust.

Building trust with a person is not a one-time occurrence, it takes continual investment. As I met with Natalie each week, I made sure to pay attention to what she shared so that I could check in with her as time went on. This commitment to being fully present in our meetings was the foundation of trust that proved to Natalie I was there for her. The act of building trust can take on many forms. It was more than just listening during our meetings; it was pushing her to dig deeper into our conversations while respecting when she was not comfortable sharing. It was being vulnerable with her about my challenges, this way she saw me as relatable—a fellow human being full of flaws.

As a mentor, it was easy to want to see my mentee grow in the ways I envision. I have learned, though, that I needed to meet my mentee where she was and push her to grow, not in my image, but in her own direction. Respecting these differences and celebrating them was crucial to building a strong relationship centered around trust. Ultimately, small moments matter, such as my mentee sharing her dreams or telling me about a fight with a friend. It was easy to wish for big, life-altering conversations, but the small moments where someone chooses to be vulnerable and to trust you are the ones that make all the difference.

Learning Objectives

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

By the end of this chapter, you will be able to...

- define trust.
- discover the effects of trust.
- analyze the process of building and maintaining trust.
- connect vulnerability and self-monitoring to trust.
- evaluate how trust can be broken and the subsequent effects on individuals.

KEYWORDS: Trust, vulnerability, trustworthiness, self-disclosure, self-monitoring, building trust

Defining Trust

Before we discuss the effects and processes associated with trust, let’s begin by defining it. **Interpersonal trust** “encompasses one’s willingness to accept vulnerability based on the expectation regarding the behavior of another party that will produce some positive outcome in the future” (Krueger & Meyer-Lindenberg, 2019, p. 92). In more simple language, trust is “choosing to risk making something you value vulnerable to another person’s actions” (Feltman, 2011, p. 7). For example, trusting that another member in a group project will fulfill their portion of the assignment by the deadline.

Distrust, on the other hand, is defined as the belief that “what is important to me is not safe with this person in this situation (or any situation)” (Feltman, 2011, p. 8). When we’re with someone we trust, we feel safe and able to be open. On the contrary, when we’re with someone we have not built trust with, we might feel a need to protect ourselves. The emotions connected to trust are care, open-handedness, and curiosity, while the feelings related to distrust are resignation, bitterness, and fear. When experiencing trust, we are prone to cooperation and collaboration, open communication, supporting others, thinking critically about our behaviors, and expecting the best from people and situations. When experiencing distrust, we are likely to be defensive, blame and shame others, judge ourselves and others, withhold information, and expect the worst from people and situations.

Choosing trust or distrust has been described as a risk assessment or a social dilemma. In other words, what is the likelihood that the other person will support or harm you, and to what extent do you make yourself vulnerable to their actions? Neuroscience supports the perspective of trust as a risk assessment. Specifically, reward networks in our brains “determine the anticipated reward for trusting another person” (Krueger & Meyer-Lindenberg, 2019, p. 94), while the salience network ties negative feelings to the risk of betrayal by another person. Our brains figure out context-based strategies for trust through the central-executive network, as well as relationship-based trustworthiness (e.g., trusting a partner) through the default-mode network. In sum, trust is not only something we feel in our relationships, but it is also something that occurs in our brains.

Discovering The Effects of Trust

Over the past half a century, trust has surfaced as a significant predictor of constructs like job satisfaction, job performance, and organizational commitment (Dirks & Ferrin, 2001; Flaherty & Pappas, 2000). At an organizational level, trust is positively related to revenue and profit (Davis et al., 2000). Looking at a younger age group, interpersonal trust has been found to significantly influence prosocial behavior among college students (Guo, 2017). Prosocial behavior is defined as actions that intend to help another person or group, such as volunteering or helping (Eisenberg & Mussen, 1989). This means that college students with more harmonious and trusting interpersonal relationships are more likely to engage in behavior such as assisting someone who needs help, sharing their knowledge/resources, or working with others to achieve a shared goal.

Outside of college, “trust is widely considered fundamental for the recovery of trauma survivors by enabling them to effectively manage conflict in relationships and establish mutually cooperative interactions” (Bell et al., 2019, p. 1042). Within the medical field, doctor-patient trust has been connected to increased patient satisfaction and compliance with medical advice, such as medication (Chandra et al., 2018). Finally, as stated by Krueger and Meyer-Lindenberg (2019), “Trust pervades nearly every social aspect of our daily lives, and its disruption is a significant factor in mental illness” (p. 92). For example, people who experience a mental illness such as schizophrenia can have a difficult time building and maintaining trust (Fett et al., 2012). As you can see, whether we’re discussing organizations, college students, or the medical field, the effects of trust are both broad and deep.

Analyzing The Process of Building and Maintaining Trust

As stated by John Gottman, a psychological researcher and clinician,

Trust is built in very small moments, which I call ‘sliding door’ moments. In any interaction, there is a possibility of connecting... or turning away... One such moment is not important, but if you’re always choosing to turn away, then trust erodes in a relationship—very gradually, very slowly. (Greater Good Science Center, 2011).

Gottman refers to small, trust-building experiences as “sliding door” moments, named after the movie *Sliding Doors*, which alternates between two storylines that demonstrate two different paths the main character’s life could have taken depending on whether or not she caught a train.

Building upon the idea that trust is built over time in small moments, Feltman (2011) shares a model in which the choice to trust is comprised of four distinct aspects of how a person might act (see Figure 6.1). The four aspects are as follows:

- **Sincerity**—the assessment that a person is honest, they are true to their word and their word is true, their opinions are valid and supported by evidence (e.g., a manager outlines the three largest obstacles facing a group and shares a two-part strategy grounded in research for overcoming them)
- **Reliability**—the assessment of how well a person keeps commitments (e.g., a friend says they’ll reach out to you in a week to schedule a time to get together and they do)
- **Competence**—the assessment that a person has the required skills, knowledge, and resources to do what they are supposed to do (e.g., a social media chairperson for a campus organization knows how to build a social media plan)
- **Care**—the assessment of how much a person is concerned with the interests of others as opposed to being exclusively motivated by self-interest (e.g., a friend tells you about the opportunity to apply for a competitive scholarship for which they are also

applying)

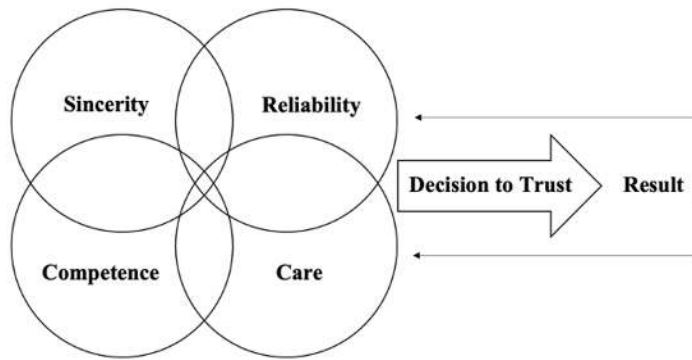


Figure 6.1: Model of Trust Adapted from Feltman (2011)

Collectively, these four aspects of trust lead us to either choose to trust someone or choose not to trust someone. When we choose to trust someone, we monitor the outcome, asking ourselves questions such as, “Were the results positive? Did they honor our trust?” If the answer to these questions is “yes,” our assessment of the other individual continues to grow, and we view them as more sincere, more reliable, more competent, and/or more caring.

Closely connected to building trust is the concept of vulnerability. Vulnerability is defined as risk uncertainty or emotional exposure (Brown, 2015). To use a previous metaphor, if vulnerability is launching yourself into the air, trust is knowing someone will catch you. Trust fuels our vulnerability, and vulnerability fuels our trust. In other words, vulnerability is critical to building trust (as evidenced by the definition of trust we discussed previously). We must be honest with others for them to know we are sincere and that we care. Likewise, trust allows us to be vulnerable. Having an idea that someone will respond to our vulnerability with kindness (i.e., a positive outcome) provides us with the sense of safety and security required to self-disclose. As such, trust and vulnerability are iterative processes, building upon each other to foster strong relationships. As trust builds in an interpersonal relationship, so does our willingness to be vulnerable. As vulnerability occurs in our interpersonal relationships, trust builds.

How Trust Can Be Broken

While trust is critical to interpersonal relationships, it can also be difficult to maintain. Most of us could likely think of an experience where we lost trust in a friend, family member, or co-worker. Research has revealed that interpersonal trust is most often lost “when the trusted individual lied or did not follow through with what they were expected to do” (Hupcey & Miller, 2006, p. 1136). While a few participants in the research study described a situation in which trust has been lost all at once (e.g., a partner who has an affair), the majority of participants shared that interpersonal trust was lost slowly over time (e.g., friend not listening to you, ignoring your texts, etc.). In other words, trust is like a brick wall. We build interpersonal trust by gradually adding bricks. Likewise, we most frequently lose trust by taking apart the wall brick-by-brick. Once in a while, the loss of trust occurs more like a wrecking ball slamming against the wall and scattering many bricks at once.

When we experience a loss of trust, some individuals believe that trust cannot be rebuilt; however, the majority of people believe trust can be rebuilt through a slow and long process (Hupcey & Miller, 2006). When trust is lost, the first step is a sincere apology in which a person does the following (Lewicki et al., 2016):

- Expresses regret
- Explains what went wrong
- Takes responsibility
- Declares remorse
- Shares how they will make it right
- Asks for forgiveness

After a sincere apology, trust may be rebuilt through the intentional and consistent implementation of the four aspects of trust: sincerity, reliability, competence, and care (see Figure 1; Flaherty & Pappas, 2000).

Notably, a loss of trust in one relationship impacts other relationships. For example, individuals who are victims of interpersonal trauma, defined as a traumatic experience caused deliberately by another person (e.g., emotional neglect), are twice as likely to develop post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD) when compared to individuals who experience accidental trauma (e.g., a natural disaster) (Charuvastra & Cloitre, 2008), emphasizing the critical role interpersonal trust plays in our lives.

Connecting Trust to the Social Change Model

Commitment, a value of the Social Change Model (SCM), is the goal-directed investment of time and energy into the process of leadership development (Higher Education Research Institute, 1996). Likewise, trust often requires an investment of time and energy. The two concepts, commitment and trust, are inextricably linked. As described by the Higher Education Research Institute (1996), “Commitment goes hand in hand with trustworthiness. Trust involves a certain amount of risk since it takes some degree of initial trust to join with others... That initial trust can be sustained only through commitment, and commitment is strengthened in turn as trust is established and common purpose is defined” (p. 43). Trust in our interpersonal relationships is necessary for building committed groups and teams that can achieve meaningful change.

In sum, trust is necessary for interpersonal relationships. When we choose or experience trust, we experience care, open-handedness, and curiosity; however, when we choose or experience distrust, we experience resignation, bitterness, and fear. We can build trust over time by being sincere, reliable, competent, and showing care (Flaherty & Pappas, 2000). Consider how you might use what we discussed throughout the current chapter to improve trust in your own relationships by processing how you build relationships with friends, family members, classmates, and coworkers.

QUESTIONS FOR JOURNALING OR DISCUSSION

- Reflect on a trusting relationship in your own life and chart the development of trust over time. When did it start? How did it grow? What were the high points? When did it “dip,” and how did it recover from the “dips”? Where might trust in this relationship go from here (i.e., how can it keep growing)? How can you apply what you’ve learned from this relationship to other relationships?
- Reflect on a current or past relationship in which trust was fractured, and chart the change in trust over time. Why was trust broken? Did it happen slowly over time or was it one main moment? What emotions accompanied the fracture of trust? How has it affected you, this relationship, and your other relationships?
- Through a lens of trust and commitment, analyze a group/team of which you’ve been a member. What level of trust and commitment did this group/team possess? How were trust and commitment connected? How did trust and commitment influence the effectiveness of this group/team?

ACTIVITIES

Classroom Activity Video Exercise

Watch the following video of Dr. John Gottman explaining how trust is built – <https://youtu.be/rgWnadSi91s>

- Discuss the following questions: What surprised, encouraged, or challenged you in this video? How does Dr. Gottman explain “sliding door moments”? What is a “sliding door moment” from your own life (encourage students to think about their relationships with their friends or family?)
- Consider your trustworthiness. When have you been trustworthy? When have you not? How can you improve your trustworthiness?

Classroom Activity Writing Exercise

- Have students do one of the first two journaling prompts in class by graphing trust in a relationship and ask them to share in small groups. Students can share as much or as little as they want. Guide students through small group sharing with structured questions (see questions above)

Case Study on Trust

- Read the following article about the England football team: <https://www.theguardian.com/football/2018/jul/10/psychology-england-football-team-change-your-life-pippa-grange>
- Consider the following questions: What stood out to you in the article? How did the article demonstrate the power of trust? Based on the content of this class, what else might help the football team build trust? Consider a time when you’ve been on a team; how did your group/team compare to the England football team in terms of trust? How might your/team build a culture of trust?

REFERENCES

Bell, V., Robinson, B., Katona, C., Fett, A. K., & Shergill, S. (2019). When trust is lost: The impact of interpersonal trauma on social interactions. *Psychological Medicine*, 49(6), 1041–1046. <https://doi.org/10.1017/s0033291718001800>

- Brown, B. (2015). *Daring greatly: How the courage to be vulnerable transforms the way we live, love, parent, and lead*. Penguin.
- Chandra, S., Mohammadnezhad, M., & Ward, P. (2018). Trust and communication in a doctor-patient relationship: A literature review. *Journal of Health Communication*, 3(3), 36. <https://doi.org/10.4172/2472-1654.100146>
- Charuvastra, A., & Cloitre, M. (2008). Social bonds and posttraumatic stress disorder. *Annual Review of Psychology*, 59(1), 301–328. <https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev.psych.58.110405.085650>
- Davis, J. H., Schoorman, F. D., Mayer, R. C., & Tan, H. (2000). The trusted general manager and business unit performance: Empirical evidence of a competitive advantage. *Strategic Management Journal*, 21(5), 563–576. [https://doi.org/10.1002/\(sici\)1097-0266\(200005\)21:5<563::aid-smj99>3.0.co;2-0](https://doi.org/10.1002/(sici)1097-0266(200005)21:5<563::aid-smj99>3.0.co;2-0)
- Dirks, K. T., & Ferrin, D. L. (2001). The role of trust in organizational settings. *Organization science*, 12(4), 450–467. <https://doi.org/10.1287/orsc.12.4.450.10640>
- Eisenberg, N., & Mussen, P. H. (1989). *The roots of prosocial behavior in children*. Cambridge University Press.
- Feltman, C. (2011). *The thin book of trust: An essential primer for building trust at work*. Thin Book Publishing.
- Fett, A. K. J., Shergill, S. S., Joyce, D. W., Riedl, A., Strobel, M., Gromann, P. M., & Krabbendam, L. (2012). To trust or not to trust: The dynamics of social interaction in psychosis. *Brain*, 135(3), 976–984. <https://doi.org/10.1093/brain/awr359>
- Flaherty, K. E., & Pappas, J. M. (2000). The role of trust in salesperson—sales manager relationships. *Journal of Personal Selling & Sales Management*, 20(4), 271–278. <https://doi.org/10.1080/08853134.2000.10754247>
- Greater Good Science Center. (2011). *John Gottman: How to build trust* [Video]. YouTube. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=rgWnadSi91s>
- Guo, Y. (2017). The influence of social support on the prosocial behavior of college students: The mediating effect based on interpersonal trust. *English Language Teaching*, 10(12), 158–163. <https://doi.org/10.5539/elt.v10n12p158>
- Higher Education Research Institute. (1996). *A Social Change Model of Leadership Development* (Version III). UCLA. <https://www.heri.ucla.edu/PDFs/pubs/ASocialChangeModelofLeadershipDevelopment.pdf>
- Hupcey, J. E., & Miller, J. (2006). Community dwelling adults' perception of interpersonal trust vs. trust in health care providers. *Journal of Clinical Nursing*, 15(9), 1132–1139. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1365-2702.2006.01386.x>
- Krueger, F., & Meyer-Lindenberg, A. (2019). Toward a model of interpersonal trust drawn from neuroscience, psychology, and economics. *Trends in neurosciences*, 42(2), 92–101. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.tins.2018.10.004>
- Lewicki, R. J., Polin, B., & Lount, R. B. (2016). An Exploration of the Structure of Effective Apologies. *Negotiation and Conflict Management Research*, 9(2), 177–196. <https://doi.org/10.1111/ncmr.12073>

6: *Developing Trust and Being Trustworthy* is shared under a CC BY-NC license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by LibreTexts.

CHAPTER OVERVIEW

7: Perceptions are Only From My Point of View

7.1: Diversity and Inclusion

7: Perceptions are Only From My Point of View is shared under a [CC BY-NC](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by LibreTexts.

7.1: Diversity and Inclusion

Gina S. Matkin & Helen Abdali Soosan Fagan

INTRODUCTION

In the Social Change Model of Leadership, Collaboration is defined as “Working with others in a common effort by capitalizing on varying perspectives and the power of diversity” (see Table 1 in the Introduction Chapter). This group-level value in the SCM model is essential if we want to work toward common goals in a way that values all voices.

Diversity and inclusion have never been more important or talked about issues than they are today. With the connectedness of our world via social media, video conferencing, news outlets, and other sources, we instantly hear what is happening the moment it occurs. This kind of connectedness requires a new lens through which to view our world and consider how our own identity plays a role in our perceptions of it. Additionally, as our world becomes more complex and connected, we need new ways to look at and talk about the world in less divisive and more inclusive ways.

This chapter will lead us on a journey to consider who we are at the many levels of our identity, how we can come from a place of knowing ourselves to better seeing and understanding others, and how we can challenge ourselves to shift our perspectives to see differences in a new and more holistic way to create more inclusive environments that welcome and value everyone!

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES:

By the end of this chapter, you will be able to...

- define diversity and explain its application to your own identity.
- define inclusion and explain its application to your own identity.
- describe the various parts of your own identity and how you experience them as either advantaging or disadvantaging you.
- apply your understanding of diversity and inclusion as they relate to you as an emerging leader in fostering collaboration and leading a diverse group or team to a common purpose.

KEYWORDS: Diversity, inclusion, identity, inclusive leadership, privilege, marginalization

It is easy to look at the world through our own lens and draw conclusions based on who we are and what we have experienced. This chapter challenges us to go beyond the “known” and into a more challenging territory where we seek to see the world, not as we are but as *it* is.

This may sound simple to do, but it requires us to both listen openly and be willing to learn from those around us. We often tell our students that there are two important things to remember when engaging in discussions where we might have a different opinion or perspective:

- *Listening to you* does not mean I agree.
- *Learning from you* does not mean I will change my mind...but I might.

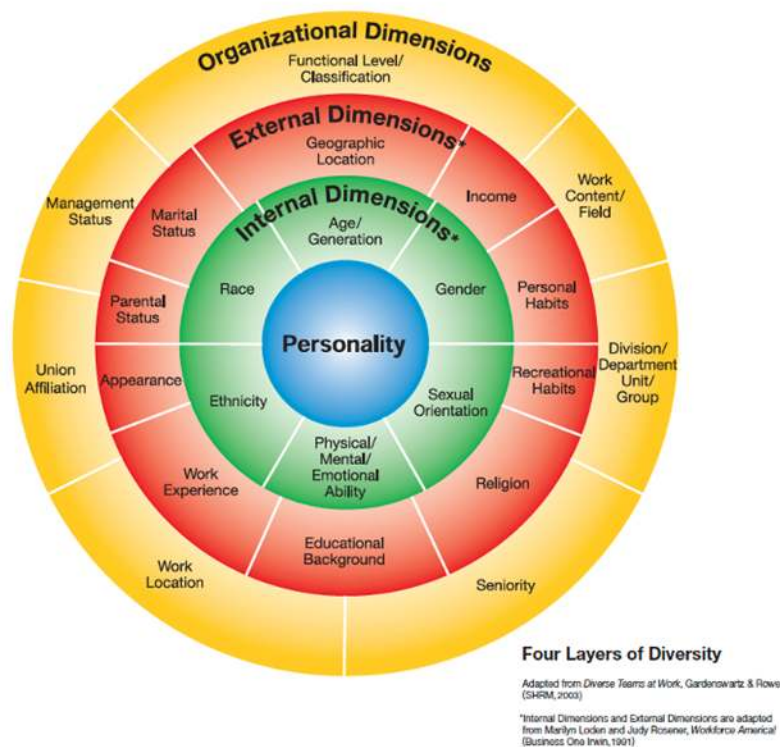
Students tell us that these two statements, when taken to heart, open up a kind of spaciousness in the room where assumptions can fall away, and we can really hear each other. Often our judgment or reaction to others who are different from us is based on fear. It might be fear of what others will think if I listen and do not openly disagree. It might be protecting a value that I hold dear. Either way, if we face our fear or discomfort, there is so much to learn!

This chapter on diversity and inclusion focuses on helping us see differences in a more holistic and positive way. We present you with ways to consider and welcome difference. This starts by examining who you are. We believe the only true way to value differences in others is to be completely open and comfortable with who you are! Being authentically “you” actually helps others be more authentically who they are when they are with you. This also includes the recognition that who we are may offer some advantages (often termed “privilege”) or disadvantages (sometimes called “marginalization”) depending on where we are and who we are surrounded by. Being aware of both our privileges and where we may be marginalized may help us be more skilled at creating spaces where others feel both welcomed and truly seen!

The Four-Layer Model of Diversity

The first model we want to introduce you to is the Four-Layer Model of Diversity. Think about the last time you heard the term “diversity.” What was the setting? What did you think was meant by this term? We define diversity as simply the “mix of

differences.” Often we think of these differences as those you can observe, but there is much more to diversity and our “mix of differences” than meets the eye. *Diverse Teams at Work* (Gardenswartz & Rowe, 2003) depicts diversity by looking at both the internal and external dimensions. This model, originally presented by Marilyn Loden and Judy Rosener (1991) in their book, *Workforce America*, illustrates diversity as far beyond what we can observe. This model helps us to see the numerous dimensions in which human beings are different. Diversity is the reality that those differences exist between us. Put quite simply, diversity is the many ways human beings are similar and different. These differences become the layers through which we experience the world, and the world experiences us (see Figure 7.1.1). While it is evident that human beings are similar and different in many ways, all differences are not equal. We cannot deny the fact that race, ethnicity, gender, age, and sexual orientation are topics that have been challenging humanity for centuries.



Note: Image used with permission.

Figure 7.1.1: The Four Layers of Diversity: Adapted with permission from *Diverse Teams at Work*, Gardenswartz & Rowe (SHRM, 2003)
 *Internal Dimensions and External Dimensions are adapted from Marilyn Loden and Judy Rosener, *Workforce America* (Business One Irwin, 1991)

At the core (blue) is personality. This core drives much of the connection we sense when we first begin to interact with people who think like us, process information like us, and manage their lives like us. This layer is the beginning of and often the most overlooked layer of diversity.

The next level (green) depicts the internal dimensions considered by Gardenswartz and Rowe (2003) as “powerful shapers of opportunities, access, and expectations” (p.32). These move our understanding of diversity beyond the central core of personality to the six internal dimensions of diversity that, for the most part, we do not choose or control, yet they have a powerful effect on our behavior, attitudes, and opportunities in organizations and communities. Briefly described, these six dimensions are:

- Age – generational differences between us drive our expectations of work, family, life, loyalty, security, etc. Diving into age differences helps us to understand that not all people have the same perspectives. It also helps us understand that while age certainly helps shape our perspective, it does not confine us to a particular way of thinking.
- Gender – While the authors were referring to biological sex when they created this model, the word sex and gender continue to be confused and used synonymously by many. While helping you understand the differences between sex and gender is beyond the scope of this chapter, it is important to recognize that differences exist and that conforming or not conforming to gender norms societally prescribed by one’s sex has become an important topic in diversity and inclusion discussions.

- Race – Contrary to popular belief, we do not live in a color-blind society, nor should it be our goal. Human differences, often focused solely on the color of one's skin, have continued to limit human beings' appreciation of differences. The term race began to be used during colonization and expanded with each century since then. Race is described as a social construct used to categorize visual differences in the color of skin, slant and roundness of eyes, the width of the nose, texture of hair, etc. (See this 2021 article from Braverman and Dominguez in *Frontiers in Public Health* for an in-depth look at this: <https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC8452910/pdf/fpubh-09-689462.pdf>).
- Ethnicity – Differences connected to one's ancestral origins (national and/or tribal) are the differences that make up the differences in ethnicity. Often people confuse ethnicity and race. Differences in ethnicity often lead to differences in language, celebrations, and what is considered "cultural"; however, culture is broader than ethnicity. Culture is made up of beliefs, behaviors, attitudes, and expectations that humans consider "normal" in assessing others. Culture begins to take shape in a family, which is operating in the confines of a nation. While national and ethnic cultures are generally the place we begin to think about culture, they are not the only layers of culture.
- Physical/Mental/Emotional Abilities – Physical, mental, and emotional abilities differ between human beings. While the original model focused on physical abilities, for the purposes of our conversation, we will think of abilities in a much broader way to include physical and cognitive abilities, as well as neurodivergence.
- Sexual Orientation – Humans differ widely when it comes to sexual orientation, and that has continued to expand over the past decade. The key factor is that not all humans are heterosexual and if people judge each other based on sexual orientation, it erodes trust and teamwork, and does not allow open authenticity in identities to emerge.

Identity Activity: Let's make this personal!

Consider this:

- What aspects of your internal dimensions of identity (age, race, gender, sexual orientation, etc.) do you most identify with?
- Are there any aspects of identity that you do not feel safe/comfortable revealing or discussing in some situations or settings? Why?

Take a moment to list as many answers to the question, "Who am I?" as come to mind in 2–3 minutes (even beyond the internal dimensions). Notice what you put on the list and what might be missing (what did you not think of right away). Now ask yourself if you would have created the same list if you were asked to share it publicly in a group, class, family setting, etc. If the lists would be different, why?

As you look back over these lists, consider the parts of your identity that you feel benefit you in some way and those that might create challenges or even barriers (judgment, misperceptions, assumptions, etc.).

Now consider situations when you have been more aware (or less aware) of these benefits and challenges. How do you think others experience their own identities and navigate those? Considering your own and then others' identities and experiences can go a long way toward greater understanding and empathy.

There are two additional layers to this model: the external layer of differences, which includes things such as income level (socioeconomic status), religion, appearance, etc., and the organizational layer of differences, which includes work field, seniority, etc. In this chapter, we are mainly focused on the internal dimensions, but you can easily see how these additional layers add complexity to our identity and how we experience it.

In learning about the four-layer model of diversity, we can see that human beings are all very complex and that we all belong in the discussions around diversity. Diversity is not about only one group. It is about all human beings. In fact, we all possess a multitude of identities based on race, gender, ethnicity, socioeconomic status, physical/mental/emotional abilities, etc. We are not just one thing. This concept can be better understood by exploring the term "intersectionality." While a conversation about intersectionality is beyond the scope of this chapter, you can learn more about what it means and find some additional resources at this website (Flowers, 2019): <https://www.edi.nih.gov/blog/communities/intersectionality-part-one-intersectionality-defined>

How we navigate the differences is what helps us succeed or fail at feeling a part of the world around us while still feeling free to be who we truly are. We term this "inclusion." We will learn more about this in the section that follows.

Inclusion: It's More Than You Think

You may have heard talk of "inclusion" or "inclusive leadership" recently. This term does not replace talking about "diversity" but rather moves us to the next step. While diversity is, in essence, about the mix of differences, inclusion is about bringing differences together. It is important to note that diversity is not something that describes a single individual but rather how a group, team,

workplace, or community can be diverse if people from various racial, ethnic, sexual orientation, and/or other identity groups are represented.

Inclusion is about more than just representation. Inclusion is about how we engage with each other and who has access to resources, decision-making, etc. Essentially it is about connection and voice! Is everyone included in decision-making? Does everyone feel heard and valued? Does everyone feel that they can bring *ALL* of who they are to the workplace, organization, classroom, or community? These are a few of the questions that we have to ask in order to gauge whether we are creating inclusive environments.

We often think that when people feel a sense of connection of belongingness, then inclusion has been achieved. This is only partly true. Belongingness is an important component of inclusion, but it does not tell the whole story.

Lynn Shore and colleagues (2011) developed a model to help us understand inclusion in a more holistic way. This model is based on two needs that humans have: the need for *belongingness* and the need for *uniqueness* (Brewer, 1991). Shore and colleagues used this concept to create a guide for a better understanding of how inclusion works. Shore's model identifies the two needs and explains what a person might experience based on the presence, absence, or lack of balance in both belongingness and uniqueness (See Figure 2).

"In inclusive workplaces, people can be fully themselves, striving to be their best, without fear or without a sense that they must hide or become someone else." (Ferdman, 2018, para. 4)

Table 7.1.1 | Shore et al., Inclusion Framework (2011)

	Low Belongingness	High Belongingness
Low Value in Uniqueness	Exclusion Individual is not treated as an organizational insider with unique value in the work group but there are other employees or groups who are insiders.	Assimilation Individual is treated as an insider in the work group when they conform to organizational/dominant culture norms and downplay uniqueness.
High Value in Uniqueness	Differentiation Individual is not treated as an organizational insider in the work group but their unique characteristics are seen as valuable and required for group/organization success.	Inclusion Individual is treated as an insider and also allowed/encouraged to retain uniqueness within the work group.

For example, if a person is feeling that they do not belong and that their unique characteristics are not seen or valued, they experience "*exclusion*." Conversely, if a person feels a sense of belongingness AND also feels that their uniqueness is valued and encouraged, they experience "*inclusion*." It is important to note that belongingness paired with the absence of valuing uniqueness or individuality can create an environment of "*assimilation*" where a person feels they must conform to the group norms in order to continue to be accepted. This is what the authors of this chapter call a "false sense of inclusion." Finally, if a person feels that they are valued for what they can contribute or bring that is unique but that they are not really accepted, it can lead to "*differentiation*," where the person ultimately feels used for their skills and talents but not seen as a member of the group or team.

This model offers an important contribution in helping us to see that inclusion and inclusive environments go beyond belongingness and require something much more complex. As a leader, your team or group will be much stronger if you carefully consider both belonging and uniqueness.

Building on Shore et al.'s (2011) model, Fagan et al. (2022) conducted an extensive review to determine how leaders create inclusion for followers. From this review, a list of seven "attributes" of inclusive leaders emerged. These were:

- Authentic Leadership
- Changemaker
- Collaborative
- Commitment to diversity and cultural competence
- Ideals
- Offering follower support

- Openness

When the seven attributes are acted upon, leaders are able to have impacts on followers that create more inclusive environments. It should be noted that the mix of these attributes is important as some may foster belongingness while not encouraging uniqueness. They state,

We believe that while some impacts may relate more toward belongingness instead of uniqueness—such as increased organizational commitment—and are beneficial for overall inclusion, inclusive leaders should be able to recognize the impacts they create as relating to both uniqueness and belongingness. (Fagan, et al., 2022, p. 101)

This observation is important in that it may feel good to help another person connect and feel as if they belong; however, if a person feels they have to conform and cannot be themselves, they will not experience true inclusion.

Scenario 1

Halle was hired by Brave Marketing company. She was the best candidate because of several successful campaigns with a rapper who was expanding his reach into clothing. Halle is the only female and the youngest person on this team. While she has been told her work is great, every time the team gets together after work, they don't include her. And during side conversations, she is not engaged by other team members, and when she tries to engage with them, they shy away from her. Her unique talents are appreciated, yet she still feels like she made the wrong decision in joining this marketing firm because she really doesn't feel like she belongs.

Do you think Halle feels valued for her contributions to the team?

Do you think she feels she is accepted as a member of the team?

Is Halle experiencing true Inclusion? If not, what is missing, and what could the team do differently to truly help her feel included?

We can begin to notice in ourselves and in our groups, classes, and other environments when inclusion is happening and when it is not. At times, noticing may be all you do, as it may or may not feel safe to intervene or ask for support. At other times, you may be able to advocate for yourself or others to make sure your group is being truly inclusive.

Reflection

Have you ever been in a group where you felt that you had to adapt to the norms of the group in order to be liked or accepted? If so, you have been experiencing an “assimilation environment.” This environment keeps us from being able to bring our full selves and our unique perspectives and ideas to the group. It essentially “silences” the person who feels they must conform in order to be accepted. Ask yourself how this would make you feel and whether you would want to continue to be part of the group if you experienced this “silencing.”

As you grow and develop in your awareness, you may find that you develop the skills and comfort level to help make the groups and other environments in which you live and work become more inclusive.

Scenario 2

Claire recently completed a class in diversity that was part of her leadership minor. Before the class, she had never thought of herself as a person who is uniquely positioned to bridge differences because she is biracial and her parents are from two different countries. During the class she gained a level of self-awareness, but was still trying to figure out what that meant for her.

Recently, during a conversation with her roommates about Disney movies, the topic of a black Ariel came up. Her roommates, who are both white, felt that having a black Ariel ruined the movie for them, and stole their childhood memories of being a mermaid. Claire could feel herself getting sad, and yet found herself unable to speak up. Claire was thinking, what about the millions of little black girls who also dreamed of being a mermaid? It sure would have been nice to have that when she was their age.

Part of the challenge of being biracial was that so many people around her made her feel like she didn't fit in. She wasn't black enough to be with the black kids, and she wasn't white enough to be with the white kids. When she was with her cousins on her mom's side, she stood out because of her skin color. When she was with her cousins on her dad's side, she stood out because of her skin color.

Now, with her roommates, she had at least found a bond over time. She wanted to scream at her roommates to try to help them see how their words were making her feel. She felt bad for even thinking that way and didn't know how to share her thoughts, so she just listened and nodded. She wanted to help them understand but didn't want to seem too different.

- What is Claire experiencing with her roommates? Do you think she feels that her uniqueness is recognized and valued?
- How might the roommates have approached the conversation differently to make sure that all voices felt comfortable expressing their views?

QUESTIONS FOR JOURNALING OR DISCUSSION

How do I feel when I am not fully included in a group but want to be?

1. What is it like to feel like I *belong* to a group, but not feel safe being my *unique* self (assimilation)?
2. What is it like to feel that my *uniqueness* is needed to accomplish something but that, otherwise, I do not really feel as if I *belong* as a member of the group (differentiation)?

How can I, as a group member or a leader, help others feel truly included?

1. What questions can I ask?
2. How can I balance helping someone feel that they belong AND that their uniquenesses are valued as well?

Activity

Comfort with Differences

Part 1: Assessing Your Comfort with Differences

If we pause and really reflect, we will know that we truly are more comfortable with some groups than others. Dr. Fagan sometimes likes to ask her students: “Who would you be most afraid to bring home as your future spouse?” The reason for the question is to get students to be honest about their level of comfort/discomfort with certain groups. Don’t feel bad. Everyone has varying levels of experience and comfort/discomfort. It is part of being human. The key to being effective as a leader is to be honest enough with yourself that you learn to manage it.

Directions: Think about each dimension of diversity and rate the level of comfort you feel in dealing with people different from you in that dimension.

Table 7.1.1 | Adapted from *Diverse Teams at Work*, Lee Gardenswartz and Anita Rowe, Irwin Professional Publishing, 2003. Used with permission.

	High	Medium	Low	How discomfort shows itself
Age				
Gender				
Sexual Orientation				
Physical/Emotional/Psychological Ability				
Ethnicity				
Race				
Geographic Location				
Different socio-economic status				
Personal Habits				
Recreational Habits				
Religion				
Educational Background				
Appearance				

	High	Medium	Low	How discomfort shows itself
Parental Status				
Marital Status				
Role of Women				
Ethical values				
Family structure/practices				
Treatment of elders				
Relationship to authority				
Role of work in life				
Personal health/hygiene				
Language differences (accents included)				
Leisure time activities				

Part 2: Processing Your Comfort with Differences

Objectives:

- To identify areas of personal discomfort in dealing with diversity
- To gain an understanding of what triggers that discomfort and gather ideas for becoming more comfortable

Processing the Activity:

- Your instructor might begin with a brief lecturette acknowledging the role of individual perspectives and experience in determining comfort level across various diversity dimensions.
- You will then respond to each item in the assessment with either a high, medium, or low score. Where there is low comfort, participants can write in the box “How discomfort shows itself.” Please be as honest as possible. You won’t have to share anything you are not comfortable sharing.
- The class will then discuss either in pairs or small groups. The number of participants and the level of trust influence the size of the discussion group. Where there is little trust, groups of 2 or 3 are preferable. If high trust exists, groups can be larger.
- Your instructor will give the small groups or dyads time (approximately 15 minutes) for sharing and discussion.
- After the small groups/dyads, the class will reconvene and have a large group discussion focusing on areas of greatest discomfort, reasons for that discomfort, and suggestions or ideas for becoming more comfortable. Since it is likely that different classmates will have varying levels of experience with different groups, this can be a particularly rich—and sometimes uncomfortable—discussion. Remember that the point is not to judge but to learn!

Questions for Discussion:

- Which areas have high comfort levels? Which ones have the lowest?
- To what do you attribute the differences?
- Where has the comfort level changed, either getting more or less comfortable?
- What has brought about the change?
- What is the consequence to your relationships and career opportunities if no change is made?
- What can you do to increase your comfort in places where it needs to increase?

REFERENCES

Braverman, B. & Dominguez, T. P. (2021). Abandon “race.” Focus on racism. *Frontiers in Public Health*, 9, 1–8. <https://doi.org/10.3389/fpubh.2021.689462>

- Brewer, M. B. (1991). The social self: On being the same and different at the same time. *Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin*, 17(5), 475–482. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0146167291175001>
- Fagan, H., Wells, B., Guenther, S., & Matkin, G. S. (2022.) The path to inclusion: A literature review of attributes and impacts of inclusive leaders. *Journal of Leadership Education*, 21(1), 88–113. <https://doi.org/10.12806/V21/I1/R7>
- Ferdman, B. M. (2018, October 25). Inclusion at work. *Society of Consulting Psychology*. https://scpd1.memberclicks.net/index.php?option=com_dailyplanetblog&view=entry&category=main-blog&id=25:inclusion-at-work
- Flowers, H. (2019). Intersectionality part one: Intersectionality defined. National Institutes of Health. <https://www.edi.nih.gov/blog/communities/intersectionality-part-one-intersectionality-defined>
- Gardenswartz, L., & Rowe, A. (2003). *Diverse Teams at Work: Capitalizing on the power of diversity*. Society for Human Resources Management.
- Loden, M., & Rosener, J. B. (1991). *Workforce America!: Managing employee diversity as a vital resource*. Business One Irwin.
- Shore, L. M., Randel, A. E., Chung, B. G., Dean, M. A., Ehrhart, K. H., & Singh, G. (2011). Inclusion and diversity in work groups: A review and model for future research. *Journal of Management*, 37(4), 1262–1289. <https://doi.org/10.1177/014920631038594>

7.1: Diversity and Inclusion is shared under a [CC BY-NC](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by LibreTexts.

8: Diversity and Inclusion

Gina S. Matkin & Helen Abdali Soosan Fagan

INTRODUCTION

In the Social Change Model of Leadership, Collaboration is defined as “Working with others in a common effort by capitalizing on varying perspectives and the power of diversity” (see Table 1 in the Introduction Chapter). This group-level value in the SCM model is essential if we want to work toward common goals in a way that values all voices.

Diversity and inclusion have never been more important or talked about issues than they are today. With the connectedness of our world via social media, video conferencing, news outlets, and other sources, we instantly hear what is happening the moment it occurs. This kind of connectedness requires a new lens through which to view our world and consider how our own identity plays a role in our perceptions of it. Additionally, as our world becomes more complex and connected, we need new ways to look at and talk about the world in less divisive and more inclusive ways.

This chapter will lead us on a journey to consider who we are at the many levels of our identity, how we can come from a place of knowing ourselves to better seeing and understanding others, and how we can challenge ourselves to shift our perspectives to see differences in a new and more holistic way to create more inclusive environments that welcome and value everyone!

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES:

By the end of this chapter, you will be able to...

- define diversity and explain its application to your own identity.
- define inclusion and explain its application to your own identity.
- describe the various parts of your own identity and how you experience them as either advantaging or disadvantaging you.
- apply your understanding of diversity and inclusion as they relate to you as an emerging leader in fostering collaboration and leading a diverse group or team to a common purpose.

KEYWORDS: Diversity, inclusion, identity, inclusive leadership, privilege, marginalization

It is easy to look at the world through our own lens and draw conclusions based on who we are and what we have experienced. This chapter challenges us to go beyond the “known” and into a more challenging territory where we seek to see the world, not as we are but as *it* is.

This may sound simple to do, but it requires us to both listen openly and be willing to learn from those around us. We often tell our students that there are two important things to remember when engaging in discussions where we might have a different opinion or perspective:

- *Listening to you* does not mean I agree.
- *Learning from you* does not mean I will change my mind...but I might.

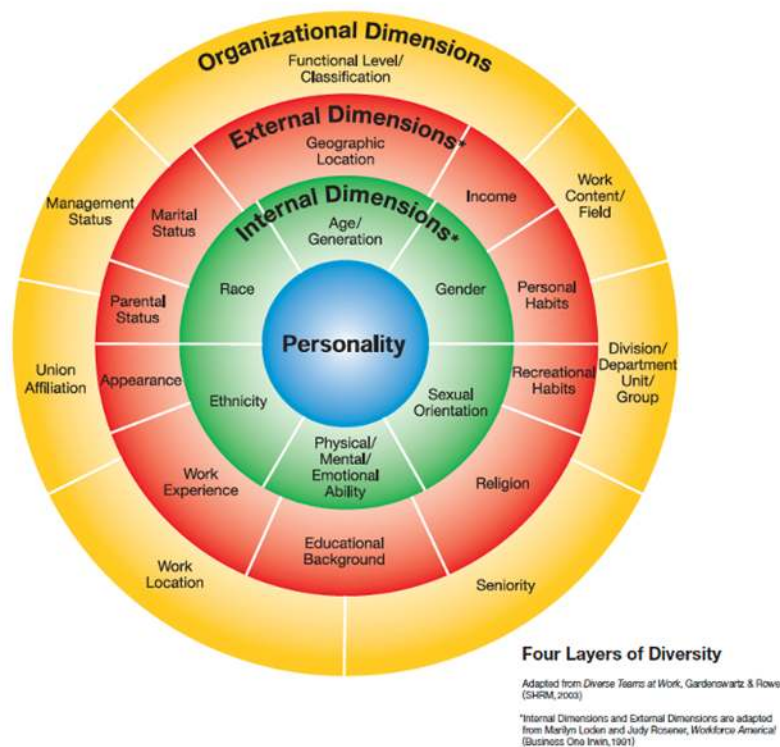
Students tell us that these two statements, when taken to heart, open up a kind of spaciousness in the room where assumptions can fall away, and we can really hear each other. Often our judgment or reaction to others who are different from us is based on fear. It might be fear of what others will think if I listen and do not openly disagree. It might be protecting a value that I hold dear. Either way, if we face our fear or discomfort, there is so much to learn!

This chapter on diversity and inclusion focuses on helping us see differences in a more holistic and positive way. We present you with ways to consider and welcome difference. This starts by examining who you are. We believe the only true way to value differences in others is to be completely open and comfortable with who you are! Being authentically “you” actually helps others be more authentically who they are when they are with you. This also includes the recognition that who we are may offer some advantages (often termed “privilege”) or disadvantages (sometimes called “marginalization”) depending on where we are and who we are surrounded by. Being aware of both our privileges and where we may be marginalized may help us be more skilled at creating spaces where others feel both welcomed and truly seen!

The Four-Layer Model of Diversity

The first model we want to introduce you to is the Four-Layer Model of Diversity. Think about the last time you heard the term “diversity.” What was the setting? What did you think was meant by this term? We define diversity as simply the “mix of

differences.” Often we think of these differences as those you can observe, but there is much more to diversity and our “mix of differences” than meets the eye. *Diverse Teams at Work* (Gardenswartz & Rowe, 2003) depicts diversity by looking at both the internal and external dimensions. This model, originally presented by Marilyn Loden and Judy Rosener (1991) in their book, *Workforce America*, illustrates diversity as far beyond what we can observe. This model helps us to see the numerous dimensions in which human beings are different. Diversity is the reality that those differences exist between us. Put quite simply, diversity is the many ways human beings are similar and different. These differences become the layers through which we experience the world, and the world experiences us (see Figure 8.1). While it is evident that human beings are similar and different in many ways, all differences are not equal. We cannot deny the fact that race, ethnicity, gender, age, and sexual orientation are topics that have been challenging humanity for centuries.



Note: Image used with permission.

Figure 8.1: The Four Layers of

Diversity: Adapted with permission from *Diverse Teams at Work*, Gardenswartz & Rowe (SHRM, 2003)

*Internal Dimensions and External Dimensions are adapted from Marilyn Loden and Judy Rosener, *Workforce America!* (Business One Irwin, 1991)

At the core (blue) is personality. This core drives much of the connection we sense when we first begin to interact with people who think like us, process information like us, and manage their lives like us. This layer is the beginning of and often the most overlooked layer of diversity.

The next level (green) depicts the internal dimensions considered by Gardenswartz and Rowe (2003) as “powerful shapers of opportunities, access, and expectations” (p.32). These move our understanding of diversity beyond the central core of personality to the six internal dimensions of diversity that, for the most part, we do not choose or control, yet they have a powerful effect on our behavior, attitudes, and opportunities in organizations and communities. Briefly described, these six dimensions are:

- Age – generational differences between us drive our expectations of work, family, life, loyalty, security, etc. Diving into age differences helps us to understand that not all people have the same perspectives. It also helps us understand that while age certainly helps shape our perspective, it does not confine us to a particular way of thinking.
- Gender – While the authors were referring to biological sex when they created this model, the word sex and gender continue to be confused and used synonymously by many. While helping you understand the differences between sex and gender is beyond the scope of this chapter, it is important to recognize that differences exist and that conforming or not conforming to gender norms societally prescribed by one’s sex has become an important topic in diversity and inclusion discussions.

- Race – Contrary to popular belief, we do not live in a color-blind society, nor should it be our goal. Human differences, often focused solely on the color of one's skin, have continued to limit human beings' appreciation of differences. The term race began to be used during colonization and expanded with each century since then. Race is described as a social construct used to categorize visual differences in the color of skin, slant and roundness of eyes, the width of the nose, texture of hair, etc. (See this 2021 article from Braverman and Dominguez in *Frontiers in Public Health* for an in-depth look at this: <https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC8452910/pdf/fpubh-09-689462.pdf>).
- Ethnicity – Differences connected to one's ancestral origins (national and/or tribal) are the differences that make up the differences in ethnicity. Often people confuse ethnicity and race. Differences in ethnicity often lead to differences in language, celebrations, and what is considered "cultural"; however, culture is broader than ethnicity. Culture is made up of beliefs, behaviors, attitudes, and expectations that humans consider "normal" in assessing others. Culture begins to take shape in a family, which is operating in the confines of a nation. While national and ethnic cultures are generally the place we begin to think about culture, they are not the only layers of culture.
- Physical/Mental/Emotional Abilities – Physical, mental, and emotional abilities differ between human beings. While the original model focused on physical abilities, for the purposes of our conversation, we will think of abilities in a much broader way to include physical and cognitive abilities, as well as neurodivergence.
- Sexual Orientation – Humans differ widely when it comes to sexual orientation, and that has continued to expand over the past decade. The key factor is that not all humans are heterosexual and if people judge each other based on sexual orientation, it erodes trust and teamwork, and does not allow open authenticity in identities to emerge.

Identity Activity: Let's make this personal!

Consider this:

- What aspects of your internal dimensions of identity (age, race, gender, sexual orientation, etc.) do you most identify with?
- Are there any aspects of identity that you do not feel safe/comfortable revealing or discussing in some situations or settings? Why?

Take a moment to list as many answers to the question, "Who am I?" as come to mind in 2–3 minutes (even beyond the internal dimensions). Notice what you put on the list and what might be missing (what did you not think of right away). Now ask yourself if you would have created the same list if you were asked to share it publicly in a group, class, family setting, etc. If the lists would be different, why?

As you look back over these lists, consider the parts of your identity that you feel benefit you in some way and those that might create challenges or even barriers (judgment, misperceptions, assumptions, etc.).

Now consider situations when you have been more aware (or less aware) of these benefits and challenges. How do you think others experience their own identities and navigate those? Considering your own and then others' identities and experiences can go a long way toward greater understanding and empathy.

There are two additional layers to this model: the external layer of differences, which includes things such as income level (socioeconomic status), religion, appearance, etc., and the organizational layer of differences, which includes work field, seniority, etc. In this chapter, we are mainly focused on the internal dimensions, but you can easily see how these additional layers add complexity to our identity and how we experience it.

In learning about the four-layer model of diversity, we can see that human beings are all very complex and that we all belong in the discussions around diversity. Diversity is not about only one group. It is about all human beings. In fact, we all possess a multitude of identities based on race, gender, ethnicity, socioeconomic status, physical/mental/emotional abilities, etc. We are not just one thing. This concept can be better understood by exploring the term "intersectionality." While a conversation about intersectionality is beyond the scope of this chapter, you can learn more about what it means and find some additional resources at this website (Flowers, 2019): <https://www.edi.nih.gov/blog/communities/intersectionality-part-one-intersectionality-defined>

How we navigate the differences is what helps us succeed or fail at feeling a part of the world around us while still feeling free to be who we truly are. We term this "inclusion." We will learn more about this in the section that follows.

Inclusion: It's More Than You Think

You may have heard talk of "inclusion" or "inclusive leadership" recently. This term does not replace talking about "diversity" but rather moves us to the next step. While diversity is, in essence, about the mix of differences, inclusion is about bringing differences together. It is important to note that diversity is not something that describes a single individual but rather how a group, team,

workplace, or community can be diverse if people from various racial, ethnic, sexual orientation, and/or other identity groups are represented.

Inclusion is about more than just representation. Inclusion is about how we engage with each other and who has access to resources, decision-making, etc. Essentially it is about connection and voice! Is everyone included in decision-making? Does everyone feel heard and valued? Does everyone feel that they can bring *ALL* of who they are to the workplace, organization, classroom, or community? These are a few of the questions that we have to ask in order to gauge whether we are creating inclusive environments.

We often think that when people feel a sense of connection of belongingness, then inclusion has been achieved. This is only partly true. Belongingness is an important component of inclusion, but it does not tell the whole story.

Lynn Shore and colleagues (2011) developed a model to help us understand inclusion in a more holistic way. This model is based on two needs that humans have: the need for *belongingness* and the need for *uniqueness* (Brewer, 1991). Shore and colleagues used this concept to create a guide for a better understanding of how inclusion works. Shore's model identifies the two needs and explains what a person might experience based on the presence, absence, or lack of balance in both belongingness and uniqueness (See Figure 2).

"In inclusive workplaces, people can be fully themselves, striving to be their best, without fear or without a sense that they must hide or become someone else." (Ferdman, 2018, para. 4)

Table 8.1 | Shore et al., Inclusion Framework (2011)

	Low Belongingness	High Belongingness
Low Value in Uniqueness	Exclusion Individual is not treated as an organizational insider with unique value in the work group but there are other employees or groups who are insiders.	Assimilation Individual is treated as an insider in the work group when they conform to organizational/dominant culture norms and downplay uniqueness.
High Value in Uniqueness	Differentiation Individual is not treated as an organizational insider in the work group but their unique characteristics are seen as valuable and required for group/organization success.	Inclusion Individual is treated as an insider and also allowed/encouraged to retain uniqueness within the work group.

For example, if a person is feeling that they do not belong and that their unique characteristics are not seen or valued, they experience "*exclusion*." Conversely, if a person feels a sense of belongingness AND also feels that their uniqueness is valued and encouraged, they experience "*inclusion*." It is important to note that belongingness paired with the absence of valuing uniqueness or individuality can create an environment of "*assimilation*" where a person feels they must conform to the group norms in order to continue to be accepted. This is what the authors of this chapter call a "false sense of inclusion." Finally, if a person feels that they are valued for what they can contribute or bring that is unique but that they are not really accepted, it can lead to "*differentiation*," where the person ultimately feels used for their skills and talents but not seen as a member of the group or team.

This model offers an important contribution in helping us to see that inclusion and inclusive environments go beyond belongingness and require something much more complex. As a leader, your team or group will be much stronger if you carefully consider both belonging and uniqueness.

Building on Shore et al.'s (2011) model, Fagan et al. (2022) conducted an extensive review to determine how leaders create inclusion for followers. From this review, a list of seven "attributes" of inclusive leaders emerged. These were:

- Authentic Leadership
- Changemaker
- Collaborative
- Commitment to diversity and cultural competence
- Ideals
- Offering follower support

- Openness

When the seven attributes are acted upon, leaders are able to have impacts on followers that create more inclusive environments. It should be noted that the mix of these attributes is important as some may foster belongingness while not encouraging uniqueness. They state,

We believe that while some impacts may relate more toward belongingness instead of uniqueness—such as increased organizational commitment—and are beneficial for overall inclusion, inclusive leaders should be able to recognize the impacts they create as relating to both uniqueness and belongingness. (Fagan, et al., 2022, p. 101)

This observation is important in that it may feel good to help another person connect and feel as if they belong; however, if a person feels they have to conform and cannot be themselves, they will not experience true inclusion.

Scenario 1

Halle was hired by Brave Marketing company. She was the best candidate because of several successful campaigns with a rapper who was expanding his reach into clothing. Halle is the only female and the youngest person on this team. While she has been told her work is great, every time the team gets together after work, they don't include her. And during side conversations, she is not engaged by other team members, and when she tries to engage with them, they shy away from her. Her unique talents are appreciated, yet she still feels like she made the wrong decision in joining this marketing firm because she really doesn't feel like she belongs.

Do you think Halle feels valued for her contributions to the team?

Do you think she feels she is accepted as a member of the team?

Is Halle experiencing true Inclusion? If not, what is missing, and what could the team do differently to truly help her feel included?

We can begin to notice in ourselves and in our groups, classes, and other environments when inclusion is happening and when it is not. At times, noticing may be all you do, as it may or may not feel safe to intervene or ask for support. At other times, you may be able to advocate for yourself or others to make sure your group is being truly inclusive.

Reflection

Have you ever been in a group where you felt that you had to adapt to the norms of the group in order to be liked or accepted? If so, you have been experiencing an “assimilation environment.” This environment keeps us from being able to bring our full selves and our unique perspectives and ideas to the group. It essentially “silences” the person who feels they must conform in order to be accepted. Ask yourself how this would make you feel and whether you would want to continue to be part of the group if you experienced this “silencing.”

As you grow and develop in your awareness, you may find that you develop the skills and comfort level to help make the groups and other environments in which you live and work become more inclusive.

Scenario 2

Claire recently completed a class in diversity that was part of her leadership minor. Before the class, she had never thought of herself as a person who is uniquely positioned to bridge differences because she is biracial and her parents are from two different countries. During the class she gained a level of self-awareness, but was still trying to figure out what that meant for her.

Recently, during a conversation with her roommates about Disney movies, the topic of a black Ariel came up. Her roommates, who are both white, felt that having a black Ariel ruined the movie for them, and stole their childhood memories of being a mermaid. Claire could feel herself getting sad, and yet found herself unable to speak up. Claire was thinking, what about the millions of little black girls who also dreamed of being a mermaid? It sure would have been nice to have that when she was their age.

Part of the challenge of being biracial was that so many people around her made her feel like she didn't fit in. She wasn't black enough to be with the black kids, and she wasn't white enough to be with the white kids. When she was with her cousins on her mom's side, she stood out because of her skin color. When she was with her cousins on her dad's side, she stood out because of her skin color.

Now, with her roommates, she had at least found a bond over time. She wanted to scream at her roommates to try to help them see how their words were making her feel. She felt bad for even thinking that way and didn't know how to share her thoughts, so she just listened and nodded. She wanted to help them understand but didn't want to seem too different.

- What is Claire experiencing with her roommates? Do you think she feels that her uniqueness is recognized and valued?
- How might the roommates have approached the conversation differently to make sure that all voices felt comfortable expressing their views?

QUESTIONS FOR JOURNALING OR DISCUSSION

How do I feel when I am not fully included in a group but want to be?

1. What is it like to feel like I *belong* to a group, but not feel safe being my *unique* self (assimilation)?
2. What is it like to feel that my *uniqueness* is needed to accomplish something but that, otherwise, I do not really feel as if I *belong* as a member of the group (differentiation)?

How can I, as a group member or a leader, help others feel truly included?

1. What questions can I ask?
2. How can I balance helping someone feel that they belong AND that their uniquenesses are valued as well?

Activity

Comfort with Differences

Part 1: Assessing Your Comfort with Differences

If we pause and really reflect, we will know that we truly are more comfortable with some groups than others. Dr. Fagan sometimes likes to ask her students: “Who would you be most afraid to bring home as your future spouse?” The reason for the question is to get students to be honest about their level of comfort/discomfort with certain groups. Don’t feel bad. Everyone has varying levels of experience and comfort/discomfort. It is part of being human. The key to being effective as a leader is to be honest enough with yourself that you learn to manage it.

Directions: Think about each dimension of diversity and rate the level of comfort you feel in dealing with people different from you in that dimension.

Table 8.1 | Adapted from *Diverse Teams at Work*, Lee Gardenswartz and Anita Rowe, Irwin Professional Publishing, 2003. Used with permission.

	High	Medium	Low	How discomfort shows itself
Age				
Gender				
Sexual Orientation				
Physical/Emotional/Psychological Ability				
Ethnicity				
Race				
Geographic Location				
Different socio-economic status				
Personal Habits				
Recreational Habits				
Religion				
Educational Background				
Appearance				
Parental Status				

	High	Medium	Low	How discomfort shows itself
Marital Status				
Role of Women				
Ethical values				
Family structure/practices				
Treatment of elders				
Relationship to authority				
Role of work in life				
Personal health/hygiene				
Language differences (accents included)				
Leisure time activities				

Part 2: Processing Your Comfort with Differences

Objectives:

- To identify areas of personal discomfort in dealing with diversity
- To gain an understanding of what triggers that discomfort and gather ideas for becoming more comfortable

Processing the Activity:

- Your instructor might begin with a brief lecturette acknowledging the role of individual perspectives and experience in determining comfort level across various diversity dimensions.
- You will then respond to each item in the assessment with either a high, medium, or low score. Where there is low comfort, participants can write in the box “How discomfort shows itself.” Please be as honest as possible. You won’t have to share anything you are not comfortable sharing.
- The class will then discuss either in pairs or small groups. The number of participants and the level of trust influence the size of the discussion group. Where there is little trust, groups of 2 or 3 are preferable. If high trust exists, groups can be larger.
- Your instructor will give the small groups or dyads time (approximately 15 minutes) for sharing and discussion.
- After the small groups/dyads, the class will reconvene and have a large group discussion focusing on areas of greatest discomfort, reasons for that discomfort, and suggestions or ideas for becoming more comfortable. Since it is likely that different classmates will have varying levels of experience with different groups, this can be a particularly rich—and sometimes uncomfortable—discussion. Remember that the point is not to judge but to learn!

Questions for Discussion:

- Which areas have high comfort levels? Which ones have the lowest?
- To what do you attribute the differences?
- Where has the comfort level changed, either getting more or less comfortable?
- What has brought about the change?
- What is the consequence to your relationships and career opportunities if no change is made?
- What can you do to increase your comfort in places where it needs to increase?

REFERENCES

Braverman, B. & Dominguez, T. P. (2021). Abandon “race.” Focus on racism. *Frontiers in Public Health*, 9, 1–8. <https://doi.org/10.3389/fpubh.2021.689462>

- Brewer, M. B. (1991). The social self: On being the same and different at the same time. *Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin*, 17(5), 475–482. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0146167291175001>
- Fagan, H., Wells, B., Guenther, S., & Matkin, G. S. (2022.) The path to inclusion: A literature review of attributes and impacts of inclusive leaders. *Journal of Leadership Education*, 21(1), 88–113. <https://doi.org/10.12806/V21/I1/R7>
- Ferdman, B. M. (2018, October 25). Inclusion at work. *Society of Consulting Psychology*. https://scpd1.memberclicks.net/index.php?option=com_dailyplanetblog&view=entry&category=main-blog&id=25:inclusion-at-work
- Flowers, H. (2019). Intersectionality part one: Intersectionality defined. National Institutes of Health. <https://www.edi.nih.gov/blog/communities/intersectionality-part-one-intersectionality-defined>
- Gardenswartz, L., & Rowe, A. (2003). *Diverse Teams at Work: Capitalizing on the power of diversity*. Society for Human Resources Management.
- Loden, M., & Rosener, J. B. (1991). *Workforce America!: Managing employee diversity as a vital resource*. Business One Irwin.
- Shore, L. M., Randel, A. E., Chung, B. G., Dean, M. A., Ehrhart, K. H., & Singh, G. (2011). Inclusion and diversity in work groups: A review and model for future research. *Journal of Management*, 37(4), 1262–1289. <https://doi.org/10.1177/014920631038594>

8: Diversity and Inclusion is shared under a CC BY-NC license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by LibreTexts.

9: Meeting the Challenge of Effective Groups and Teams Membership

Sarah A. Bush & Jason Headrick

INTRODUCTION

When you are assigned to a new team or group in one of your classes, what is the first emotion you feel? For many, this can bring excitement to work with peers and to approach a challenge, project, or assignment creatively. For others, however, the mention of group work brings anxiety and dread. Your reaction is most likely due to previous experiences that you have had working or competing in a team-based environment. Understanding more about the dynamics of teams and the best way to collaborate with others can help you be more successful when working in these environments.

CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

By the end of this chapter, you will be able to...

- distinguish a group from a team.
- identify the importance of teams in organizations and change processes.
- explain synergy, cohesion, and collaboration on teams.
- provide examples of things you can do personally to work more effectively and efficiently on teams.
- analyze the benefits and barriers to working in teams.
- assess strategies for creating synergy, cohesion, and collaboration on teams ready to engage in your community or workplace.

KEYWORDS: Teams, problem-solving, groups, synergy, cohesion, collaboration

Working in a group or a team can bring about innovation, creativity, a celebration of diversity, and advancements in problem-solving, critical thinking, and building trust. Understanding how to work effectively in groups and teams allows you to engage directly with the ideas behind leadership, which will help prepare you for the workforce. Additionally, teams are increasingly becoming the path to change, as interdisciplinary solutions are required to solve real-world problems impacting our organizations and communities locally and globally.

Organizations use many types of teams to address challenges and create new projects and workgroups. The notion of working in groups and teams prepares individuals to work interdependently with others to accomplish a task or goal. Interdependent work closely relates to the definition of leadership as “a process whereby an individual influences a group of individuals to achieve a common goal” (Northouse, 2019, p. 5). Rather than focusing on influencing others, productive team members focus on how all individuals take on leadership roles and contribute via collaboration. Those who engage in collaborative processes do so to solve problems and make decisions with the input of individuals from multiple perspectives. This diversity leads to synergy; however, there are many obstacles to overcome to achieve synergy and reap the benefits of working collaboratively. Learning more about teams and strategies for collaboration can lead to more effective and efficient teams.

Welcome to the Team!

Research on group processes dates back to the early 1900s (Weingart, 2012); the 1940s marked the beginning of group approaches at the forefront of leadership research (Northouse, 2019). As humans, we gravitate towards work that involves others. We work in groups and teams for various reasons, including dividing tasks to be more efficient, learning from others, and creating solutions from different perspectives; however, individuals, organizations, and scholars have mixed views related to teams (Franz, 2012). Working with a group requires a lot of work, time, and decision-making. It can be hard to get teams to work collaboratively, embrace diversity, overcome conflict, and achieve synergy. This chapter will uncover the benefits and barriers to working in teams and provide strategies to help you personally and professionally increase collaboration in teams.

The Difference Between Groups and Teams

Let's start by defining groups and teams. Many people use the two terms interchangeably, but there are some key differences. Forsyth (2014) defines a **group** as “two or more individuals who are connected by and within social relationships” (p. 4). Based on this definition, a group can range from two individuals to many people who are connected based on a shared interest or affiliation (Forsyth, 2014). For instance, a group may march for a cause they believe in, such as women's rights, and be connected by social affiliation to their shared cause. Groups might also be members of an organization, such as a club or Greek organization.

A **team** is a group that has structure, a focused task, a shared goal, and a relatively high level of “groupness” (Franz, 2012). Katzenbach and Smith (1993) proposed the following definition: “a team is a small number of people with complementary skills who are committed to a common purpose [and] set of performance goals” (p. 112). Therefore, every team is a group, but every group is not a team. See Table 1 for Katzenbach and Smith’s (2005) take on differentiating working groups from teams. Consider the preceding example of the group marching for women’s rights. Every individual involved with the march may have some level of “groupness” based on their shared and vested interest; however, the planning committee for the march implemented their individual talents towards a shared common purpose of planning the march and performance goals and mutual accountability to one another based on the march’s success. Similarly, the executive board or a subcommittee of a Greek chapter tends to function as a team.

Table 1 | Differences between Working Groups and Teams

Working Group Characteristics	Team Characteristics
Strong, clearly focused leader	Shared leadership roles
Individual accountability	Individual and mutual accountability
The group's purpose is the same as the broader organizational mission	Specific team purpose that the team itself delivers
Individual work products	Collective work products
Runs efficient meetings	Encourages open-ended discussion and active problemsolving meetings
Measures its effectiveness indirectly by its influence on others (such as financial performance of the business)	Measures performance directly by assessing collective work products
Discusses, decides, and delegates	Discusses, decides, and does real work together

Note: Table was created from Katzenbach and Smith (2005)

Differentiating teams from groups is essential to understanding potential processes and outputs, but it is also necessary to explore the age-old question—“are two heads better than one?” The true answer to this is complex—it depends. Research shows that teams who can overcome adversity and other barriers can successfully achieve synergy as individuals and in team environments (Forsyth, 2014; Franz, 2012; Northouse, 2019). When teams can achieve synergy, organizations reap the benefits (Franz, 2012; West, 2004). This reason alone is why many organizations invest both financial and time-based resources in team-based training for their employees. **Synergy** occurs when the team is something more significant than the sum of its parts. A team’s effectiveness and synergy can play a positive role in their quality of work. Effective teams can lead to the following outcomes (Parker, 1990; West, 2004; Yost & Tucker, 2000):

- Increased productivity and task performance
- More effective use of resources
- Better decision-making and problem-solving
- Better quality products and services
- Improved organizational learning
- Higher employee engagement
- Enhanced member interpersonal skills and compatibility
- Heightened use of emotional intelligence (EI) and practical application of empathy, social skills, motivation, and the ability to resolve differences
- Greater creativity and innovation

Leader Log: How can you build synergy with your group or team? Why is synergy something you want to improve within groups and teams? Reflect on some of the reasons this is important to you.

Breakdown of Models and Theories

Many theories and models provide insight into how groups and teams work and what makes them effective. In leadership research, team development has been a primary area of study (Fisher, 1970; Hurt & Trombley, 2007; Lewin, 1947; McClure, 2005; McGrath,

1991; Morgan, et al., 1993; Poole, 1981, 1983; Tuckman, 1965; Tuckman & Jensen, 1977; Wheelan, 2009). This chapter will briefly overview the historical models, reveal how they have adapted over time, and guide current application-based models. To fully describe group dynamics and development, we will highlight Tuckman and Jensen's (1977) Stages of Group Development Model and Fisher's (1970) Small Group Development Model.

Stages of Group Development Model

Tuckman's (1965) Stages of Group Development Model had four initial phases: forming, storming, norming, and performing (see Figure 9.1). In the forming stage, a group establishes, and the members begin to become familiar with other members, their leaders, their environment, and the preexisting standards in the group (Tuckman, 1965). During storming, conflict arises around interpersonal issues, and the group struggles with adversity, but the norming stage brings group cohesiveness (Tuckman, 1965). Finally, a group's new-found structure and "groupness" becomes a problem-solving tool, and the group enters the performing stage (Tuckman, 1965). This model demonstrates the formation of group structure and group problem-solving performance. Tuckman and Jensen (1977) revisited the model after researching the life cycles of groups and added a fifth stage, adjourning. During the adjourning phase, the group completes their task and disperses (Tuckman & Jensen, 1977).

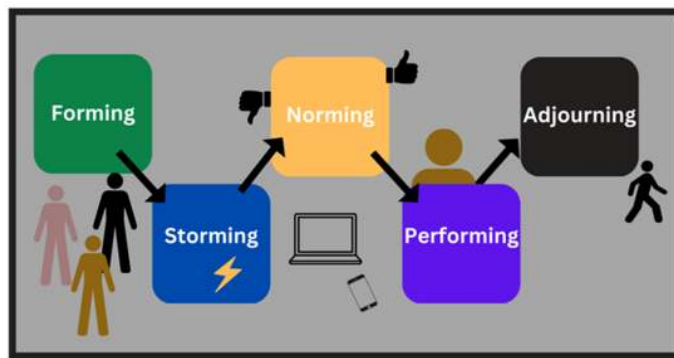


Figure 9.1: Stages of Team Development (Tuckman &

Jensen, 1977)

Small Group Development Model

Fisher's (1970) Small Group Development Model focuses more explicitly on a group's actions during a decision-making process. This model, similar to Tuckman's (1965) and Tuckman & Jensen's (1977) models, contributes to group processing. The model deals mainly with communication and interactions and includes four phases: orientation, conflict, emergence, and reinforcement (see Figure 9.2).

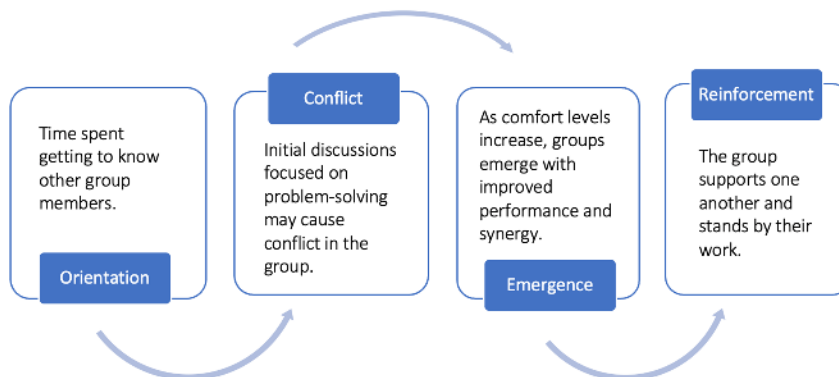


Figure 9.2: Small group development

model

Orientation: During the orientation phase, group members spend time getting to know each other, and a bit of tension may be present due to individuals being uncomfortable communicating with each other (Fisher, 1970). When we meet with a group or team members for the first time, it is important to focus time on introductions, getting to know one another, and discussing the group's goals. Establishing some of the norms and standards for the group/team can start the time together more positively. Deciding how the group will communicate (e.g., exchanging phone numbers and email addresses) is essential during the orientation period.

Conflict: The conflict phase occurs from tension in the group when individuals debate and discuss possible solutions to the problems at hand (Fisher, 1970). Notably, conflict can benefit all members in discussing rules or norms the group or team will have when future conflict occurs. These expectations help establish the group's footing and prepare them for future decision-making and conflict. This chapter provides strategies to move through and process conflict.

Emergence: As the individuals become more comfortable with each other and a defined group structure is formed, the emergence phase occurs (Fisher, 1970). The emergence phase helps groups and teams set work patterns that increase performance and help achieve goals. Consider this stage like a butterfly coming out of its cocoon – when it emerges, it's ready to flutter around and get to work. When a group or team develops, it shows that the efforts to reach synergy have happened, and the group or team begins working together effectively. For this to happen, the group or team may need to reevaluate the roles and duties of all involved and make adjustments so the best work is moving forward. A commitment to making adjustments means that individuals will put the group's greater good ahead of their personal needs and decisions.

Reinforcement: Finally, through reinforcement, all individuals reach a consensus to support the decision made through both verbal and nonverbal transmissions (Fisher, 1970). This stage means that the group or team is willing to help and stand behind the assignment, work, and decisions made through working together.

Each phase of Fisher's model is essential for groups to consider as they navigate their work. By using the stages as a blueprint, the groups and teams can address conflict and be effective in their decision-making and other team responsibilities.

The Barriers We Face

Over the years, models have continued to develop on group processes, and many still involve stages; however, newer models are more flexible in the progression of the phases, recognizing the issues with the prescribed straight-forward team and group processes (McGrath, 1991; Morgan et al., 1993; Poole, 1983; Wheelan, 2009). In these models, teams can backtrack through phases or skip stages. These models recognize changing social relationships involved in a team and how dynamic teams are in a state of continual evolution.

Lencioni (2002) created a model that considers barriers teams must overcome, identifying how they can cause a chain reaction contributing to other obstacles. Lencioni's (2002) Five Dysfunctions of a Team Model identifies these barriers as primary issues when working in a team. In this model, the dysfunctions are interrelated and build upon one another (see Figure 9.3).

This image depicts the Five Dysfunctions of a Team Pyramid. The pyramid is divided into five horizontal sections. From the bottom layer (base of the pyramid) up, the sections are labeled in order of the dysfunctions: absence of trust, fear of conflict, lack of commitment, avoidance of accountability, inattention to results.



Figure 9.3: Lencioni's (2002) Five

Dysfunctions of a Team Pyramid

The presence of a dysfunction sparks a chain reaction of events causing other dysfunctions to occur. So, even the existence of just one dysfunction will often be detrimental to teamwork (Lencioni, 2002).

Absence of trust: The first dysfunction, lack of trust, is based upon vulnerability (Lencioni, 2002). Lencioni (2002) described group trust as “the confidence among team members that their peers’ intentions are good and that there is no reason to be protective or careful around the group” (p. 196). Hence, team members must be vulnerable with each other in acknowledging their shortcomings, making mistakes without judgment, and requesting aid from others (Lencioni, 2002). A team that shares mutual trust understands each member’s distinctive attributes and how those attributes add value to the group. As the model’s foundation, a team that lacks trust will make teamwork nearly impossible (Lencioni, 2002).

Fear of conflict: Without trust, a team will not debate when problem-solving (Lencioni, 2002), which leads to the second dysfunction, fear of conflict. Although we often think of conflict negatively, any strong relationship must undergo conflict to succeed (Lencioni, 2002); however, productive conflict is understood to be healthy debate or arguments over concepts and ideas. It avoids “personality-focused, mean-spirited attacks” (Lencioni, 2002, p. 202).

Lack of commitment: Individuals in a group need to feel heard before committing to a decision, whether it was their idea or not (Lencioni, 2002). The third dysfunction, lack of commitment, relates to team members not supporting or feeling confident in decisions made by the team (Lencioni, 2002). Buy-in from all members allows teams to stand behind decisions, whether there is a great deal of risk involved or not (Lencioni, 2002). All team members must fully support decisions and understand their role in a productive team.

Avoidance of accountability: The fourth dysfunction, avoidance of responsibility, occurs when team members are unwilling to approach their peers about their performance or behaviors, harming the overall team (Lencioni, 2002). At times, the fear of conflict causes individuals with strong relationships to ignore the poor performance of other team members (Lencioni, 2002). Lencioni (2002) stated that ignoring negative behaviors leads to resentment. When peers do not hold each other accountable, group structure lacks, and some form of structure is vital for a team (Lencioni, 2002).

Inattention to details: Suppose team structure breaks and all individuals are not contributing. In that case, team members focus on their own needs and personal goals instead of the overall team goals (Lencioni, 2002). The fifth dysfunction, inattention to details, occurs when team members focus their attention on “something other than the collective goals of the group” (Lencioni, 2002, p. 216).

Teams must have overarching goals in which all members invest. Members of a successful team must trust each other, engage in conflict, commit to group decisions, hold their peers accountable, and achieve results (Lencioni, 2002).

Barriers to Achieving Synergy

Teams often have so many barriers to overcome that they struggle with productivity, efficiency, problem-solving, organizational learning, and creativity. Team success is rare (Coutu & Beschloss, 2009). This lack of success is due to an inability to overcome barriers and dysfunctions, as described through Lencioni’s (2002) model. These dysfunctions provide an overview of obstacles for teams to achieve synergy and perform, but several other difficulties related to communication, interpersonal matters, problem-solving, and cohesion also plague teams (Franz, 2012). The first step to overcoming these barriers is to identify the overarching problem. For instance, if your team is having communication issues and information is withheld from the group, you can start by examining if the issue is a communication issue or an issue related to trust. Poor communication can result in deteriorating trust, and a lack of trust can result in poor communication. Understanding the basis for the barrier and conflict helps you know which issue to approach first.

Cohesion & Collaboration

The intended outcome for most teams is to achieve synergy, which requires collaboration. A team cannot be greater than the sum of its parts without true collaboration. Collaboration is a process that involves a group working to solve a problem or make a decision that requires shared goals and the sharing of responsibility, authority, and accountability (Franz, 2012; Higher Education Research Institute, 1996; Komives & Wagner, 2017; Liedtka, 1996; Schrage, 1990). The key to understanding collaboration is that the process and outcomes are all shared. It is more than delegating tasks and working separately towards a common purpose. Collaboration includes the following:

- Human relationships and how people relate to each other
- A process for developing common goals and purpose
- Shared responsibility, authority, and accountability in achieving goals
- Creating synergy by utilizing multiple perspectives and strengths of team members (Komives & Wagner, 2017)

This process can be challenging to achieve as these teams need to overcome the five dysfunctions, have high levels of communication, and must dedicate time to increasing cohesion.

Cohesion from both a task and social aspect is essential to engage in collaborative processes (Franz, 2012). Cohesion is grounded in the attraction of members to the group and the group's work. Cohesion can be threatened by the size of a group, individuals' interest in the tasks, tasks being completed individually rather than shared, and the diversity of experiences and personalities. To increase cohesion, teams should establish a group identity, emphasize teamwork, recognize and reward contributions, and respect all group members (Franz, 2012). Cohesion involves both personal and team-level efforts.

Strategies for Increasing Collaboration, Cohesion, and Synergy

At this point, you may be asking – “So what can I do to increase the likelihood of success for a team?” As mentioned prior, your team can dedicate time to developing relationships and increasing trust. For example, you should spend time at the beginning of meetings to get to know one another's interests, backgrounds, experiences, etc. Success also includes discussing each person's interest in the project or work, which helps determine what personal goals exist even before discussing shared goals. Be open to learning and listening to others. It's also essential to share ownership for the process and fully be invested in the group's decisions whether there is success or room for improvement. Those who are great team members celebrate the team's successes and other individuals and take responsibility for failures, even when they weren't involved (Komives & Wagner, 2017). Teams that fail should fail together, and teams that succeed should share in accomplishments.

You can also be seen as trustworthy by being dependable, helping other team members, sharing your views, and encouraging others to do the same (Komives & Wagner, 2017). Building trust allows groups to focus on the process of collaboration. Collaboration often starts with creating a shared group identity and then developing shared goals and purpose. Through this process, communication is critical and should be a focus at all times. Diversity is also important and requires that members form groups with people who have different perspectives that engage in dialogue and express their views openly without fear of judgment. Work with your team to set team rules to promote respect. When groups uphold these strategies, cohesion increases, and teams can achieve collaboration and synergy (Franz, 2012; Komives & Wagner, 2017). Use your knowledge, experience, and skills to make yourself a better group member and to help bring out the best in others.

QUESTIONS FOR JOURNALING OR DISCUSSION

- When have your experiences with teams been positive? How have other experiences been negative? What content from this chapter helped you understand what you might have done differently during that negative team experience?
- What is the role of the individual in a group or team?
- How does a solid team foundation help address conflict or other challenges a group or team faces?
- Which model of teamwork effectiveness do you think you are likely to use in the future? How can you help others get on board with those steps or strategies?
- Reflect on the necessary skills you develop through your involvement with a group or team. Why are these skills needed for the future? How can you use them to build your leadership capacity?

ACTIVITIES

No Good Path Activity—A Case Study on Collaborating to Provide Solutions

Chestnut Lake State College is a medium-sized university with about 13,000 students located in Ramberville, a town with approximately 45,000 people. This quaint city is known for its walkability, history, and friendliness. Additionally, it is one of the best places to raise a family. Historically, Chestnut Lake State College has maintained a good relationship with Ramberville. The residents enjoy attending sporting events and interacting with students.

Five years ago, Chestnut Lake State College set a goal to increase the student population by 5,000 over the next ten years. As the student population is growing, student housing is expanding. Previously, nightlife and student housing had all been located on the south side of the campus, directly connecting to the campus. New and attractive student housing options are being built on the north side of campus, behind several residential housing blocks. Over the last year, residents in this area have made noise complaints about students walking through their neighborhoods late at night. These noise complaints occur because the most direct path from nightlife to the new student housing options is through several local areas. Recently, reports of vandalism and stolen items from lawns have also been made.

The relationship between Ramberville and Chestnut Lake State College is quickly deteriorating as the university and town leadership fail to respond to the complaints. The local police have been attempting to patrol the area more frequently but always

seem to get called away to respond to other calls at this time. Ramberville cannot afford to increase its staffing based on the city's current budget. A bus system drops the students off downtown but makes the last run at 11:30 pm. Additionally, cabs and rideshare services are hard to come by in the local area. Typically, walking is the fastest way to get home. The university also sponsors a safe-walk system, but it does not extend to these new housing areas.

The university must respond with some proposed actions and initiatives to maintain its relationship with Ramberville. They've decided to create a joint task force with the local community to develop potential solutions. Work through the prompts below and be ready to discuss your answers.

- How can the university create a diverse team of community and student leaders? Who should serve on the team? Why?
- How will team diversity help achieve synergy?
- How can you go about setting up the team process to achieve synergy?
- How can the leader of the team overcome the five dysfunctions?
- Create a plan of action for developing a solution to the current issue.

"Hidden Agendas" Activity

Instructions:

Place individuals in teams of 6-7. Give them the common task of building a wall (using LEGO® blocks, note cards, etc.). The wall should be four blocks high and six blocks wide. Then hand out cards with specific goals for each participant. This card represents their personal hidden agenda. The participants should never reveal what is on their card or show their card to another individual. Let the team members work through the activity and do their best to solve the group assignment while satisfying their hidden agenda; however, it should be clear that their personal agenda is always more important than the team agenda.

You can conduct the activity in two ways. The first is to make the activity solvable and provide enough time for them to develop the solution. The second is to make the solution impossible and stop the activity after a set time. The aim of both is to discuss how a lack of commitment to a shared goal and hidden personal agendas can get in the way of collaboration.

Some examples of hidden agenda tasks using colored bricks or blocks as building materials:

- Ensure there are three red bricks on each row
- Ensure no red brick touches a yellow one
- Ensure a blue brick touches a yellow brick on each row
- Ensure every row contains two yellow bricks
- Ensure there is a vertical line of touching white bricks, one block wide, from top to bottom
- Ensure every row has at least one double-block brick
- Ensure that all green bricks are at the end of the row

Reflection:

Reflect by discussing how hidden agendas impact overall group work. Below are some prompts to help start your reflections.

- What was the cause of most of the issues?
- How do hidden agendas impact group work?
- Provide an example of a time you worked with individuals with hidden agendas.
- How do hidden agendas impact trust?
- How could you work through hidden agendas?
- Do you see how this demonstrates the storming phase?
 - Discuss how teams move to the norming phase by working through hidden agendas and creating team-focused goals.
- Did you experience or observe any other team-based components in this activity?

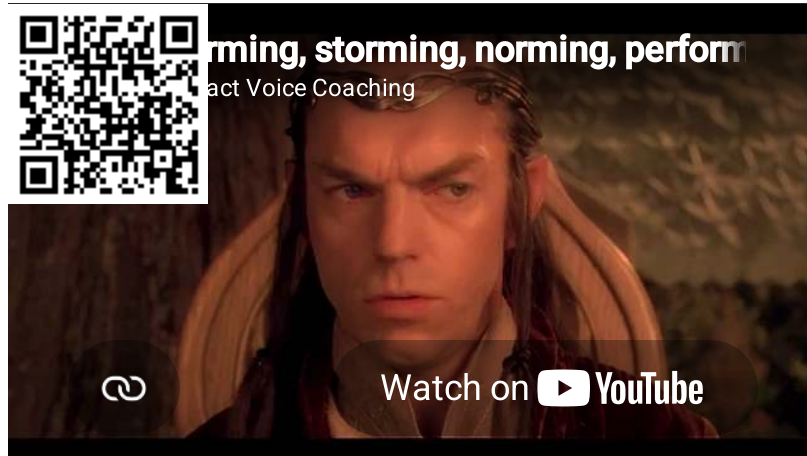
Reflection Questions

- What was the best experience you've ever had working on a team? What made the group so enjoyable?
- In this experience, how did your team progress through Tuckman and Jensen's (1977) Stages of Group Development Model or Fisher's (1970) Small Group Development Model?
- How did your team build cohesion and collaborate?
- Did your team achieve synergy? How do you know?
- What was the worst experience you've ever had working on a team? What made the group so challenging?

- What dysfunctions from Lencioni's (2002) Five Dysfunctions were present?
- How could you, as an individual, increase cohesion and collaboration on your team?
- What strategies could your team have used to increase cohesion and collaboration?

Suggested Videos

Stages of group development as told through the Fellowship of the Ring: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ysWWGf8VsOg&t=11s>



Stages of group development: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=H8gryfMB2P4>



Five Dysfunctions of a Team: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=wHpB1EBufFo&t=12s>



Forgetting the pecking order at work: [https://www.ted.com/talks/margaret heffernan forget the pecking order at work](https://www.ted.com/talks/margaret_heffernan_forget_the_pecking_order_at_work)



REFERENCES

- Coutu, D., & Beschloss, M. (2009). Why teams don't work. *Harvard Business Review*, 87(5), 98–105. <https://hbr.org/2009/05/why-teams-dont-work>
- Fisher, B. A. (1970). Decision emergence: Phases in group decision-making. *Speech Monographs*, 37(1), 53–66. <https://doi.org/10.1080/03637757009375649>
- Forsyth, D. R. (2014). *Group dynamics*. Wadsworth.
- Franz, T. M. (2012). *Group dynamics and team interventions: Understanding and improving team performance*. Wiley-Blackwell.
- Higher Education Research Institute. (1996). *A Social Change Model of Leadership Development* (Version III). UCLA. <https://www.heri.ucla.edu/PDFs/pubs/ASocialChangeModelofLeadershipDevelopment.pdf>
- Hurt, A. C., & Trombley, S. M. (2007). *The punctuated-Tuckman: Towards a new group development model*. <https://files.eric.ed.gov/fulltext/ED504567.pdf>
- Katzenbach, J. R., & Smith, D. K. (1993). *The wisdom of teams: Creating the high-performance organization*. Harvard Business School.
- Katzenbach, J. R., & Smith, D. K. (2005). The discipline of teams. *Harvard Business Review*, 83(7/8), 162–171. <https://hbr.org/1993/03/the-discipline-of-teams-2>

- Komives, S. R., & Wagner, W. (Eds.). (2017). *Leadership for a better world: Understanding the Social Change Model of Leadership Development* (2nd ed.). Jossey-Bass.
- Lencioni, P. (2002). *The five dysfunctions of a team*. Jossey-Bass.
- Lewin, K. (1947). Frontiers in group dynamics: Concept, method and reality in social science, social equilibria and social change. *Human Relations*, 1(2), 143–153. <https://doi.org/10.1177/001872674700100201>
- Liedtka, J. M. (1996). Collaborating across lines of business for competitive advantage. *Academy of Management Perspectives*, 10(2), 20–34. <https://doi.org/10.5465/ame.1996.9606161550>
- McClure, B. A. (2005). *Putting a new spin on groups: The science of chaos* (2nd ed.). Taylor and Francis. <https://doi.org/10.4324/9781410611932>
- McGrath, J. (1991). Time, interaction, and performance (TIP): A theory of groups. *Small-Group Research*, 22(2), 147–174. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1046496491222001>
- Morgan, B. B., Salas, E., & Glickman A. (1993). An analysis of team evolution and maturation. *The Journal of General Psychology*, 120(3), 277–291. <https://doi.org/10.1080/00221309.1993.9711148>
- Northouse, P. G. (2019). *Leadership: Theory and practice* (8th ed). Sage.
- Parker, G. M. (1990). *Team players and teamwork*. Jossey-Bass.
- Poole, M. S. (1981). Decision development in small groups I: A comparison of two models. *Communications Monographs*, 48(1), 1–24. <https://doi.org/10.1080/03637758109376044>
- Poole, M. S. (1983). Decision development in small groups II: A study of multiple sequences in decision making. *Communication Monographs*, 50(3), 206–232. <https://doi.org/10.1080/03637758309390165>
- Schrage, M. (1990). *Shared minds: The new technologies of collaboration*. Random House.
- Tuckman, B. W. (1965). Developmental sequence in small groups. *Psychological Bulletin*, 63(6), 384–399. <https://doi.org/10.1037/h0022100>
- Tuckman, B. W., & Jensen, M. A. C. (1977). Stages of small-group development revisited. *Groups and Organization Management*, 2(4), 419–427. <https://doi.org/10.1177/105960117700200404>
- Weingart, L. R. (2012). Studying dynamics within groups. In M. A. Neale & E. A. Mannix (Eds.), *Looking back, moving forward: A review of group and team-based research* (pp. 1–25), Emerald Group Publishing Limited. [https://doi.org/10.1108/S1534-0856\(2012\)0000015004](https://doi.org/10.1108/S1534-0856(2012)0000015004)
- West, M. A. (2004). *Effective teamwork: Practical lessons from organizational research*. Wiley-Blackwell.
- Wheelan, S. A. (2009). Group size, group development, and group productivity. *Small-Group Research*, 40(2), 247–262. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1046496408328703>
- Yost, C. A., & Tucker, M. L. (2000). Are effective teams more emotionally intelligent? Confirming the importance of effective communication in teams. *Delta Pi Epsilon Journal*, 42(2), 101.

9: Meeting the Challenge of Effective Groups and Teams Membership is shared under a CC BY-NC license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by LibreTexts.

10: Engaging with Empathy

Helen Abdali Soosan Fagan, Hannah M. Sunderman, & Colette M. Yellow Robe

“I’ve learned that people will forget what you said, people will forget what you did, but people will never forget how you made them feel.” —Maya Angelou

INTRODUCTION

Empathy plays a critical role in interpersonal communication by helping to bring us together, a task that is particularly important as we face interpersonal as well as global crises. These challenges offer no easy solutions and require us to connect with and understand each other. **Empathy**, defined as sensing and imagining the feelings of others, is at the core of connection. While empathy is a powerful aspect of relationships, it can be challenging to engage with well. Therefore, the purpose of this chapter is to engage you, the reader, in the process of understanding, developing, and applying empathy.

Chapter Objectives

By the end of this chapter, you will be able to...

- define empathy.
- describe the difference between empathy and sympathy.
- identify and apply the three types of empathy.
- describe the benefits and potential pitfalls of empathy.
- identify ways to increase empathy.

KEYWORDS: Empathy, perspective-taking, compassion, understanding, cognitive empathy, affective empathy

This chapter starts by defining empathy and distinguishing empathy from sympathy. Then, we discuss the three types of empathy: cognitive empathy, emotional empathy, and empathic concern. After talking through various definitions of empathy, we share the positive effects of empathy and the potential challenges of empathy. Finally, the chapter ends with a discussion on the four attributes of empathy and how empathy can be developed.

Defining Empathy

Empathy is the uniquely human ability to focus on another person’s internal state. While the word “empathy” can be used to describe a wide array of experiences, empathy in the context of interpersonal relationships is often defined as “the ability to sense other people’s emotions, coupled with the ability to imagine what someone else might be thinking or feeling” (“Empathy Defined,” n.d., para. 1).

To further understand empathy, it is helpful to distinguish it from sympathy. While sympathy involves understanding from our own perspective, empathy involves taking the perspective of the other person, sharing their emotion, and exhibiting concern. Sympathy involves feeling *for* someone else. Empathy pushes us to feel *with* someone else. Sympathy is surface-level connection, while empathy is deeper and more intense. In sum, “empathy fuels connection, sympathy drives disconnection” (Brown, 2013, 0:15). When faced with someone else’s pain, sympathy maintains distance from the other person’s emotions by, for example, finding the bright side of a situation or changing the subject. Sympathy might motivate us to express sorrow or send a card, actions that are often appreciated (Bariso, 2018). Empathy, however, takes more time and effort by moving us to connect with the other person’s emotions, drawing from feelings we have previously felt. Given that empathy can recall uncomfortable and difficult feelings, empathy can be a difficult and vulnerable choice.

Consider this example: You had a misunderstanding with a roommate and left your dorm room. Later you are sitting in a corner booth in the union. You overhear a person who sounds like your roommate talking to someone about how terrible they felt about the disagreement with their roommate (i.e., you) and how they wish they would have taken time after hearing the news of a sick family member to go for a walk. Your roommate shares that a walk would have allowed them to clear their head and avoid projecting their sadness over the sickness of a family member onto their roommate (i.e., you). When you hear this, you recall a similar feeling from your own life in which your grandma was sick, and it was difficult for you to talk about. Connecting a previously experienced emotion to your roommate’s current feelings allows you to gain a level of understanding and connection with your roommate, enabling you to understand their perspective (and reaction) and share in the emotional burden. In response to

understanding your roommate's emotions, you decide to act and check in with them, eventually leading you to volunteer to help them study, run errands, or think through contacting their professors.

The example above illustrates three different types of empathy (Goleman et al., 2017). First, cognitive empathy is understanding someone else's perspective. Cognitive empathy can also be referred to as perspective-taking (Goleman, 2008), which can help in motivating people. However, cognitive empathy without the other types of empathy can be used to hurt people by understanding other people's emotions and using them to wound or manipulate; therefore, we also need emotional empathy, the second type of empathy. Emotional empathy is feeling what another person feels. In other words, emotional empathy can spread emotions as if they were contagious. The potential downside of emotional empathy is that we may feel other people's emotions so strongly that it could hinder our ability to be of help (Goleman, 2008). This leads us to the third type of empathy, empathic concern, which is defined as sensing what someone else needs from you. Empathic concern, also referred to as compassionate empathy, is what motivates us to act and help.

Discovering the Effects of Empathy

Researchers in a variety of fields have identified numerous benefits of empathy. In healthcare, empathy by care providers (e.g., doctors and nurses) has been shown to increase patient satisfaction following a course of treatment and reduce stress (Riess, 2015). Additionally, providers themselves benefit from empathy because it enhances job satisfaction, belief that their work is meaningful, and overall well-being (Riess, 2015). In the customer service industry, empathy reduces conflict and enhances customer satisfaction (Clark et al., 2013). Further, empathetic workplaces typically have stronger collaboration, less stress, and greater morale (Zaki, 2020). Additionally, employees bounce back from challenging circumstances faster.

While the benefits of empathy are significant, scholars have argued that too much empathy can be harmful. Paul Bloom (2016), a psychology professor at Yale University, has discussed the potential downsides of empathy. Specifically, Bloom (2016) argued that too much empathy for a person or group might result in an inability to be rational. The lack of rationality could lead to us being too closely aligned with the person or group for whom we have empathy and result in a bias towards outsiders. For example, if one of our friends gets into a fight with another friend, we may empathize with one friend's perspective, making it difficult for us to see another perspective.

Rather than empathy, Bloom (2016) argues for rational compassion. Rational compassion encourages people to utilize rational thinking (e.g., cost-benefit analysis) to decide what is the right thing to do and then to utilize compassion to motivate yourself to follow through on doing the right thing. An additional limitation of empathy is that we can become so consumed in what other people are feeling and experiencing that we are emotionally overwhelmed, an experience to which people in caregiving professions can be particularly susceptible. What do these potential pitfalls of empathy teach us? Empathy is necessary for interpersonal relationships, allowing us to understand the feelings and experiences of others; however, empathy is not a cure-all solution for the cultural challenges we face. By understanding the potential limitations of empathy, as well as the numerous strengths of empathy, we can more effectively utilize it to build relationships and foster understanding.

Developing Empathy

As we start to consider how empathy can be developed, let's look at the four defining attributes of empathy (Wiseman, 1996). First, empathy allows us to see the world as others see it. While we will never be able to put ourselves fully into the shoes of another perspective, we can work to take on their perspectives. Second, empathy is non-judgmental. If we are going to connect empathetically with others, we must leave judgment at the door. As we give up judgment of others, we are also able to give up judgment of ourselves. Third, empathy allows us to understand another person's current emotions. Fourth, empathy should also result in us communicating our understanding of the person's feelings. Naming emotions helps us make sure that we understand the other person correctly. At times, communicating other people's feelings means that we might get the emotion wrong. When this happens, it gives the other person the opportunity to share what they are truly feeling.

Specific practices that can help us move through Wiseman's (1996) attributes of empathy include the following:

- Active listening: paying close attention to what the other person is saying and focusing on understanding their experiences
- Practice mindfulness: be aware of what is going on around you, including the behaviors and expressions of people. Practicing mindfulness has been shown to help us with perspective-taking while also preventing us from becoming overwhelmed by others' negative emotions (Birnie et al., 2010)
- Demonstrate empathetic body language: empathy extends beyond what we say to our facial expressions, eye contact, and posture

- Meditate: neuroscience research shows that meditation, specifically meditation focused on concern for others, can increase empathy (Lutz et al., 2008)

Summary

As we honor the experiences of ourselves and others, empathy is a critical component to understanding experiences and fostering connection. Empathy allows us to connect with ourselves and our emotions, thereby contributing to the consciousness of self-value within the Social Change Model (SCM) of Leadership (Higher Education Research Institute, 1996). Further, empathy significantly contributes to the three group values in the SCM: collaboration, common purpose, and controversy with civility. Notably, the working ensemble of the Higher Education Research Institute, the scholars behind SCM, identify empathy as one of the values underlying effective group functioning. Specifically, they write,

Keeping an open mind and cultivating the ability to be empathic are vital to building collaborative relationships. Without openness and empathy, individuals can become too easily focused on their own ideas and perspectives. Letting themselves ‘walk in other people’s shoes’ creates further opportunities for enhancing self-knowledge. (Higher Education Research Institute, 1996, p. 50)

In sum, empathy connects us with our own emotions, as well as the feelings and experiences of others, and promotes a positive and productive group and work environment.

QUESTIONS FOR JOURNALING OR DISCUSSION

- Reflect on the four attributes of empathy as defined and articulated by Wiseman (1996). Which of these four attributes is the most important to you and why? When has someone shown you this attribute of empathy? How have you extended this attribute of empathy to someone else? What are additional opportunities in the future where you might extend this attribute of empathy?
- Consider what it is like when you feel that someone really understands you. What do they do? How do you know they understand you? Ask a handful of friends and/or classmates the same questions, and then compare their responses to your own. Do they experience empathy in the same ways as you? What is similar? What is different? How might what you observed influence how you engage empathetically with others?
- We often talk about empathy within the context of something difficult happening to ourselves or to a friend; however, empathy also occurs during moments of joy, excitement, jealousy, frustration, etc. How might empathy look different depending on the emotion the other person is experiencing? Which situations or emotions are the most challenging for you to engage with empathetically?
- Look through the list of practices for increasing empathy above. Which of these strategies would you be interested in trying? Implement this practice for four days and monitor how it impacts your conversations and relationships, as well as yourself.

ACTIVITIES

“Walk With Me” Case Study

Empathy is a core value in leadership that provides us with opportunities to make connections. As we engage in social change, an awareness of how those around us perceive a situation is critical. The following activity is designed to frame empathy in leadership from a Social Change Model perspective.

Walk With Me – I Do Not Need You to Feel Sorry for Me

There is an opportunity for students to assist a local coalition of non-profit centers that serves people who are experiencing homelessness. While there tends to be a large outpouring of support during the winter months, there is a significant need for supplies during the summer months as well. Let’s look at this from the story of one person in particular, Bruno. Bruno is a single man who experienced a series of setbacks in life, along with a handful of tough choices. The events took Bruno down a slow spiral, and Bruno had little access to outside resources that may have helped. He came home to his apartment one day and found the eviction notice. Bruno had lost his home and shelter. While he has a place in a local park where he prefers to rest during the warm months, he struggles with insect bites. In a local shelter, Bruno became a vocal advocate for people who lack shelter. He repeatedly reminds staff about the need for bug spray. One day, the center director asks Bruno to share his story on video to explain the need. He hesitated to make the video and replied, “Just walk with me one day to see, experience, and feel the welts from all my bites. I don’t need you to feel sorry for me.” At that critical point, the director was humbled and reflected upon the original request. Bruno’s words never left her, and she continues to utilize them when giving presentations for donations and support: “Walk With Me.”

Activity: Break into small groups and identify the types of empathy in this story. Then, discuss ways in which your team might assist with this need (among others).

Questions to consider:

1. How do you determine the needs of people who are experiencing homelessness?
2. What feelings, thoughts, or emotions emerge as you imagine yourself helping people experiencing homelessness?
3. What judgments do we often make about people who are experiencing homelessness? How might this affect your decisions as a leader?
4. Your “job” is to walk by the side of the people experiencing homelessness. How will you support their needs and resist any urge to “fix them” or, as Bruno stated, “not feel sorry for anyone”?
5. How does what we discussed about empathy throughout this chapter apply to the case study? If you were the director of the center, what would you be able to learn from the chapter?
 1. What might be a sympathetic response for the director? What would be an empathetic response?

Active Listening Activity

- Split up students into groups of 2-3
- Rotate turns as sharer, listener, and observer
- The sharer will spend three minutes sharing about something significant to them this semester (something especially difficult, encouraging, etc.). The listener will focus on demonstrating active and empathetic listening. The observer will take notes on empathetic listening behaviors and non-empathetic listening behaviors.
- Debrief key takeaways (e.g., which role was the most difficult for you? Which role was the easiest? Why?)

Empathy and Service-Learning

- If your class is engaging in a service-learning project, discuss how your service-learning project has impacted your capacity for empathy. If your class is not engaging in service-learning, discuss the below questions in light of other interactions with family, friends, community members, classmates, younger students, etc.
- When have you observed the emotional experience of others at your service-learning site?
- How did you respond to observing others’ emotional experiences?
- When do you show empathy? When did you show sympathy? If you were placed in this situation again, how would you respond differently?

REFERENCES

- Bariso, J. (2018). There are actually 3 types of empathy: Here’s how they differ and how you can develop them all. *Inc.* <https://www.inc.com/justin-bariso/there-are-actually-3-types-of-empathy-heres-how-they-differ-and-how-you-can-develop-them-all.html>
- Birnie, K., Speca, M., & Carlson, L. E. (2010). Exploring self-compassion and empathy in the context of mindfulness-based stress reduction (MBSR). *Stress and Health*, 26(5), 359–371. <https://doi.org/10.1002/smi.1305>
- Bloom, P. (2016). *Against empathy: The case for rational compassion*. Harper Collins Publishing.
- Brown, B. (2013, December 10). *Brené Brown on empathy* [Video]. YouTube. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=1Evwgu369Jw%27>
- Clark, C. M., Murfett, U. M., Rogers, P. S., & Ang, S. (2013). Is empathy effective for customer service? Evidence from call center interactions. *Journal of Business and Technical Communication*, 27(2), 123–153. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1050651912468887>
- Empathy defined. (n.d.). *Greater Good Magazine*. <https://greatergood.berkeley.edu/topic/empathy/definition>
- Goleman, D. (2008, March 1). Hot to help: When can empathy move us to action? *Greater Good Magazine*. https://greatergood.berkeley.edu/article/item/hot_to_help
- Goleman, D., McKee, A., & Waytz, A. (2017). *Empathy (HBR Emotional Intelligence Series)*. Harvard Business Press.
- Higher Education Research Institute. (1996). *A Social Change Model of Leadership Development* (Version III). UCLA. <https://www.heri.ucla.edu/PDFs/pubs/ASocialChangeModelofLeadershipDevelopment.pdf>

- Lutz, A., Brefczynski-Lewis, J., Johnstone, T., & Davidson, R. J. (2008). Regulation of the neural circuitry of emotion by compassion meditation: Effects of meditative expertise. *PLoS ONE*, 3(3), e1897. <https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pone.0001897>
- Riess, H. (2015). The impact of clinical empathy on patients and clinicians: Understanding empathy's side effects. *AJOB Neuroscience*, 6(3), 51–53. <https://doi.org/10.1080/21507740.2015.1052591>
- Wiseman, T. (1996). A concept analysis of empathy. *Journal of Advanced Nursing*, 23(6), 1162–1167. <https://doi.org/10.1046/j.1365-2648.1996.12213.x>
- Zaki, J. (2020). *The war for kindness: Building empathy in a fractured world*. Penguin Random House Publishing.

10: Engaging with Empathy is shared under a CC BY-NC license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by LibreTexts.

Detailed Licensing

Pages in this book can be re-mixes of open content from other books in the LibreTexts Library. Sometimes sections from several sources are used on the same page and there may be no unique open license. Where there is a conflict, the licensing may appear as *undeclared*. On any page, by toggling AutoAttribution on the Tools menu, you can display the detailed attribution on a paragraph level. Material from different books will be color coded and the source displayed by mousing over the paragraph.

Content in the Front and Back Matter, directories and similar can be uncopywriteable, being simple listings and these are also shown as *undeclared*.

Overview

Title: [COLL 110- Introduction to Personal Leadership](#)

Webpages: 25

Applicable Restrictions: Noncommercial

All licenses found:

- [CC BY-NC 4.0](#): 40% (10 pages)
- [CC BY 4.0](#): 28% (7 pages)
- [Undeclared](#): 24% (6 pages)
- [Unknown License](#): 4% (1 page)
- [Public Domain](#): 4% (1 page)

By Page

- [COLL 110- Introduction to Personal Leadership](#) - *Unknown License*
 - [Front Matter](#) - *CC BY 4.0*
 - [TitlePage](#) - *CC BY 4.0*
 - [InfoPage](#) - *Public Domain*
 - [Table of Contents](#) - *Undeclared*
 - [Licensing](#) - *Undeclared*
 - [1: Foundations of Personal Leadership for Community College Students](#) - *CC BY 4.0*
 - [1.1: Leadership Begins with YOU](#) - *CC BY 4.0*
 - [1.2: The Reality of Leadership](#) - *CC BY 4.0*
 - [1.3: Goal Setting & Decision-Making](#) - *CC BY 4.0*
 - [1.4: Relating with Others](#) - *CC BY 4.0*
 - [2: How I See Myself](#) - *CC BY-NC 4.0*
 - [3: Defining My Personal Values](#) - *CC BY-NC 4.0*
 - [4: Defining My Vision, Setting Personal Goals, and Making Decisions](#) - *CC BY-NC 4.0*
 - [5: Nonverbal Communication and Active Listening in Small Groups](#) - *CC BY-NC 4.0*
 - [6: Developing Trust and Being Trustworthy](#) - *CC BY-NC 4.0*
 - [7: Perceptions are Only From My Point of View](#) - *CC BY-NC 4.0*
 - [7.1: Diversity and Inclusion](#) - *CC BY-NC 4.0*
 - [8: Diversity and Inclusion](#) - *CC BY-NC 4.0*
 - [9: Meeting the Challenge of Effective Groups and Teams Membership](#) - *CC BY-NC 4.0*
 - [10: Engaging with Empathy](#) - *CC BY-NC 4.0*
 - [Back Matter](#) - *Undeclared*
 - [Index](#) - *Undeclared*
 - [Glossary](#) - *Undeclared*
 - [Detailed Licensing](#) - *Undeclared*